

Question ID: 85b8b9c5

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Many mechanical calculators were powered by a notched cylinder mechanism called the Leibniz wheel. Leibniz wheel calculators were popular in the first half of the twentieth _____ these ingenious devices were eventually replaced by electronic calculators.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. century
- B. century,
- C. century, but
- D. century that

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma and a coordinating conjunction ("but") to join the first main clause ("Leibniz...century") and the second main clause ("these ingenious...calculators").

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can't be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice D is incorrect because joining the two main clauses in this way with the subordinating conjunction "that" results in an ungrammatical and illogical sentence.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Santa Clara Pueblo artist Roxanne Swentzell’s sculpture *Mud Woman Rolls On* consists of five human figures made of clay and plant fiber and arranged in descending size; each figure holds the smaller one in front of it. The arrangement of the figures, according to _____ represents her idea that “we all come from the Earth, generation after generation.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Swentzell
- B. Swentzell,
- C. Swentzell:
- D. Swentzell—

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The phrase “according to Swentzell” is an aside that interrupts the flow of the sentence, so it needs to be separated from the sentence with a pair of matching punctuation marks: two commas, two dashes, or a pair of parentheses. We already have a comma before “according,” so we must add a comma after “Swentzell.” .

Choice A is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error. The phrase “according to Swentzell” is an aside that interrupts the flow of the sentence, so it needs to be separated from the sentence with a pair of matching punctuation marks: one before and one after the phrase. Choice C is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error. “The arrangement of the figures, according to Swentzell” is not an independent clause, so it can’t come before a colon. Choice D is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error. The phrase “according to Swentzell” is an aside that interrupts the flow of the sentence, so it needs to be separated from the sentence with a pair of matching punctuation marks. We already have a comma at the beginning, so we have to use another comma here to match. We can’t just switch to a dash! .

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Nine months before Rosa Parks made history by refusing to comply with the segregated seating policy on a Montgomery, Alabama, bus, a fifteen-year-old Montgomery girl named Claudette Colvin was arrested for the same _____ to some historians, Colvin’s arrest led to Parks’s action and eventually to the desegregation of Montgomery’s bus system.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. offense. According
- B. offense, according
- C. offense according
- D. offense and according

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. “Nine months...offense” and “according to...system” are both independent clauses. Separating them with a period and turning them into their own sentences is the only grammatically correct choice among the provided options.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice results in a comma splice error, which is a punctuation error that occurs when two independent clauses are joined by only a comma. “Nine months...offense” and “according to...system” are both independent clauses, so they need to be either joined by a semicolon, joined by a comma and a coordinating conjunction, or separated by a period. Choice C is incorrect. This choice results in a run-on sentence, which occurs when two independent clauses are joined without punctuation. “Nine months...offense” and “according to...system” are both independent clauses, so they need to be either joined by a semicolon, joined by a comma and a coordinating conjunction, or separated by a period. Choice D is incorrect. This choice results in a run-on sentence, which occurs when two independent clauses are joined without punctuation. “Nine months...offense” and “according to...system” are independent clauses, so we would need to put a comma before the coordinating conjunction “and” to join them properly.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

The first computerized spreadsheet, Dan Bricklin’s *VisiCalc*, improved financial recordkeeping not only by providing users with an easy means of adjusting data in spreadsheets but also by automatically updating all calculations that were dependent on these _____ to VisiCalc’s release, changing a paper spreadsheet often required redoing the entire sheet by hand, a process that could take days.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. adjustments prior
- B. adjustments, prior
- C. adjustments. Prior
- D. adjustments and prior

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between the first sentence (“The...adjustments”) and the second sentence (“Prior...days”). Because the adverbial phrase beginning with “prior” indicates when changing a spreadsheet required redoing the sheet by hand, that phrase belongs with the second sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. Two sentences are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice D is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction “and” can’t be used in this way to join the sentences.

Question ID: 548f4956

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

It is generally true that technological change is a linear process, in which once-useful technologies are replaced by new and better ____ the reawakening of interest in the steam engine (from advocates of carbon-neutral rail travel) reminds us that ostensibly obsolete technologies may be brought back into service to address society’s changing needs.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. ones, even so;
- B. ones even so,
- C. ones; even so,
- D. ones, even so,

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses within a sentence. This choice uses a semicolon in a conventional way to join the first main clause (“It is...ones”) and the second main clause (“even so...needs”). Furthermore, the placement of the semicolon after “ones” indicates that the supplementary phrase “even so” modifies the following clause (“the reawakening...needs”), resulting in the most logical and grammatically complete sentence. With this punctuation, the sentence logically indicates that the recent interest in an old technology like steam engines is despite the fact that technological change typically seeks out new technologies.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a confusing and illogical sentence. Placing the semicolon after “so” indicates that the supplementary element “even so” modifies the first clause of the sentence, which doesn’t make sense in this context. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. It fails to mark the boundary between the two main clauses with appropriate punctuation. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join the two main clauses of the sentence.

Question ID: 9d4a701b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Along with carbon dioxide concentration and temperature, light intensity affects the chemical reaction rate of _____ as light intensity increases, so does the rate at which the reactants (water and carbon dioxide) are converted into their products (glucose and oxygen).

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. photosynthesis and
- B. photosynthesis,
- C. photosynthesis:
- D. photosynthesis

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation in a sentence. In this choice, a colon is correctly used to mark the boundary between one main clause ("Along with...photosynthesis") and another main clause ("as light...oxygen") and to introduce the following explanation of how light intensity affects photosynthesis.

Choice A is incorrect because when coordinating two longer main clauses such as these, it's conventional to use a comma before the coordinating conjunction ("and"). Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a coordinating conjunction following it, a comma can't be used in this way to join two main clauses ("Along with...photosynthesis" and "as light...oxygen"). Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses ("Along with...photosynthesis" and "as light...oxygen") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question ID: 2c84f96a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

In 2017, artists Isabel and Ruben Toledo redesigned the costumes and sets for The Miami City Ballet’s production of *The _____* to reviewers, the Toledos’ designs helped infuse the production with elements of Miami’s Latin American culture.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. *Nutcracker* according,
- B. *Nutcracker*, according
- C. *Nutcracker* according
- D. *Nutcracker*. According

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence (“In 2017...*Nutcracker*”) and another (“According...culture”). The supplementary element “according to reviewers” modifies the main clause of the second sentence (“the Toledos’...culture”).

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Furthermore, no punctuation is needed within the supplementary element “according to reviewers.” Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Fernando Palma Rodríguez creates robotic sculptures that combine mechanical elements with materials like feathers, soil, and seeds. The artist is from a rural farming community outside Mexico City, and he studied engineering in college. The natural and mechanical _____ highlight these two aspects of his background.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. materials that Palma Rodríguez uses in his art,
- B. materials that Palma Rodríguez uses in his art
- C. materials, that Palma Rodríguez uses in his art,
- D. materials, that Palma Rodríguez uses in his art

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of an integrated relative clause within a sentence. No punctuation is needed between the noun phrase (“The natural and mechanical materials”) and the integrated relative clause (“that Palma Rodríguez uses in his art”). The integrated relative clause provides essential information about the materials, so no punctuation should separate it from the noun phrase it modifies. Additionally, no punctuation is needed between the sentence’s subject (“The natural and mechanical materials that Palma Rodríguez uses in his art”) and its main verb (“highlight”).

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the sentence’s subject (“The natural...art”) and its main verb (“highlight”). Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the noun phrase (“The natural...materials”) and the integrated relative clause (“that...art”) that modifies it. Additionally, no punctuation is needed between the sentence’s subject (“The natural...art”) and its main verb (“highlight”). Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the noun phrase (“The natural...materials”) and the integrated relative clause (“that...art”) that modifies it.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

To illustrate Albert Einstein's special theory of relativity, picture two jugglers: one juggling on a steadily moving parade float, the other juggling while standing still on a sidewalk. The laws of physics are identical for both _____ motion relative to each other. But what, Einstein wondered, about the speed of light?

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. jugglers', regardless of they're
- B. jugglers, regardless of there
- C. juggler's, regardless of their
- D. jugglers, regardless of their

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of plural nouns and possessive determiners. The plural noun "jugglers" and the plural possessive determiner "their" correctly indicate that there are multiple jugglers whose motion is being discussed.

Choice A is incorrect because the context requires the plural noun "jugglers" and the plural possessive determiner "their," not the plural possessive noun "jugglers'" and the contraction "they're." Choice B is incorrect because the context requires the plural possessive determiner "their," not the word "there," which means "in that place." Choice C is incorrect because the context requires the plural noun "jugglers," not the singular possessive noun "juggler's."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

African American Percy Julian was a scientist and entrepreneur whose work helped people around the world to see. Named in 1999 as one of the greatest achievements by a US chemist in the past hundred years, _____ led to the first mass-produced treatment for glaucoma.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Julian synthesized the alkaloid physostigmine in 1935; it
- B. in 1935 Julian synthesized the alkaloid physostigmine, which
- C. Julian's 1935 synthesis of the alkaloid physostigmine
- D. the alkaloid physostigmine was synthesized by Julian in 1935 and

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase “Julian’s 1935 synthesis” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase “named...years.” In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that Julian’s 1935 synthesis of the alkaloid physostigmine—and not another noun in the sentence—was named in 1999 as one of the greatest achievements by a US chemist in the past hundred years.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun “Julian” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that Julian himself was named as one of the greatest achievements by a US chemist in the past hundred years. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the prepositional phrase “in 1935” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically and confusingly suggests that “in 1935” was named as one of the greatest achievements by a US chemist in the past hundred years. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “the alkaloid physostigmine” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically and confusingly suggests that the alkaloid physostigmine itself (not the synthesis of it) was named as one of the greatest achievements by a US chemist in the past hundred years.

Question ID: 4ba99a6f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Seneca sculptor Marie Watt’s blanket art comes in a range of shapes and sizes. In 2004, Watt sewed strips of blankets together to craft a 10-by-13-inch _____ in 2014, she arranged folded blankets into two large stacks and then cast them in bronze, creating two curving 18-foot-tall blue-bronze pillars.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. sampler later,
- B. sampler;
- C. sampler,
- D. sampler, later,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses within a sentence. This choice uses a semicolon in a conventional way to join the first main clause (“In 2004...sampler”) and the second main clause (“in 2014...pillars”).

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. The word “later” is an adverb and cannot be used to join two main clauses unless it is preceded by a conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. The word “later” is an adverb and cannot be used to join two main clauses unless it is preceded by a conjunction.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

The life spans of rockfish vary greatly by species. For instance, the colorful calico rockfish (*Sebastes dallii*) can survive for a little over a _____ the roughey rockfish (*Sebastes aleutianus*) boasts a maximum life span of about two centuries.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. decade: while
- B. decade. While
- C. decade; while
- D. decade, while

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between a main clause and a subordinate clause. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the main clause ("the colorful...decade") and the subordinate clause ("while...centuries") that provides contrasting information about the life span of roughey rockfish.

Choice A is incorrect because a colon can't be used in this way to join a main clause and a subordinate clause. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with "while." Choice C is incorrect because a semicolon can't be used in this way to join a main clause and a subordinate clause.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

The Arctic-Alpine Botanic Garden in Norway and the Jardim Botânico of Rio de Janeiro in Brazil are two of many botanical gardens around the world dedicated to growing diverse plant _____ fostering scientific research; and educating the public about plant conservation.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. species, both native and nonnative,
- B. species, both native and nonnative;
- C. species; both native and nonnative,
- D. species both native and nonnative,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of items in a complex series (a series including internal punctuation). The semicolon after “nonnative” is correctly used to separate the first item (“growing diverse plant species, both native and nonnative”) and the second item (“fostering scientific research”) in the series of things that botanical gardens are dedicated to. Further, the comma after “species” is correctly used to separate the noun phrase “diverse plant species” and the supplementary phrase “both native and nonnative” that modifies it.

Choice A is incorrect because a comma (specifically, the comma after “nonnative”) can’t be used in this way to separate items in a complex series. Choice C is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to separate the noun phrase “diverse plant species” and the supplementary phrase “both native and nonnative” that modifies it. Further, a comma can’t be used in this way to separate items in a complex series. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the noun phrase “diverse plant species” and the supplementary phrase “both native and nonnative” that modifies it. Further, a comma can’t be used in this way to separate items in a complex series.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

The US Geological Survey wants to map every human-made structure in the United States, and it is asking volunteers to help. Cassie Tammy Wang and Ashish D’Souza are just two of the many volunteer map editors who _____ to the project since it began in 2012.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. contribute
- B. will contribute
- C. have contributed
- D. will be contributing

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verbs to express tense in a sentence. In this choice, the present perfect tense verb “have contributed,” used in conjunction with the phrase “since it began in 2012,” correctly indicates that map editors have contributed in the past and continue to do so in the present.

Choice A is incorrect because the present tense verb “contribute” is inconsistent with the phrase “since it began in 2012,” which suggests that the contributions occurred in the past and continue into the present. Choice B is incorrect because the future tense verb “will contribute” is inconsistent with the phrase “since it began in 2012,” which suggests that the contributions occurred in the past and continue into the present. Choice D is incorrect because the future tense verb “will be contributing” is inconsistent with the phrase “since it began in 2012,” which suggests that the contributions occurred in the past and continue into the present.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

In 1955, Indian Bengali filmmaker Satyajit Ray released his first movie, *Pather* _____ quiet black-and-white drama about a family in rural India, Ray’s film was quite different from the loud, colorful action-romance movies that were popular at the time.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. *Panchali* a
- B. *Panchali*, which was a
- C. *Panchali*, a
- D. *Panchali*. A

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence ("In...*Panchali*") and another ("A quiet...time"). The phrase beginning with "a quiet" modifies the subject of the next sentence, "Ray’s film."

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Félix González-Torres debuted his sculpture *“Untitled”* (*USA Today*) in New York City in 1990. The work consists of piled candy, a material González-Torres became known for. _____ created additional installations using a variety of sweets, like bubblegum, lollipops, and chocolates.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. They all
- B. Those
- C. Both
- D. He

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is pronoun-antecedent agreement. The singular pronoun "he" agrees in number with the singular antecedent "Félix González-Torres," and it clearly indicates that González-Torres created the additional installations.

Choice A is incorrect because the plural noun phrase "they all" doesn't agree in number with the singular antecedent "Félix González-Torres," and it doesn't clearly indicate that he (González-Torres) created the additional installations. Choice B is incorrect because the plural pronoun "those" doesn't agree in number with the singular antecedent "Félix González-Torres," and it doesn't clearly indicate that he (González-Torres) created the additional installations. Choice C is incorrect because the plural pronoun "both" doesn't agree in number with the singular antecedent "Félix González-Torres," and it doesn't clearly indicate that he (González-Torres) created the additional installations.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

By analyzing the level of radioactive decay within a fossil specimen, scientists can establish the age of that fossil with a high degree of precision. When radioactive elements aren't present, scientists turn to _____ analysis of Earth's sediment layers (strata)—to estimate how old a fossil is based on the age of the strata in which the fossil is found.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. stratigraphy—the
- B. stratigraphy (the
- C. stratigraphy: the
- D. stratigraphy, the

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. The dash after "stratigraphy" pairs with the dash after "(strata)" to separate the supplementary element "the analysis of Earth's sediment layers (strata)" from the rest of the sentence. This supplementary element functions to define the term "stratigraphy," and the pair of dashes indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice B is incorrect because a parenthesis can't be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because a colon can't be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because a comma can't be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

A study showed that a solar park caused nearby land to cool, though the ecological impact of this temperature decrease isn't yet known. Before the park's construction, the surface temperature 30 meters outside of the park boundary was 0.1°C cooler than that of a control ____ construction, the temperature 30 meters outside of the boundary was 1.7°C cooler than that of the control area.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. area after
- B. area after,
- C. area. After
- D. area, after

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used to correctly mark the boundary between one sentence ("Before...area") and another ("After...area"). The phrase "After construction" modifies the next sentence to indicate that the temperature was cooler after construction.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence that fuses the two sentences ("Before...area" and "after...area") without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence that connects the two sentences ("Before...area" and "after...area") without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Additionally, no punctuation is needed between "after" and "construction." Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between the two sentences ("Before...area" and "after...area").

Question ID: 684b8bd2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

Far from being modern inventions, _____ more than 5,000 years ago.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Sumerians in ancient Mesopotamia used drinking straws
- B. drinking straws were used by Sumerians in ancient Mesopotamia
- C. the use of drinking straws by Sumerians in ancient Mesopotamia happened
- D. ancient Mesopotamia was home to Sumerians who used drinking straws

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. Modifiers and their subjects must go next to each other. The modifier “far from being modern inventions” must be describing “drinking straws,” because those are the only possible inventions in this sentence.

Choice A is incorrect. Modifiers and their subjects must go next to each other. The modifier “far from being modern inventions” can’t be describing “Sumerians,” because they are a group of people, not an invention. Choice C is incorrect. Modifiers and their subjects must go next to each other. The modifier “far from being modern inventions” can’t be describing “the use of drinking straws,” because it is not “the use” of drinking straws that is an invention—it is the drinking straws themselves. Choice D is incorrect. Modifiers and their subjects must go next to each other. The modifier “far from being modern inventions” can’t be describing “Ancient Mesopotamia,” because that is a place, not an invention.

Question ID: f30a478e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

A study published by Rice University geoscientist Ming Tang in 2019 offers a new explanation for the origin of Earth’s _____ structures called arcs, towering ridges that form when a dense oceanic plate subducts under a less dense continental plate, melts in the mantle below, and then rises and bursts through the continental crust above.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. continents geological
- B. continents: geological
- C. continents; geological
- D. continents. Geological

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a main clause and a supplementary phrase. In this choice, a colon is correctly used to mark the boundary between the main clause (“A study...continents”) and the supplementary phrase (“geological...above”) and to introduce the following explanation of the origin of Earth’s continents.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the main clause (“A study...continents”) and the supplementary phrase (“geological...above”) with appropriate punctuation. Choice C is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the main clause (“A study...continents”) and the supplementary phrase (“geological...above”). A semicolon is conventionally used to join two main clauses, whereas a colon is conventionally used to introduce an element that explains or amplifies the information in the preceding clause, making it the better choice in this context. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “geological.”

Question ID: 67667d72

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Humans were long thought to have begun occupying the Peruvian settlement of Machu Picchu between 1440 and 1450 CE. However, a team led by anthropologist Dr. Richard Burger used accelerator mass spectrometry to uncover evidence that it was occupied _____ 1420 CE, according to Burger, humans were likely inhabiting the area.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. earlier. In
- B. earlier, in
- C. earlier, which in
- D. earlier in

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence (“However...earlier”) and another (“In...area”). The supplementary phrase “in 1420 CE” modifies “humans,” the subject of the third sentence.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Moreover, the subordinating conjunction “which” creates a confusing and illogical sentence that suggests that the supplementary phrase beginning with “in” modifies the previous information (“However...earlier”) rather than the information that follows. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences (“However...earlier” and “in...area”) are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question ID: 80aa7690

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

The Austronesian language family includes Tagalog, Malagasy, and some 1,200 other languages throughout the Pacific, making it one of the largest language families in the world and of keen interest to _____ of the University of Toronto.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. linguist, Diane Massam,
- B. linguist, Diane Massam
- C. linguist Diane Massam
- D. linguist: Diane Massam

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation between titles and proper nouns. No punctuation is needed to set off the proper noun "Diane Massam" from the title that describes Massam, "linguist." Because "Diane Massam" is essential information identifying the "linguist," no punctuation is necessary.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed before or after the proper noun "Diane Massam." Setting the linguist’s name off with commas suggests that it could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn’t the case. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

How did whales, once no bigger than seals, evolve to become the largest animals on Earth? Brazilian biologist Mariana Nery believes the answer might be found in whales' DNA. In January 2023, Nery and her colleagues _____ a study showing changes over time in four whale genes associated with body size.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. published
- B. publishing
- C. having published
- D. to publish

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. A main clause requires a finite (tensed) verb to perform the action of the subject (in this case, Nery and her colleagues), and this choice supplies the finite past tense verb "published" to indicate that these biologists shared their findings about changes in whale genes associated with body size.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle "publishing" doesn't supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice C is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle "having published" doesn't supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite to-infinitive "to publish" doesn't supply the main clause with a finite verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

What makes the theremin a unique musical instrument? You play it without touching it. When you place your _____ the pitch will shift as your hands move through the air.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. hand’s between the two antenna’s,
- B. hands between the two antennas,
- C. hands’ between the two antennas’,
- D. hands’ between the two antennas,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of plural nouns in a sentence. The plural noun "hands" and the plural noun "antennas" correctly indicate that two hands are placed between two antennas when playing the theremin.

Choice A is incorrect because the context requires the plural nouns "hands" and "antennas," not the singular possessive nouns "hand’s" and "antenna’s." Choice C is incorrect because the context requires the plural nouns "hands" and "antennas," not the plural possessive nouns "hands'" and "antennas'." Choice D is incorrect because the context requires the plural noun "hands," not the plural possessive noun "hands'."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Many companies have simplified their products’ packaging designs in recent years, but _____ Researcher Lan Anh Nu Ton and her colleagues designed a research study to find out.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. consumers actually do prefer this simpler style.
- B. do consumers actually prefer this simpler style?
- C. do consumers actually prefer this simpler style.
- D. consumers actually do prefer this simpler style?

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is end-of-sentence punctuation. This choice correctly uses a question mark to punctuate the interrogative clause “do consumers actually prefer this simpler style,” which asks a direct question at the end of the sentence. This is the question that the researchers in the next sentence were trying to investigate.

Choice A is incorrect because the context requires an interrogative clause. The declarative clause “consumers actually do prefer this simpler style” incorrectly indicates the consumers’ preference was already known, whereas the researchers had yet to find this out. Choice C is incorrect because a period can’t be used in this way to punctuate an interrogative clause at the end of a sentence. Choice D is incorrect because a question mark can’t be used in this way to punctuate a declarative clause, such as “consumers actually do prefer this simpler style,” at the end of a sentence.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

Cheng Dang and her colleagues at the University of Washington recently ran simulations to determine the extent to which individual snow _____ affect the amount of light reflecting off a snowy surface.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. grain’s physical properties’
- B. grains’ physical properties
- C. grains’ physical property’s
- D. grains physical properties

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of plural and possessive nouns. The plural possessive noun “grains” and the plural noun “properties” correctly indicate that the simulations involved multiple snow grains and that those snow grains had several properties.

Choice A is incorrect because the context requires the plural possessive noun “grains” and the plural noun “properties,” not the singular possessive noun “grain’s” and the plural possessive noun “properties’.” Choice C is incorrect because the context requires the plural noun “properties,” not the singular possessive noun “property’s.” Choice D is incorrect because the context requires the plural possessive noun “grains’,” not the plural noun “grains.”

Question ID: a94b7fd6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

With residents from Mexico, China, El Salvador, and many other countries, Los Angeles has long been a city of cultural diversity. Even back in the 1860s, nearly 30% of the city’s population _____ from outside the United States.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. is being
- B. was
- C. is
- D. will be

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verbs to express tense in a sentence. In this choice, the past tense verb "was," used in conjunction with the prepositional phrase "from outside the United States," correctly indicates that in the 1860s nearly 30% of the population in Los Angeles wasn’t from the US.

Choice A is incorrect because the present progressive tense verb "is being" doesn’t indicate that the claim about Los Angeles’s population refers to the population back in the 1860s. Choice C is incorrect because the present tense verb "is" doesn’t indicate that the claim about Los Angeles’s population refers to the population back in the 1860s. Choice D is incorrect because the future tense verb "will be" doesn’t indicate that the claim about Los Angeles’s population refers to the population back in the 1860s.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

In a US national election, one might expect major-party campaigns to focus on the most populous states. However, if polls and past voting data suggest that the outcome in a given state is a foregone conclusion, a campaign will not invest its resources there. Ultimately, a state’s voting record and polling data, not its population size, _____ its importance to campaigns.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. determines
- B. determining
- C. has determined
- D. determine

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms in a sentence. The plural verb “determine” supplies the main clause with a finite main verb and agrees in number with the plural subject “a state’s voting record and polling data.”

Choice A is incorrect because the singular verb “determines” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “a state’s voting record and polling data.” Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle “determining” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite plural verb. Choice C is incorrect because the singular verb “has determined” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “a state’s voting record and polling data.”

Question ID: 6bc907c9

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Novelist Jane Austen greatly admired the work of Fanny Burney, a popular English author. In fact, scholars believe that a passage from the last chapter of *Cecilia*, a 1782 novel by Burney, likely inspired the title of one of _____ *Pride and Prejudice*.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Austen’s most famous novels,
- B. Austens’ most famous novels’,
- C. Austens most famous novels,
- D. Austen’s most famous novel’s,

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of plural and possessive nouns. The singular possessive proper noun "Austen’s" and the plural noun "novels" correctly indicates that Austen wrote multiple novels that were famous.

Choice B is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive proper noun "Austen’s" and the plural noun "novels," not the plural possessive nouns "Austens'" and "novels'." Choice C is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive proper noun "Austen’s," not the plural proper noun "Austens." Choice D is incorrect because the context requires the plural noun "novels," not the singular possessive noun "novel’s."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

The intense pressure found in the deep ocean can affect the structure of proteins in fish’s cells, distorting the proteins’ shape. The chemical trimethylamine N-oxide (TMAO) counters this effect, ensuring that proteins retain their original _____ is found in high concentrations in the cells of the deepest-dwelling fish.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. configurations. TMAO
- B. configurations TMAO
- C. configurations, TMAO
- D. configurations and TMAO

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period after “configurations” is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence (“The intense...configurations”) and another (“TMAO...fish”). The supplementary phrase (“ensuring...configurations”) modifies the main clause of the first sentence (“The chemical...effect”), and “TMAO” is the subject of the second sentence.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences (“The intense...configurations” and “TMAO...fish”) are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice D is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction “and” can’t be used in this way to join sentences.

Question ID: 1e274153

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

During World War II, codebreakers played an essential role in deciphering coded messages. In the US military, more than 10,000 women _____ as codebreakers, making up nearly half of all US codebreakers.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. having served
- B. to serve
- C. served
- D. serving

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. A main clause requires a finite (tensed) verb to perform the action of the subject (in this case, “more than 10,000 women”), and this choice supplies the finite past tense verb “served” to state what the women did.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle “having served” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite to-infinitive “to serve” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle “serving” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb.

Question ID: 36868920

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Increasing the heat on an uncovered boiling pot of water does not increase the temperature of the water. What increases is the rate at which the water turns to ____ a pressure cooker pot, though, an airtight seal traps the vapor in the pot, creating pressure that allows the temperature of the water to increase past its boiling point.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. vapor. With
- B. vapor with
- C. vapor, with
- D. vapor and with

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence ("What...vapor") and another ("With...point").

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences ("What...vapor" and "with...point") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice D is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction "and" can't be used in this way to join sentences.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Most of the ice found on Earth is ice Ih, distinguished by a crystalline structure in which molecules form a hexagonal pattern. Amorphous ice, on the other hand, constitutes most of the ice in the ultrafrigid environment of outer space. Defined by a disorganized molecular structure, _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. ice Ih contains crystals, whereas amorphous ice, which lacks the thermal energy to form them, does not.
- B. amorphous ice lacks the thermal energy to form the crystals found in ice Ih.
- C. the lack of thermal energy in amorphous ice explains its inability to form the crystals found in ice Ih.
- D. ice Ih differs from amorphous ice in that it possesses the thermal energy to form crystals.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase “amorphous ice” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase “defined...structure.” In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that amorphous ice—and not another noun in the sentence—is being described as having a disorganized molecular structure.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun “ice Ih” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that ice Ih has a disorganized molecular structure, whereas ice Ih is previously described as having molecules that form a hexagonal pattern. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “the lack of thermal energy” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the lack of thermal energy has a disorganized molecular structure. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of “ice Ih” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that ice Ih has a disorganized molecular structure, whereas ice Ih is previously described as having molecules that form a hexagonal pattern.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Multiple newspapers _____ the Spanish-speaking population of Washington, DC, including *El Tiempo Latino* and *Washington Hispanic*.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. serve
- B. having served
- C. to serve
- D. serving

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. A main clause requires a finite (tensed) verb to perform the action of the subject (in this case, "multiple newspapers"), and this choice supplies the finite present tense verb "serve" to indicate that there are multiple newspapers serving the Spanish-speaking population of Washington, DC.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle "having served" doesn't supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice C is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite to-infinitive "to serve" doesn't supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle "serving" doesn't supply the main clause with a finite verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

When particles are suspended in liquid (like pollen in a water glass), they will zigzag randomly through the liquid and collide with one another in perpetuity. This type of random, continuous _____ is known as Brownian motion, can be observed throughout the natural world.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. movement: which
- B. movement, which
- C. movement which
- D. movement. Which

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. This choice correctly uses commas to set off the nonessential relative clause "which is known as Brownian motion" that provides extra information about the "random, continuous movement" that isn't necessary for the function of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice results in a punctuation error. The relative clause "which is known as Brownian motion" is a nonessential supplement. Nonessential supplements need to be set apart from the rest of the sentence with a pair of commas, dashes, or parentheses, so we can't use a colon here. Also, notice that colons can only come after an independent clause, which isn't the case here. Choice C is incorrect. This choice results in a punctuation error. The relative clause "which is known as Brownian motion" is a nonessential supplement, so it should be separated from the rest of the sentence by a pair of matching punctuation marks. We already have a comma after "motion," so we need to add a comma before "which." This choice is missing that comma. Choice D is incorrect. This choice results in a sentence fragment. "This type of random, continuous movement" is not an independent clause and can't stand alone as a full sentence, so we can't put a period here.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Walt Whitman’s *Leaves of Grass* first appeared in 1855 as a slim collection of twelve poems, but Whitman would revise and expand it substantially over the next four decades. These extensive _____ the addition of hundreds of new poems, the removal of some existing ones, and the insertion of prefatory material, reflected the poet’s evolving literary perspective and experience of the US Civil War.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. changes, including
- B. changes would include
- C. changes included
- D. changes, include

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The nonfinite present participle "including" is correctly used to form a supplementary element that interrupts the main clause "These extensive changes...reflected the poet’s evolving literary perspective and experience of the US Civil War." This supplementary element, offset by commas after "changes" and "material," provides examples of the changes Whitman made to *Leaves of Grass*.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite modal verb "would include" can’t be used in this way to form a supplementary element within the main clause. Choice C is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite past tense verb "included" can’t be used in this way to form a supplementary element within the main clause. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite present tense verb "include" can’t be used in this way to form a supplementary element within the main clause.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

In his groundbreaking book *Bengali Harlem and the Lost Histories of South Asian America*, Vivek Bald uses newspaper articles, census records, ships’ logs, and memoirs to tell the _____ who made New York City their home in the early twentieth century.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. story’s of the South Asian immigrants
- B. story’s of the South Asian immigrants’
- C. stories of the South Asian immigrants
- D. stories’ of the South Asian immigrant’s

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of plural and possessive nouns. The plural nouns “stories” and “immigrants” correctly indicate that the memoir tells multiple stories of multiple immigrants.

Choice A is incorrect because the context requires the plural noun “stories,” not the singular possessive noun “story’s.” Choice B is incorrect because the context requires the plural nouns “stories” and “immigrants,” not the singular possessive noun “story’s” and the plural possessive noun “immigrants’.” Choice D is incorrect because the context requires the plural nouns “stories” and “immigrants,” not the plural possessive noun “stories’” and the singular possessive noun “immigrant’s.”

Question ID: 5670a657

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

During the decades-long movement to codify the rights of Latinos in the US, certain events were pivotal: the founding of social justice group the League of United Latin American Citizens in _____ *Katzenbach v. Morgan* court decision in 1966, which affirmed the rights of Latino voters, is another such event.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. 1929. For one, the
- B. 1929, for one, the
- C. 1929 for one, the
- D. 1929, for one. The

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The conventions being tested are punctuation use between sentences and the punctuation of a supplementary element. This choice correctly uses a period to mark the boundary between one sentence ("During...one") and another ("The *Katzenbach*...event") and uses a comma to separate the supplementary phrase "for one" from the preceding main clause. Further, placing the period after "for one" correctly indicates that the information in the preceding main clause ("the founding...1929") is the first example provided of a pivotal event in the Latino rights movement.

Choice A is incorrect because placing the period after "1929" illogically indicates that the information in the next main clause (describing the *Katzenbach v. Morgan* court decision) is the first example provided of a pivotal event in the Latino rights movement; rather, it's a second example. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to join two main clauses. Moreover, it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element "for one" from the preceding main clause.

Question ID: b6560e5a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Materials scientist Marie-Agathe Charpagne and her colleagues believed they could improve on the multicomponent alloy NiCoCr, an equal-proportions mixture of nickel (Ni), cobalt (Co), and chromium (Cr), by replacing chromium with ruthenium ____ the alloy that resulted, NiCoRu, turned out to be an unsuitable replacement for NiCoCr.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. (Ru)
- B. (Ru) but
- C. (Ru),
- D. (Ru), but

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses. This choice correctly uses a comma and the coordinating conjunction “but” to join the first main clause (“Materials...Ru”) and the second main clause (“the alloy...NiCoCr”).

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because when coordinating two longer main clauses such as these, it’s conventional to use a comma before the coordinating conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Chondrites are stony meteorites that are undifferentiated—that is, their contents have not melted and separated into distinct layers. They are hardly _____ many chondrites experience aqueous alteration as a result of exposure to fluids, as well as fracturing, veining, and localized melting due to collisions with other objects.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. pristine, though
- B. pristine, though;
- C. pristine; though
- D. pristine, though,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma to separate the supplementary adverb "though" from the preceding main clause ("They are hardly pristine") and uses a semicolon to join the two main clauses ("They...though" and "many...objects"). Further, placing the semicolon after "though" indicates that the information in the preceding main clause (chondrites are far from pristine) is contrary to what might be assumed from the information in the previous sentence (chondrites have been generally unaltered by their environment).

Choice A is incorrect because placing the comma after "pristine" and using "though" as a subordinating conjunction illogically indicates that the information in the next main clause (many chondrites have experienced damage) is contrary to the information in the previous clause (chondrites are far from pristine). Choice C is incorrect because placing the semicolon after "pristine" illogically indicates that the information in the next main clause (many chondrites have experienced damage) is contrary to the information in the previous clause (chondrites are far from pristine). Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, the comma after "though" can't be used in this way to join two main clauses.

Question ID: 5b8f9cf2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

In the canon of North African literature, Moroccan author Driss Chraïbi’s 1954 novel *The Simple Past* (*Le Passé simple*) looms large. A coming-of-age story, a social meditation, and a sober gaze into the dark maw of French colonialism, _____ interrogates systemic power with memorable intensity.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Morocco gained its independence two years before the publication of Chraïbi’s debut novel, which
- B. Chraïbi’s debut novel, published two years before Morocco gained its independence,
- C. Chraïbi wrote a debut novel that, published two years before Morocco gained its independence,
- D. published two years before Morocco gained its independence, Chraïbi wrote a debut novel that

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. Subject-modifier placement requires a modifier and its subject to be next to each other. The subject of the modifier "a coming-of-age story...colonialism" is Chraïbi’s novel *The Simple Past*, so the subject "Chraïbi’s debut novel" fits perfectly after this introductory modifying phrase.

Choice A is incorrect. Modifiers and their subjects must go next to each other. The introductory modifier "a coming-of-age story...colonialism" is describing Chraïbi’s novel, not Morocco. However, this choice places Morocco directly next to that modifier. Choice C is incorrect. Modifiers and their subjects must go next to each other. The introductory modifier "a coming-of-age story...colonialism" all describes Chraïbi’s novel, not Chraïbi himself. However, this choice places Chraïbi directly next to that modifier. Choice D is incorrect. Modifiers and their subjects must go next to each other. The modifier "a coming-of-age story..." is describing Chraïbi’s novel, so that needs to be the subject immediately after the modifier. This choice adds another modifier that describes Chraïbi’s novel, but then puts "Chraïbi" himself—not the novel—right after that modifier, which doesn’t make sense. Chraïbi wasn’t "published two years before" Moroccan independence; his novel *The Simple Past* was.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

When writing *The Other Black Girl* (2021), novelist Zakiya Dalila Harris drew on her own experiences working at a publishing office. The award-winning book is Harris’s first novel, but her writing _____ honored before. At the age of twelve, she entered a contest to have a story published in *American Girl* magazine—and won.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. were
- B. have been
- C. has been
- D. are

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb “has been” agrees in number with the singular subject “writing.”

Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb “were” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “writing.” Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb “have been” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “writing.” Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb “are” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “writing.”

Question ID: 432b1ede

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

The forty-seven geothermal springs of Arkansas’ Hot Springs National Park are sourced via a process known as natural groundwater recharge, in which rainwater percolates downward through the earth—in this case, the porous rocks of the hills around Hot _____ collect in a subterranean basin.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Springs to
- B. Springs: to
- C. Springs—to
- D. Springs, to

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of a supplementary element within a sentence. The dash after “Springs” pairs with the dash after “earth” to separate the supplementary element “in this case, the porous rocks of the hills around Hot Springs” from the rest of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice B is incorrect because a colon can’t be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because a comma can’t be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

In 1959, the film industry debuted Smell-O-Vision. Theaters were fitted with specialized vents that emitted odors at specific points in a _____ as the scent of roses when roses appeared in a scene. Smell-O-Vision failed to impress, however, with one reviewer declaring it “briefly weird and not very interesting.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. movie such
- B. movie; such
- C. movie. Such
- D. movie, such

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The comma appropriately separates the nonessential descriptive aside "such as...scene" from the independent clause "Theaters were...movie." Since the descriptive example of roses isn't necessary for the sentence to function, it needs to be set off with punctuation.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice results in a run-on sentence. Since the example of roses isn't necessary for the sentence to function, the descriptive aside "such as...scene" needs to be separated from the preceding independent clause with some sort of punctuation. Choice B is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error. A semicolon can only be used to separate two independent clauses, but "such...scene" is not an independent clause and couldn't stand on its own as a sentence. Choice C is incorrect. This choice results in a sentence fragment. The descriptive aside "Such...scene" is not an independent clause and can't stand on its own as a sentence.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

In winter, the diets of Japanese macaques, also known as snow monkeys, are influenced more by food availability than by food preference. Although the monkeys prefer to eat vegetation and land-dwelling invertebrates, those food sources may become unavailable because of extensive snow and ice cover, _____ the monkeys to hunt for marine animals in any streams that have not frozen over.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. forces
- B. to force
- C. forcing
- D. forced

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of finite and nonfinite verb forms within a sentence. The nonfinite present participle “forcing” is correctly used to form a participial phrase that supplements the main clause “those...cover,” describing the effects on monkeys of the lack of food sources.

Choice A is incorrect because the finite present tense verb “forces” can’t be used in this way to supplement the main clause (“those...cover”).

Choice B is incorrect. While the nonfinite to-infinitive “to force” could be used to form a subordinate clause that supplements the main clause (“those...cover”), to-infinitives conventionally express purpose, and nothing in the sentence suggests that the food sources become unavailable for the purpose of forcing monkeys to hunt marine animals. Choice D is incorrect because the finite past tense verb “forced” can’t be used in this way to supplement the main clause (“those...cover”).

Question ID: 267a13e2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

In 2010, archaeologist Noel Hidalgo Tan was visiting the twelfth-century temple of Angkor Wat in Cambodia when he noticed markings of red paint on the temple _____. the help of digital imaging techniques, he discovered the markings to be part of an elaborate mural containing over 200 paintings.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. walls, with
- B. walls with
- C. walls so with
- D. walls. With

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period after “walls” is used correctly to mark the boundary between the first sentence (“In...walls”) and the second sentence (“With...techniques”), which starts with a supplementary phrase.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences (“In...walls” and “with...paintings”) are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice C is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction “so” can’t be used in this way to join sentences.

Question ID: 403d7bb5

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

According to Naomi Nakayama of the University of Edinburgh, the reason seeds from a dying dandelion appear to float in the air while _____ is that their porous plumes enhance drag, allowing the seeds to stay airborne long enough for the wind to disperse them throughout the surrounding area.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. falling,
- B. falling:
- C. falling;
- D. falling

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The word “falling” occurs in the middle of a clause and isn’t part of a supplement, so we don’t need any punctuation after it. We can see this more clearly if we simplify the rest of the sentence: “The reason seeds appear to float while falling is that their plumes enhance drag.” .

Choice A is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. The word “falling” occurs in the middle of a clause and isn’t part of a supplement, so we don’t need any punctuation after it. We can see this more clearly if we simplify the sentence: “The reason seeds appear to float while falling is that their plumes enhance drag.” . Choice B is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. The word “falling” occurs in the middle of a clause and isn’t part of a supplement, so we don’t need any punctuation after it. We can see this more clearly if we simplify the sentence: “The reason seeds appear to float while falling is that their plumes enhance drag.” . Choice C is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. The word “falling” occurs in the middle of a clause and isn’t part of a supplement, so we don’t need any punctuation after it. We can see this more clearly if we simplify the sentence: “The reason seeds appear to float while falling is that their plumes enhance drag.” .

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

In his *Naturalis historia*, Pliny the Elder praised Hipparchus’s star catalog, a second-century BCE list of roughly 850 different stars’ celestial positions. For centuries, scholars dreamed about locating a copy of this legendary lost _____ fantasy (partially) became reality in 2022, when researchers uncovered traces of the star catalog on a palimpsest, a reused parchment.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. work, that
- B. work that
- C. work. That
- D. work and that

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence ("For...work") and another ("That...parchment").

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences ("For...work" and "that...parchment") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice D is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction "and" can’t be used in this way to join sentences.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Azulejos, mosaics made of glazed ceramic tiles, can be found throughout Portugal. These mosaics beautify places such as _____ stations, and public squares.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. libraries train
- B. libraries: train
- C. libraries—train
- D. libraries, train

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of items in a simple series. The comma after "libraries" is used conventionally to separate the first and second items ("libraries" and "train stations") in the series.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to separate the first two items ("libraries" and "train stations") in the series. Choice B is incorrect because a colon can't be used in this way to separate items in a simple series. Choice C is incorrect because a dash can't be used in this way to separate items in a simple series.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Jetties—long, narrow structures that extend from a landmass into the water—are often constructed to protect coastlines from erosion. Jetties can sometimes have the opposite _____ obstructing the natural flow of sand along the shore can lead to increased erosion in some areas.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. effect, though;
- B. effect, though
- C. effect; though
- D. effect, though,

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma to separate the supplementary adverb "though" from the preceding main clause ("Jetties can sometimes have the opposite effect") and uses a semicolon to join the next main clause ("obstructing...areas") to the rest of the sentence. Further, placing the semicolon after "though" logically indicates that the information earlier in this sentence (that jetties can sometimes cause erosion) is contrary to what might be assumed from the information in the previous sentence (that jetties are often constructed for the purpose of protecting coastlines from erosion).

Choice B is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the two main clauses with appropriate punctuation. With "though...areas" functioning as a subordinate clause following the comma, this choice illogically indicates that the following information (that obstructing the natural flow of sand along the shore can sometimes lead to erosion) is contrary to the information earlier in the sentence (that jetties can sometimes cause erosion). Instead, the information following "though" supports the previous claim about the erosive effects of jetties. Choice C is incorrect because it's not conventional to use a semicolon in this way to separate a main clause from a dependent clause. Further, it illogically indicates that the following information (that obstructing the natural flow of sand along the shore can sometimes lead to erosion) is contrary to the information earlier in the sentence (that jetties can sometimes cause erosion). Instead, the information following "though" supports the previous claim about the erosive effects of jetties. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Commas can't be used in this way to set off a supplementary word or phrase between two main clauses.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

Planetary scientist Briony Horgan and her colleagues have determined that as much as 25 percent of the sand on Mars is composed of impact spherules. These spherical bits of glass form when asteroids collide with the planet, ejecting bits of molten rock into the atmosphere that, after cooling and solidifying into glass, _____ back onto Mars’s surface.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. to rain
- B. raining
- C. having rained
- D. rain

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. "That...[rain] back onto Mars’s surface" is a relative clause that describes the "bits of molten rock." Forming the clause requires a conjugated, finite verb, and this is the only choice that provides that.

Choice A is incorrect. "To rain" is an infinitive and can’t serve as the main verb of a clause. A conjugated verb is needed here to form the main verb of the relative clause "that...[rain] back onto Mars’s surface," which describes the "bits of molten rock." Choice B is incorrect. "Raining" is a present participle and, on its own, can’t serve as the main verb of a clause. A conjugated verb is needed here to form the main verb of the relative clause "that...[rain] back onto Mars’s surface," which describes the "bits of molten rock." Choice C is incorrect. "Having rained" is a perfect participle and can’t serve as the main verb of a clause. A conjugated verb is needed here to form the main verb of the relative clause "that...[rain] back onto Mars’s surface," which describes the "bits of molten rock."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Lê Lương Minh became the thirteenth secretary-general of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) in January 2013, making _____ the first time the organization would appoint a Vietnamese leader.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. these
- B. those
- C. this
- D. some

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is pronoun-antecedent agreement. The singular pronoun "this" agrees in number with the singular antecedent "Lê Lương Minh became the thirteenth secretary-general of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) in January 2013." The pronoun "this" is referring back to the singular event described earlier in the sentence in which Minh became secretary-general of ASEAN.

Choice A is incorrect because the plural pronoun "these" doesn't agree in number with the singular antecedent "Lê Lương Minh became the thirteenth secretary-general of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) in January 2013." Choice B is incorrect because the plural pronoun "those" doesn't agree in number with the singular antecedent "Lê Lương Minh became the thirteenth secretary-general of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) in January 2013." Choice D is incorrect because the indefinite pronoun "some" is ambiguous in this context; the resulting sentence leaves unclear what marks the first time the organization appointed a Vietnamese leader.

Question ID: 6b49f5f1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

In 1727, dramatist Lewis Theobald presented a new play, *Double Falsehood*, at a London theater. Theobald claimed that his drama was based on a little-known play by William Shakespeare, *Cardenio*. Many, including poet Alexander Pope, were _____ historians have determined that Shakespeare’s company did perform a play called *Cardenio* in 1613.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. skeptical but
- B. skeptical, but
- C. skeptical,
- D. skeptical

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. There are two independent clauses in the sentence, each with a subject and a verb: "many...were skeptical" and "historians have determined...." These clauses can be grammatically joined by a comma and the coordinating conjunction "but."

Choice A is incorrect. This choice results in a run-on sentence, which occurs when two independent clauses are joined without punctuation. Two independent clauses can't be joined by just the coordinating conjunction "but." A comma would also be required. Choice C is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error called a comma splice. This sentence contains two independent clauses ("Many...were skeptical" and "historians have determined..."). A comma alone can't join two independent clauses. That requires a comma and a coordinating conjunction. Choice D is incorrect. This choice results in a run-on sentence, which occurs when two independent clauses are joined without punctuation. This sentence contains two independent clauses ("Many...were skeptical" and "historians have determined..."), which need to be either joined by a semicolon, joined by a comma and a coordinating conjunction, or separated by a period.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Mathematician Grigori Perelman, sometimes in conjunction with mathematicians Richard S. Hamilton and Shing-Tung Yau, _____ credited with proving the Poincaré conjecture. Having built on Hamilton’s previous work to solve the proof, Perelman has insisted that Hamilton receive credit. Yau later found and closed gaps in Perelman’s proof, persuading some mathematicians that he deserves credit as well.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. are
- B. have been
- C. are being
- D. is

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "is credited" agrees in number with the singular subject "mathematician Grigori Perelman."

Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb "are credited" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "mathematician Grigori Perelman."

Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "have been credited" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "mathematician Grigori Perelman." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "are being credited" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "mathematician Grigori Perelman."

Question ID: 2dd1b8bf

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Compared to that of alumina glass, _____ silica glass atoms are so far apart that they are unable to re-form bonds after being separated.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. silica glass is at a significant disadvantage due to its more dispersed atomic arrangement:
- B. silica glass has a more dispersed atomic arrangement, resulting in a significant disadvantage:
- C. a significant disadvantage of silica glass is that its atomic arrangement is more dispersed:
- D. silica glass’s atomic arrangement is more dispersed, resulting in a significant disadvantage:

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes “silica glass’s atomic arrangement” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase “compared to that of alumina glass.” In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that silica glass’s atomic arrangement—and not another noun in the sentence—is being compared to the atomic arrangement (“that”) of alumina glass.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “silica glass” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that silica glass itself (rather than its atomic arrangement) is being compared to alumina glass’s atomic arrangement. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “silica glass” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that silica glass itself (rather than its atomic arrangement) is being compared to alumina glass’s atomic arrangement. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “a significant disadvantage” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that “a significant disadvantage” is being compared to alumina glass’s atomic arrangement.

Question ID: 577b09fa

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Robin Wall Kimmerer of the Citizen Potawatomi Nation is a bryologist, a plant scientist who specializes in mosses. To Kimmerer, mosses are Earth’s most adaptable plants: they can clone _____ enter a dormant state in times of drought, and grow in areas that don’t have soil.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. themselves;
- B. themselves,
- C. themselves. And
- D. themselves

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of items in a series. The comma after “themselves” is used conventionally to separate the first item (“they can clone themselves”) and the second item (“enter a dormant state in times of drought”) in the series of things mosses can do.

Choice A is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to separate items in a simple series such as this. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “And enter.” Choice D is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the first and second items in the series.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

The Tantaquidgeon Museum in Uncasville, Connecticut, was founded in 1931 with the goal of showcasing the culture and history of the Mohegan _____. today, nearly a century later, it is the oldest Native-owned and -operated museum in the country.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Tribe, and
- B. Tribe
- C. Tribe and
- D. Tribe,

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. This choice uses a comma and a coordinating conjunction (“and”) to join two independent clauses (“The Tantaquidgeon...Tribe” and “Today...country”).

Choice B is incorrect. This choice results in a grammar error known as a run-on sentence. The clauses before and after “Tribe” are both independent, so they need to be separated with some sort of punctuation. Choice C is incorrect. This choice results in a grammar error known as a run-on sentence. The clauses before and after “and” are both independent, so they can’t be linked with just a conjunction. A comma would also be required. Choice D is incorrect. This choice results in a grammar error called a comma splice. The clauses before and after “Tribe” are both independent, so they can’t be linked with just a comma. A coordinating conjunction like “and” or “but” would also be required.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

That the expansionist appetites of colonial European powers had their sights set on his country was evident to Siam’s King _____ deterring those ambitions through international diplomacy and domestic reform was perhaps his foremost achievement. Though his reign ended roughly twenty years before Siam became known by its modern name of Thailand, King Chulalongkorn is often credited with ushering the nation into modernity.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Chulalongkorn;
- B. Chulalongkorn that
- C. Chulalongkorn,
- D. Chulalongkorn

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice uses a semicolon in a conventional way to join the first main clause (“That...Chulalongkorn”) and the second main clause (“detering...achievement”).

Choice B is incorrect. Using the conjunction “that” to introduce “detering...achievement” as a subordinate element of the main clause (“That...Chulalongkorn”) results in a confusing and ungrammatical sentence. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Scala is referred to as a compiled programming language because it typically incorporates a compiler—a tool that translates lines of code into executable commands. Compiling isn’t exclusive to certain programming ____ any language can incorporate this tool.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. languages. However,
- B. languages; however,
- C. languages, however,
- D. languages, however;

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma to separate the supplementary adverb “however” from the preceding main clause (“Compiling...languages”) and uses a semicolon to join the next main clause (“any...tool”) to the rest of the sentence. Further, placing the semicolon after “however” indicates that the information in the preceding main clause (“compiling isn’t exclusive to certain programming languages”) is contrary to what might be assumed from the information in the previous sentence (Scala’s status as a compiled programming language might suggest that compiling is unique to certain languages).

Choice A is incorrect because placing a period after “languages” and starting a new sentence with “however” illogically indicates that the information in the next sentence (any language can incorporate a compiler) is contrary to the information in the previous sentence (“compiling isn’t exclusive to certain programming languages”). Instead, the information following “however” supports the previous claim. Choice B is incorrect because placing the semicolon after “languages” illogically indicates that the information in the next main clause (any language can incorporate a compiler) is contrary to the information in the previous clause (“compiling isn’t exclusive to certain programming languages”). Instead, the information following “however” supports the previous claim. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Commas can’t be used in this way to punctuate a supplementary word or phrase between two main clauses.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

For thousands of years, humans have used domesticated goats (*Capra hircus*) to clear land of unwanted vegetation. When it comes to their diets, goats are notoriously _____ they will devour all kinds of shrubs and weeds, leaving virtually no part of any plant unconsumed.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. indiscriminate and
- B. indiscriminate,
- C. indiscriminate
- D. indiscriminate:

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between two main clauses. In this choice, a colon is correctly used to mark the boundary between one main clause ("goats are notoriously indiscriminate") and another main clause ("they will devour all kinds of shrubs and weeds") and to introduce the following explanation of goats’ nondiscriminatory behavior when it comes to what they eat.

Choice A is incorrect because when coordinating two longer main clauses such as these, it’s conventional to use a comma before the coordinating conjunction. Furthermore, the conjunction "and" fails to indicate that what follows is an explanation of goats’ nondiscriminatory behavior when it comes to their diets. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses ("goats...indiscriminate" and "they...weeds"). Choice C is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses ("goats...indiscriminate" and "they...weeds") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

On March 27, 2004, after nine years as a professional boxer, Isra Girgrah retired. The Yemeni American athlete _____ her career with a record of twenty-eight wins, three losses, and two ties.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. finish
- B. has been finishing
- C. finished
- D. will be finishing

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of a verb to express tense in a sentence. In this choice, the past tense verb “finished” is consistent with the other past tense verb (“retired”) used to refer to Girgrah’s retirement in 2004.

Choice A is incorrect because the present tense verb “finish” isn’t consistent with the other past tense verb (“retired”) used to refer to Girgrah’s retirement in 2004. Furthermore, the plural verb “finish” doesn’t agree in number with the sentence’s singular subject “The Yemeni American athlete.” Choice B is incorrect because the present perfect progressive tense verb “has been finishing” isn’t consistent with the other past tense verb (“retired”) used to refer to Girgrah’s retirement in 2004. Choice D is incorrect because the future progressive tense verb “will be finishing” isn’t consistent with the other past tense verb (“retired”) used to refer to Girgrah’s retirement in 2004.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Food and the sensation of taste are central to Monique Truong’s novels. In *The Book of Salt*, for example, the exiled character of Binh connects to his native Saigon through the food he prepares, while in *Bitter in the Mouth*, the character of Linda _____ a form of synesthesia whereby the words she hears evoke tastes.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- Answer**
- A. experienced
 - B. had experienced
 - C. experiences
 - D. will be experiencing

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verbs to express tense. In this choice, the present tense verb “experiences” is consistent with the other present tense verbs (e.g., “connects” and “prepares”) used to describe the events in Truong’s novels. Furthermore, it’s conventional to use the present tense when discussing a literary work.

Choice A is incorrect because the past tense verb “experienced” isn’t consistent with the other present tense verbs used to describe the events in Truong’s novels. Choice B is incorrect because the past perfect tense verb “had experienced” isn’t consistent with the other present tense verbs used to describe the events in Truong’s novels. Choice D is incorrect because the future progressive tense verb “will be experiencing” isn’t consistent with the other present tense verbs used to describe the events in Truong’s novels.

Question ID: b260c65a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Earth is not a perfect sphere. Due to the _____ gravitational pull, Earth bulges out on the sides closest to and farthest from the Moon. This distorting pull is known as a tidal force, and it is responsible for the changes in water levels that are called high and low tides.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Moon’s
- B. Moons
- C. Moons’
- D. Moon

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of possessive nouns. The singular possessive noun "Moon's" correctly indicates that there is only one Moon, and it has a gravitational pull.

Choice B is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive noun "Moon's," not the plural noun "Moons." Choice C is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive noun "Moon's," not the plural possessive noun "Moons'." Choice D is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive noun "Moon's," not the singular noun "Moon."

Question ID: 83c9c503

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Nigerian American artist Toyin Ojih Odutola uses black-ink pens to create highly detailed drawings of human figures. Her portrait of novelist Zadie _____ is displayed in the National Portrait Gallery in London.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Smith:
- B. Smith—
- C. Smith
- D. Smith,

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a subject and a verb. No punctuation is needed when, as in this case, a subject ("Her portrait of novelist Zadie Smith") is immediately followed by a main verb ("is displayed").

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

While the ancient Celts—Iron Age peoples who inhabited parts of western and central Europe—weren’t a single unified group, their art often featured common elements. These included intricate patterns of interlocking spiral lines, which often held symbolic _____ of birds, horses, and other animals; and inlaid enamel accents.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. significance; depictions
- B. significance, depictions
- C. significance: depictions
- D. significance. Depictions

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of elements in a complex series. It’s conventional to use a semicolon to separate items in a complex series with internal punctuation, and in this choice, the semicolon after “significance” is conventionally used to separate the first item (“intricate...significance”) and the second item (“depictions...animals”) in the series of common elements found in Celtic art. Moreover, the semicolon after “significance” matches the semicolon used later to separate the second item (“depictions...animals”) and the third item (“and...accents”) in the series.

Choice B is incorrect because a comma after “significance” doesn’t match the semicolon used later to separate the second and third items in the series (“depictions...animals” and “and...accents”). Choice C is incorrect because a colon can’t be used in this way to separate items in a complex series. Choice D is incorrect because placing a period after “significance” results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “depictions.”

Question ID: 9f737b2a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

In Death Valley National Park’s Racetrack Playa, a flat, dry lakebed, are 162 rocks—some weighing less than a pound but others almost 700 pounds—that move periodically from place to place, seemingly of their own volition. Racetrack-like trails in the _____ mysterious migration.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. playas sediment mark the rock’s
- B. playa’s sediment mark the rocks
- C. playa’s sediment mark the rocks’
- D. playas’ sediment mark the rocks’

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of plural and possessive nouns. The singular possessive noun “playa’s” and the plural possessive noun “rocks” correctly indicate that the sediment is that of one playa (the Racetrack Playa) and that there are multiple rocks that have mysteriously migrated across the sediment.

Choice A is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive noun “playa’s” and the plural possessive noun “rocks;” not the plural noun “playas” and the singular possessive noun “rock’s.” Choice B is incorrect because the context requires the plural possessive noun “rocks;” not the plural noun “rocks.” Choice D is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive noun “playa’s,” not the plural possessive noun “playas’.”

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

The human brain is primed to recognize faces—so much so that, due to a perceptual tendency called pareidolia, _____ will even find faces in clouds, wooden doors, pieces of fruit, and other faceless inanimate objects. Researcher Susan Magsamen has focused her work on better understanding this everyday phenomenon.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. she
- B. they
- C. it
- D. those

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. "It" is a singular pronoun used to stand in for objects. Since the antecedent in this case is the singular noun phrase "the human brain," "it" is a perfect pronoun to use here.

Choice A is incorrect. Although "she" is a singular pronoun, it is reserved for people and animals, not objects like "the human brain." Choice B is incorrect. "They" is a plural pronoun, but we need a singular pronoun to represent the antecedent "the human brain." Choice D is incorrect. "Those" is a plural pronoun, but we need a singular pronoun to represent the antecedent "the human brain."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

The poem *Beowulf* begins with the word “hwæt,” which is an Old English _____ as “hark!” or “listen!” in some versions, the word was playfully rendered as “bro!” by Maria Dahvana Headley in her 2020 translation of the poem.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. exclamation, translated
- B. exclamation and translated
- C. exclamation translated
- D. exclamation. Translated

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence ("The poem...exclamation") and another sentence that begins with a supplementary element ("Translated...poem"). The supplementary element "translated as 'hark!' or 'listen!' in some versions" modifies the subject of the second sentence, "the word" (referring to hwæt).

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice after "exclamation." A comma can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice B is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction "and" can't be used in this way to join sentences. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice after "versions." A comma can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

In 2016, engineer Vanessa Galvez oversaw the installation of 164 bioswales, vegetated channels designed to absorb and divert stormwater, along the streets of Queens, New York. By reducing the runoff flowing into city sewers, _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. the mitigation of both street flooding and the resulting pollution of nearby waterways has been achieved by bioswales.
- B. the bioswales have mitigated both street flooding and the resulting pollution of nearby waterways.
- C. the bioswales’ mitigation of both street flooding and the resulting pollution of nearby waterways has been achieved.
- D. both street flooding and the resulting pollution of nearby waterways have been mitigated by bioswales.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase “the bioswales” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase “By reducing...sewers.” In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that the bioswales—and not another noun in the sentence—are reducing runoff flowing into city sewers.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “the mitigation...waterways” immediately after the modifying phrase results in unclear modification. The resulting sentence makes it hard to determine what is responsible for “reducing the runoff”: the bioswales or some other noun in the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “the bioswales’ mitigation...waterways” immediately after the modifying phrase results in unclear modification. The resulting sentence makes it hard to determine what is responsible for “reducing the runoff”: the bioswales or some other noun in the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “street flooding and the resulting pollution” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the “flooding and pollution” are reducing runoff flowing into city sewers.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

Official measurements of the Mississippi River’s length vary: according to the US Geological Survey, the river is 2,300 miles long, whereas the Environmental Protection Agency records its length as 2,320 miles. This disparity can be explained in part by the fact that rivers such as the Mississippi expand and contract as _____ sediment.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. they accumulate
- B. one accumulates
- C. it accumulates
- D. we accumulate

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is pronoun-antecedent agreement. The plural pronoun “they” agrees in number with the plural antecedent “rivers” and clearly expresses the general statement that rivers expand and contract as they accumulate sediment. Secondly, the plural verb “accumulate” agrees in number with the plural pronoun and its plural antecedent.

Choice B is incorrect because the singular pronoun “one” doesn’t agree in number with the plural antecedent “rivers.” Choice C is incorrect because the singular pronoun “it” doesn’t agree in number with the plural antecedent “rivers.” Choice D is incorrect because the use of the personal pronoun “we” is illogical in this context; it suggests that a group of people (including the speaker) accumulate sediment, which doesn’t make sense.

Question ID: a466679a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

In 1976, the Inuit rock group Sikumiut recorded the album *People of the Ice*. Though only their first record, it shows a band already skilled at the difficult task of making music that sounds easy and fun. On songs like “Utirumavunga,” Lucassie Koperqualuk’s guitar riffs effortlessly _____ Charlie Adams’s delightfully catchy vocal melodies.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. blend, with
- B. blend. With
- C. blend; with
- D. blend with

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between a verb and a prepositional phrase. No punctuation is needed between the verb “blend” and the prepositional phrase “with Charlie Adams’s delightfully catchy vocal melodies.” The prepositional phrase completes the idea of the sentence, explaining with what Koperqualuk’s guitar riffs blend.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the verb and the prepositional phrase. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the verb and the prepositional phrase. Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the verb and the prepositional phrase.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Nigerian author Buchi Emecheta’s celebrated literary oeuvre includes *The Joys of Motherhood*, a novel about the changing roles of women in 1950s _____ a television play about the private struggles of a newlywed couple in Nigeria; and *Head Above Water*, her autobiography.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Lagos, *A Kind of Marriage*,
- B. Lagos; *A Kind of Marriage*,
- C. Lagos, *A Kind of Marriage*:
- D. Lagos; *A Kind of Marriage*

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of items in a complex series (a series including internal punctuation). In this choice, the semicolon after “Lagos” is conventionally used to separate the first item (“*The Joys*...Lagos”) and the second item (“*A Kind*...Nigeria”) in the series. Further, the comma after “*Marriage*” correctly separates the title “*A Kind of Marriage*” from the supplementary phrase (“a television...Nigeria”) that describes it.

Choice A is incorrect because the comma after “Lagos” doesn’t match the semicolon used later in the series to separate the second item (“*A Kind*...Nigeria”) from the third item (“and...autobiography”). Choice C is incorrect because the comma after “Lagos” doesn’t match the semicolon used later in the series to separate the second item (“*A Kind*...Nigeria”) from the third item (“and...autobiography”). Additionally, a colon can’t be used in this way to separate the title “*A Kind of Marriage*” from the supplementary phrase (“a television...Nigeria”) that describes it. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the title “*A Kind of Marriage*” from the supplementary phrase (“a television...Nigeria”) that describes it.

Question ID: 898f182c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Richard Spikes was a prolific African American inventor known for his contributions to automotive engineering. Between 1907 and 1946, he patented many inventions, _____ an automobile turn signal, a safety brake, and—most famously—the first automatic gearshift.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. included
- B. includes
- C. including
- D. will include

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of nonfinite verb forms within a sentence. The nonfinite present participle "including" is correctly used to form a participial phrase that supplements the main clause "he patented many inventions," listing several of Spikes’s patented inventions.

Choice A is incorrect because the finite past tense verb "included" can’t be used in this way to supplement the main clause "he patented many inventions." Choice B is incorrect because the finite present tense verb "includes" can’t be used in this way to supplement the main clause "he patented many inventions." Choice D is incorrect because the finite future tense verb "will include" can’t be used in this way to supplement the main clause "he patented many inventions."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Even though bats prefer very sweet nectar, the plants that attract them have evolved to produce nectar that is only moderately sweet. A recent study _____ why: making sugar is energy-intensive, and it is more advantageous for plants to make a large amount of low-sugar nectar than a small amount of high-sugar nectar.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. explains
- B. explaining
- C. having explained
- D. to explain

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of finite and nonfinite verb forms within a sentence. A main clause requires a finite verb to perform the action of the subject (in this case, “a recent study”), and this choice supplies the finite present tense verb “explains” to indicate that the study explains why plants that attract bats have evolved to produce moderately sweet nectar.

Choice B is incorrect because the nonfinite participle “explaining” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice C is incorrect because the nonfinite participle “having explained” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice D is incorrect because the nonfinite to-infinitive “to explain” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Long attributed to Jacques-Louis David, the preeminent Neoclassical painter of his day, the 1801 painting *Marie Joséphine Charlotte du Val d’Ognes* gained fresh attention in the 1990s when art historians discovered that the painting—which depicts a solitary young woman sketching—was actually the work of little-known French portrait _____ Marie-Denise Villers (1774–1821).

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. artist—
- B. artist
- C. artist:
- D. artist,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation between titles and proper nouns. No punctuation is needed to set off the proper noun "Marie-Denise Villers" from the title that describes Villers, "little-known French portrait artist."

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed. Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed.

Question ID: 84658166

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

In 1943, in the midst of World War II, mathematics professor Grace Hopper was recruited by the US military to help the war effort by solving complex equations. Hopper’s subsequent career would involve more than just _____ as a pioneering computer programmer, Hopper would help usher in the digital age.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. equations, though:
- B. equations, though,
- C. equations. Though,
- D. equations though

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation to mark boundaries between supplements and clauses. The comma after “equations” is used to separate the independent clause (“Hopper’s...equation”) from the supplementary adverb phrase “though.” The colon after “though” is used to mark the boundary between the clause ending with “though” and the following clause (“as...age”). A colon used in this way introduces information that illustrates or explains information that has come before it. In this case, the colon after “though” introduces the following explanation of how Hopper’s subsequent career would involve more than just solving equations: she would become a pioneering computer programmer.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to join two independent clauses (“Hopper’s... though” and “as...age”) such as these. Choice C is incorrect because it results in an illogical sequence of sentences. Placing the period after “equations” and beginning the next sentence with “Though” illogically suggests that the following information (that Hopper would help usher in the digital age) is contrary to the information in the previous sentence (Hopper’s subsequent career would involve more than just solving equations). Instead, the information that follows supports the information from the previous sentence by explaining how her work and influence extended beyond solely solving equations. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two independent clauses (“Hopper’s...though” and “as...age”) are fused without punctuation.

Question ID: 7c48a6dd

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

In the late 1960s, inspired in part by the sight of laundry hanging on a clothesline, African American abstract painter Sam Gilliam began to create his iconic “Drape” paintings. He applied bold, saturated hues to large canvases and _____ them from ceilings or walls, causing the drooping fabric to cascade in dramatic loops and curves.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. to have suspended
- B. suspending
- C. to suspend
- D. suspended

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The past tense verb “suspended” provides a second finite verb to complete the coordinated structure of the sentence, in which the two finite verbs (“applied” and “suspended”) are used to describe what Gilliam did.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite to-infinitive “to have suspended” doesn’t supply a second finite verb to complete the coordinated structure of the sentence. Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle “suspending” doesn’t supply a second finite verb to complete the coordinated structure of the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite to-infinitive “to suspend” doesn’t supply a second finite verb to complete the coordinated structure of the sentence.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Digital artist Jung (Lulu) Chen primarily uses a suite of software tools to create illustrations for children’s books. To manifest the warm and welcoming atmospheres that are a signature of her _____ she occasionally relies on more traditional art techniques, such as painting with watercolors.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. work, though,
- B. work, though
- C. work; though,
- D. work, though;

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. The comma after "work" pairs with the comma after "though" to separate the supplementary element "though" from the rest of the sentence. This supplementary element signals that what follows is an exception to Chen using software tools to create illustrations, and the pair of commas indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice B is incorrect because the comma after "work" must be paired with a comma after "though" to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be paired with a comma in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be paired with a comma in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

A conceptual artist and designer embraced by both the art world and the fashion _____ Mary Ping was chosen to curate the exhibition *Front Row: Chinese American Designers* for the Museum of Chinese in America.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. world
- B. world:
- C. world;
- D. world,

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between a supplementary phrase and a main clause. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the supplementary phrase (“A conceptual artist...world”), which describes Mary Ping, and the main clause (“Mary...America”).

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the supplementary phrase (“A conceptual artist...world”) and the main clause (“Mary...America”) with appropriate punctuation. Choice B is incorrect because a colon can’t be used in this way to join the supplementary phrase (“A conceptual artist...world”) and the main clause (“Mary...America”). In this context, the colon incorrectly suggests that the information in the supplementary phrase is an explanation or amplification of the information in the main clause (Mary Ping being chosen to curate the exhibition), which isn’t the case. Choice C is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the supplementary phrase (“A conceptual artist...world”) and the main clause (“Mary...America”). Semicolons are conventionally used to separate two main clauses or to separate items in a complex series.

Question ID: 8d53e7a0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

Slam poet Elizabeth Acevedo’s debut novel *The Poet X*, winner of the 2018 National Book Award for Young People’s Literature, is composed of _____ protagonist, fifteen-year-old Xiomara Batista.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. poems putatively written by the novel’s
- B. poem’s putatively written by the novel’s
- C. poem’s putatively written by the novels’
- D. poems putatively written by the novels’

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. Nothing belongs to the “poems” in the sentence, so it should not be possessive—just a simple plural noun. The protagonist does belong to the novel—it’s the protagonist of the novel—so “novel” needs to be a singular possessive noun.

Choice B is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. This choice uses the singular possessive “poem’s,” but the text indicates that it should be the simple plural “poems”: there is more than one poem, and nothing belongs to the poems. Choice C is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. This choice uses the singular possessive “poem’s,” but the text indicates that it should be the simple plural “poems”: there is more than one poem, and nothing belongs to the poems. This choice also uses the plural possessive “novels’,” which is incorrect because there is only one novel. Choice D is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. This choice uses the plural possessive “novels’,” which is incorrect because there is only one novel, so it should be the singular possessive “novel’s.” .

Question ID: 43b88827

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

In October of 1648, representatives from 96 different parties convened to sign the final treaties of the Peace of Westphalia. The treaties, which brought an end to the Thirty Years’ War, _____ signed in the cities of Osnabrück and Münster, both located in the Holy Roman Empire–controlled region of Westphalia.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. were
- B. is
- C. was
- D. has been

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The plural verb “were signed” agrees in number with the plural subject “the treaties.”

Choice B is incorrect because the singular verb “is signed” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “the treaties.” Choice C is incorrect because the singular verb “was signed” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “the treaties.” Choice D is incorrect because the singular verb “has been signed” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “the treaties.”

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Both Sona Charaipotra, an Indian American, and Dhonielle Clayton, an African American, grew up frustrated by the lack of diverse characters in books for young people. In 2011, these two writers joined forces to found CAKE Literary, a book packaging _____ specializes in the creation and promotion of stories told from diverse perspectives for children and young adults.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. company,
- B. company that
- C. company
- D. company, that

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use and punctuation of an integrated relative clause. This choice correctly uses the relative pronoun “that” and no punctuation to create an integrated relative clause that provides essential information about the noun phrase (“a book packaging company”) that it modifies.

Choice A is incorrect because it doesn’t use a relative pronoun to link the verb phrase beginning with “specializes” to the noun phrase that it modifies (“a book packaging company”). Choice C is incorrect because it doesn’t use a relative pronoun to link the verb phrase beginning with “specializes” to the noun phrase that it modifies (“a book packaging company”). Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the integrated relative clause beginning with “that specializes” and the noun phrase that it modifies (“a book packaging company”).

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Artist Yto Barrada’s exhibition *Ways to Baffle the Wind* incorporates sculptures, textiles, and films. Barrada’s pieces, utilizing elements as disparate as plant-dyed fabrics, wire crab traps filled with stones, and cotton balls dangling above a fan, _____ the ways humans attempt to organize and regulate nature.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. explore
- B. has explored
- C. explores
- D. exploring

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The plural verb “explore” agrees in number with the plural subject “Barrada’s pieces.”

Choice B is incorrect because the singular verb phrase “has explored” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “Barrada’s pieces.” Choice C is incorrect because the singular verb “explores” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “Barrada’s pieces.” Choice D is incorrect because the nonfinite participle “exploring” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

When a given term—“self-fulfilling prophecies” and “role models” are two well-known examples—is generally accepted and frequently used, _____ susceptible to obliteration by incorporation (OBI). In cases of OBI, widely used terms are rarely, if at all, attributed to the individuals who coined them.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. they often become
- B. these often become
- C. this often becomes
- D. it often becomes

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is pronoun-antecedent agreement. The singular pronoun “it” agrees in number with the singular antecedent “a given term” and clearly indicates that the term becomes susceptible to obliteration by incorporation.

Choice A is incorrect because the plural pronoun “they” neither agrees in number with the singular antecedent “a given term” nor clearly indicates that the given term—not another plural noun in the sentence, such as “examples”—becomes susceptible to obliteration by incorporation. Choice B is incorrect because the plural pronoun “these” neither agrees in number with the singular antecedent “a given term” nor clearly indicates that the given term—not another plural noun in the sentence, such as “examples”—becomes susceptible to obliteration by incorporation. Choice C is incorrect because the singular pronoun “this” is ambiguous in this context, leaving unclear what exactly becomes susceptible to obliteration by incorporation.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Author Madeline L’Engle, _____ to create a suspenseful tone that draws the reader in, begins her novel *A Wrinkle in Time* with descriptions of “wraithlike shadows” and “the frenzied lashing of the wind.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. looked
- B. looks
- C. is looking
- D. looking

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The nonfinite present participle verb “looking” is correctly used to form a subordinate clause that describes the intent behind how L’Engle begins her novel.

Choice A is incorrect because the finite past tense verb “looked” can’t be used in this way to form a subordinate clause. Choice B is incorrect because the finite present tense verb “looks” can’t be used in this way to form a subordinate clause. Choice C is incorrect because the finite present progressive tense verb “is looking” can’t be used in this way to form a subordinate clause.

Question ID: 7b950fc2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

In 2000, Nora de Hoyos Comstock, herself an owner of a successful consulting firm, sought to increase Latina representation in corporate _____. She founded Las Comadres para las Americas, an international community that for over two decades has served as a resource and information network for Latina business professionals.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. settings she
- B. settings, she
- C. settings and she
- D. settings. She

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. It appropriately uses a period to mark the end of one independent clause ("In 2000...settings") and the start of another ("She founded...professionals").

Choice A is incorrect. This choice results in a run-on sentence error. Both the clause before the blank ("In 2000...settings") and the clause after the blank ("she...professionals") are independent clauses, so they need to be separated by punctuation. Choice B is incorrect. This choice results in a comma splice error. It incorrectly joins two independent clauses with just a comma. Linking two independent clauses with a comma also requires the use of a coordinating conjunction (like *for*, *and*, *nor*, *but*, *or*, *yet*, or *so*). Choice C is incorrect. This choice results in a run-on sentence, an error caused when two independent clauses are joined without punctuation or appropriate conjunctions. Since both the clause before the blank ("In 2000...settings") and the clause after the blank ("she...professionals") are independent, a comma would be required in addition to the coordinating conjunction "and."

Question ID: 75f49353

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

The Progressive Era in the United States witnessed the rise of numerous Black women’s clubs, local organizations that advocated for racial and gender equality. Among the clubs’ leaders _____ Josephine St. Pierre Ruffin, founder of the Women’s Era Club of Boston.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. was
- B. were
- C. are
- D. have been

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested here is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb “was” agrees in number with the singular subject “Josephine St. Pierre Ruffin.”

Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb “were” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “Josephine St. Pierre Ruffin.” Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb “are” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “Josephine St. Pierre Ruffin.” Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb “have been” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “Josephine St. Pierre Ruffin.”

Question ID: 20a6a4ed

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Anthropologist Livia Barbosa, of the Universidade Federal Fluminense in Brazil, _____ food and sociability in contemporary Brazil—specifically, how foods such as cabidela (a rice and rabbit dish) and churrasco (a barbeque dish) function as central mechanisms in building social relationships, values, and identities.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. studies
- B. are studying
- C. have studied
- D. study

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "studies" agrees in number with the singular subject "anthropologist Livia Barbosa."

Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "are studying" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "anthropologist Livia Barbosa."

Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "have studied" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "anthropologist Livia Barbosa."

Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb "study" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "anthropologist Livia Barbosa."

Question ID: 2cb1ee22

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

In premodern Europe, one could sail from the east coast of England to the Netherlands or France faster than one could travel by land to England’s capital, London. In that era, historian Michael Pye argues in his 2015 book *The Edge of the World: A Cultural History of the North Sea and the Transformation of Europe*, the North Sea did more to link the various peoples, cultures, and economies on _____ shores than to divide them.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. its
- B. it’s
- C. they’re
- D. their

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of possessive determiners. The singular possessive determiner “its” agrees in number with the singular noun “the North Sea” and thus indicates that the shores are those of the North Sea.

Choice B is incorrect because “it’s” is the contraction for “it is” or “it has,” not a possessive determiner. Choice C is incorrect because “they’re” is the contraction for “they are,” not a possessive determiner. Choice D is incorrect because the plural possessive determiner “their” doesn’t agree in number with the singular noun “the North Sea.”

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

The Proto-Nilotic language, common ancestor of fifty-five African languages with similar linguistic properties, _____ like all protolanguages, hypothetical: there’s no direct evidence these ancestral languages actually existed.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. is,
- B. are,
- C. have been,
- D. were,

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "is" agrees in number with the singular subject "the Proto-Nilotic language." Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "are" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "the Proto-Nilotic language." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "have been" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "the Proto-Nilotic language." Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb "were" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "the Proto-Nilotic language."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

In the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, automobiles were commonly referred to as horseless carriages after the older technology they still resembled. Known as the Brass Era, this period in automotive design is remembered for its grandeur and artistry, its vehicles _____ by collectors for their ornate detailing and gleaming brass fittings.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. are highly prized
- B. had been highly prized
- C. highly prized
- D. were highly prized

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms in a sentence. The nonfinite past participle phrase "highly prized" is correctly used to form a supplementary element that modifies the main clause "this...artistry," describing memorable features of Brass Era automotive design.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Using the finite present tense verb phrase "are highly prized" creates a second main clause in the sentence, and two main clauses can't be joined in this way with only a comma after "artistry." Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Using the finite past perfect tense verb phrase "had been highly prized" creates a second main clause in the sentence, and two main clauses can't be joined in this way with only a comma after "artistry." Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Using the finite past tense verb phrase "were highly prized" creates a second main clause in the sentence, and two main clauses can't be joined in this way with only a comma after "artistry."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

The radial velocity method, a means of indirect planetary discovery, has detected previously unknown exoplanets at vast distances from _____ the gas giant 55 Cancri d; at 60 light-years away, the Neptune-like planet Pi Mensae d; and, as of 2023, over 1,000 other exoplanets that are too far away and dim to be observed directly.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Earth at 41 light-years away:
- B. Earth: at 41 light-years away,
- C. Earth, at 41 light-years away,
- D. Earth at 41 light-years away,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. In this choice, a colon is correctly used after the main clause (“The radial...Earth”) to introduce the complex series that follows. Furthermore, the comma after “away” is conventionally used to separate the supplementary phrase “at 41 light-years away” from the noun phrase it describes (“the gas giant 55 Cancri d”), the first item in the series.

Choice A is incorrect because placing a colon after “away” illogically separates the supplementary phrase “at 41 light-years away” from the noun phrase it describes (“the gas giant 55 Cancri d”) and attaches it to the main clause (“The radial...away”), resulting in a confusing and illogical sentence. Choice C is incorrect because a comma cannot be used in this way to mark the boundary between a main clause (“The radial...Earth”) and a complex series. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the main clause (“The radial...Earth”) and the complex series that follows with appropriate punctuation.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Hegra is an archaeological site in present-day Saudi Arabia and was the second largest city of the Nabataean Kingdom (fourth century BCE to first century CE). Archaeologist Laila Nehmé recently traveled to Hegra to study its ancient _____ into the rocky outcrops of a vast desert, these burial chambers seem to blend seamlessly with nature.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. tombs. Built
- B. tombs, built
- C. tombs and built
- D. tombs built

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period after “tombs” is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence (“Archaeologist...tombs”) and another (“Built...nature”).

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice C is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction “and” can’t be used in this way to join the two sentences. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences (“Archaeologist...tombs” and “Built...nature”) are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Alberto Gabriele, author of *Reading Popular Culture in Victorian Print*, tracks the transnational dissemination of works by author Mary Elizabeth Braddon via the magazine _____ from 1866 to 1899 and distributed throughout the Australian cities of Melbourne, Adelaide, and Hobart; the continental European cities of Brussels, Paris, and Turin; and cities in Turkey, India, and Jamaica, this magazine helped make Braddon’s serialized novels globally available.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. *Belgravia*; published
- B. *Belgravia*. Published
- C. *Belgravia* published
- D. *Belgravia*, published

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between the first sentence (“Alberto...*Belgravia*”) and the second (“Published...available”). The participial phrase beginning with “published” contains a complex series punctuated with commas and semicolons (“the Australian cities of Melbourne, Adelaide, and Hobart; the continental European cities of Brussels, Paris, and Turin; and cities in Turkey, India, and Jamaica”), and this participial phrase modifies the subject of the second sentence, “this magazine.”

Choice A is incorrect. Using a semicolon to join two main clauses in this way in combination with the semicolons that separate the items in the complex series would result in an ambiguous and confusing sentence. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. With no punctuation after “*Belgravia*,” the participial phrase “published...Jamaica” reads as an integrated modifier within the noun phrase “the magazine *Belgravia*,” and the first main clause (“Alberto...Jamaica”) is then joined to a second main clause (“this...available”) using only a comma. A comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses.

Question ID: fff4c7f4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

American poet Emily Dickinson wrote many of her poems on scraps of paper, but she also took steps to collect these works. From 1858 to around 1864, for example, she copied more than 800 of _____ into forty homemade booklets (known as fascicles).

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. them
- B. this
- C. that
- D. it

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The pronoun "them" agrees with the plural antecedents "poems" and "works."

Choice B is incorrect. "This" is a singular pronoun, but its antecedents, "poems" and "works," are plural. Choice C is incorrect. "That" is a singular pronoun, but its antecedents, "poems" and "works," are plural. Choice D is incorrect. "It" is a singular pronoun, but its antecedents, "poems" and "works," are plural.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Luci Tapahonso is the inaugural poet laureate of the Navajo Nation. Her book *Sáanii Dahataal/The Women Are Singing*—a combination of fiction and memoir, poetry and _____ serves as a testament to her versatility as a writer.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. prose;
- B. prose
- C. prose,
- D. prose—

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. “A combination of fiction and memoir, poetry and prose” is a nonessential supplement, so it needs to be set off from the rest of the sentence with a pair of matching punctuation marks. We already have a dash at the beginning of the supplement, so we need to add a dash at the end of the supplement to match.

Choice A is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. “A combination of fiction and memoir, poetry and prose” is a nonessential supplement, so it needs to be set off from the rest of the sentence with a pair of matching punctuation marks. We already have a dash at the beginning of the supplement, so we need to add a dash at the end of the supplement to match. Choice B is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. “A combination of fiction and memoir, poetry and prose” is a nonessential supplement, so it needs to be set off from the rest of the sentence with a pair of matching punctuation marks. We already have a dash at the beginning of the supplement, so we need to add a dash at the end of the supplement to match. Choice C is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. “A combination of fiction and memoir, poetry and prose” is a nonessential supplement, so it needs to be set off from the rest of the sentence with a pair of matching punctuation marks. We already have a dash at the beginning of the supplement, so we need to add a dash at the end of the supplement to match.

Question ID: b15724fc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

American writer Edwidge Danticat, who emigrated from Haiti in 1981, has won acclaim for her powerful short stories, novels, and _____ her lyrical yet unflinching depictions of her native country’s turbulent history, writer Robert Antoni has compared Danticat to Nobel Prize–winning novelist Toni Morrison.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. essays, praising
- B. essays and praising
- C. essays praising
- D. essays. Praising

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period after “essays” is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence (“American...essays”) and another (“praising...Morrison”). The participial phrase beginning with “Praising” modifies the subject of the second sentence, “writer Robert Antoni.”

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice B is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction “and” can’t be used in this way to join sentences. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences (“American...essays” and “Praising...Morrison”) are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Scientists believe that, unlike most other species of barnacle, turtle barnacles (*Chelonibia testudinari*) can dissolve the cement-like secretions they use to attach _____ to a sea turtle shell, enabling the barnacles to move short distances across the shell’s surface.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. it
- B. themselves
- C. them
- D. itself

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is pronoun-antecedent agreement. The plural reflexive pronoun “themselves” agrees in number with the plural antecedent “turtle barnacles,” correctly indicating what is attached to a sea turtle shell.

Choice A is incorrect because the singular pronoun “it” doesn’t agree in number with the plural antecedent “turtle barnacles.” Choice C is incorrect because it results in an unclear and confusing sentence. In this context, it’s unclear what the plural pronoun “them” refers to. Choice D is incorrect because the singular reflexive pronoun “itself” doesn’t agree in number with the plural antecedent “turtle barnacles.”

Question ID: e2759b92

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Occupying a significant part of modern-day Nigeria, the Kingdom of Benin was one of the major powers in West Africa between the thirteenth and nineteenth centuries. It _____ ruled by Oba Ewuare I from 1440 to 1473.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. is
- B. will be
- C. has been
- D. was

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verbs to express tense in a sentence. In this choice, the past tense verb “was ruled” correctly indicates that Oba Ewuare I ruled the Kingdom of Benin in the distant past (from 1440 to 1473). This past tense verb choice is consistent with the other past tense verb (“was”) used to describe the Kingdom of Benin.

Choice A is incorrect because the present tense verb “is ruled” doesn’t indicate that Oba Ewuare I ruled the Kingdom of Benin in the distant past. Choice B is incorrect because the future tense verb “will be ruled” doesn’t indicate that Oba Ewuare I ruled the Kingdom of Benin in the distant past. Choice C is incorrect because the present perfect tense verb “has been ruled” doesn’t indicate that Oba Ewuare I ruled the Kingdom of Benin in the distant past.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Mia Heavener’s 2019 novel *Under Nushagak Bluff*, which takes place in a mid-twentieth-century rural Alaskan fishing _____ the story of three Yup’ik women who grapple with the rise of commercial fisheries and other changes affecting their community.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. village. Tells
- B. village tells
- C. village: tells
- D. village, tells

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. The comma after “village” pairs with the comma after “*Under Nushagak Bluff*” to separate the supplementary relative clause (“which...village”) from the rest of the sentence. This supplementary relative clause functions to provide additional information about the setting of Heavener’s novel, and the pair of commas indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in two rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragments, one beginning with “Mia” and the other beginning with “tells.” Choice B is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary relative clause (“which...village”) from the rest of the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because a colon can’t be paired with a comma in this way to separate the supplementary relative clause (“which...village”) from the rest of the sentence. A colon can be used between two main clauses or a main clause and supplement, but here there is no main clause on either side of the colon.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

The pedagogy of the Suzuki method is rooted in several central _____ by Japanese violinist Shinichi Suzuki, who sought to parallel the linguistic learning environment, the method emphasizes playing instruments from a very young age and teaches students as young as three to play simple classical pieces such as “March in G.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. tenets. Developed
- B. tenets developed
- C. tenets that, developed
- D. tenets, developed

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. This choice correctly uses a period to mark the boundary between one sentence ("The pedagogy...tenets") and another ("Developed...‘March in G’"). The participial phrase "developed by Japanese violinist Shinichi Suzuki" modifies the subject of the next sentence, "the method."

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences ("The pedagogy...tenets" and "Developed...‘March in G’") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it creates a confusing and illogical sentence structure. The relative pronoun "that" followed by a comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Consider the mechanics of the pinhole camera: light passes through a small hole, resulting in a focused projected image. A ray diagram reveals how this _____ the hole's small size restricts light to a single ray, all light passing through the hole can only arrive at a single destination, eliminating diffraction and ensuring a clear image.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. works because
- B. works. Because
- C. works, it's because
- D. works: it's because

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used to correctly mark the boundary between one sentence ("A ray...works") and another ("Because...image").

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two sentences ("A ray...works" and "Because...image") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Since the contraction "it's" creates a main clause, the comma after "single ray" can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between two main clauses ("it's...ray" and "all light...image").

Question ID: 594b4a94

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

The field of geological oceanography owes much to American ____ Marie Tharp, a pioneering oceanographic cartographer whose detailed topographical maps of the ocean floor and its multiple rift valleys helped garner acceptance for the theories of plate tectonics and continental drift.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. geologist,
- B. geologist
- C. geologist;
- D. geologist:

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “Marie tharp” is essential information that completes the first clause — the first clause doesn’t function without it. So we don’t want to separate it with punctuation.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error. “The field of geological oceanography owes much to American geologist” is unclear: which geologist are we talking about? We need the “Marie Tharp” for clarity, which means it’s essential information and should not be separated by a comma. Choice C is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error. “The field of geological oceanography owes much to American geologist” is unclear: which geologist are we talking about? We need the “Marie Tharp” for clarity, which means it’s essential information and should not be separated by a semicolon. Choice D is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error. “The field of geological oceanography owes much to American geologist” is unclear: which geologist are we talking about? We need the “Marie Tharp” for clarity, which means it’s essential information and should not be separated by a colon.

Question ID: 5ad2a12c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

The First Folio, published in 1623, is the first collection of William Shakespeare's plays. The collection _____ 18 plays that might otherwise have been lost, such as *Julius Caesar* and *Macbeth*.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. to be including
- B. including
- C. to include
- D. includes

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. A main clause requires a finite (tensed) verb to perform the action of the subject (in this case, "the collection"), and this choice supplies the finite present tense verb "includes" to indicate what is in the collection.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite to-infinitive "to be including" doesn't supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle "including" doesn't supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice C is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite to-infinitive "to include" doesn't supply the main clause with a finite verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

In her large-scale sculpture *Casa-Is/a*, artist Edra Soto included references to her childhood in Puerto Rico. For example, the sculpture’s steel panels have a crisscrossing pattern inspired by the iron gates _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Soto would see in her neighborhood?
- B. Soto would see in her neighborhood.
- C. would Soto see in her neighborhood.
- D. would Soto see in her neighborhood?

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is end-of-sentence punctuation. This choice correctly uses a period to punctuate a declarative sentence ("For example...neighborhood").

Choice A is incorrect. It’s unconventional to use a question mark in this way to punctuate a declarative sentence. Choice C is incorrect. The structure requires a declarative clause at the end of the sentence that states where Soto saw the steel panels, not an incomplete interrogative clause that asks a direct question, such as "would Soto see in her neighborhood." Choice D is incorrect. The structure requires a period and a declarative clause at the end of the sentence that states where Soto saw the steel panels, not an incomplete interrogative clause asking a direct question, such as "would Soto see in her neighborhood?"

Question ID: 2fd05c15

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

In crafting her fantasy fiction, Nigerian-born British author Helen Oyeyemi has drawn inspiration from the classic nineteenth-century fairy tales of the Brothers Grimm. Her 2014 novel *Boy, Snow, Bird*, for instance, is a complex retelling of the story of Snow White, while her 2019 novel _____ offers a delicious twist on the classic tale of Hansel and Gretel.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. *Gingerbread*—
- B. *Gingerbread*,
- C. *Gingerbread*
- D. *Gingerbread*:

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between a subject and a verb. When, as in this case, a subject (“her 2019 novel *Gingerbread*”) is immediately followed by a verb (“offers”), no punctuation is needed.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Unsupervised machine learning is an approach that computer scientists like Nina Miolane use to engineer artificial intelligence technologies. It involves training computer algorithms to organize unlabeled data sets. Multitask learning is another approach. _____ involves training computer models to perform multiple tasks at the same time.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Those
- B. They
- C. It
- D. Some

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is pronoun-antecedent agreement. The singular pronoun "it" agrees in number with the singular antecedent "multitask learning" and clearly indicates what multitask learning involves.

Choice A is incorrect because the plural demonstrative pronoun "those" doesn't agree in number with the singular antecedent "multitask learning." Choice B is incorrect because the plural pronoun "they" doesn't agree in number with the singular antecedent "multitask learning." Choice D is incorrect because the indefinite pronoun "some" is ambiguous in this context; the resulting sentence leaves unclear what exactly "involves training computer models."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

In the 2011 documentary *The Barber of Birmingham*, civil rights activist James Armstrong recounts how his barbershop in Birmingham, Alabama, _____ as a political hub for members of the Black community during the 1950s.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. serving
- B. having served
- C. served
- D. to serve

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. Relative clauses, such as the one beginning with "how," require a finite (tensed) verb, a verb that can function as the main verb of a clause. This choice correctly supplies the clause with the finite past tense verb "served."

Choice A is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle "serving" doesn't supply the clause with a finite verb. Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle "having served" doesn't supply the clause with a finite verb. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite to-infinitive "to serve" doesn't supply the clause with a finite verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Light of Truth is a bronze and marble sculpture by artist Richard Hunt. It honors civil rights icon Ida B. Wells. The sculpture _____ in a tree-lined plaza in Chicago, just a few blocks from where Wells lived.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. are standing
- B. have been standing
- C. stands
- D. were standing

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "stands" agrees in number with the singular subject "sculpture." Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb "are standing" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "sculpture." Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "have been standing" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "sculpture." Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb "were standing" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "sculpture."

Question ID: c88d6301

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

In the 1980s, Latino filmmakers Luis Valdez, Gregory Nava, and Ramón Menéndez helped expand on-screen representation of Latino Americans with the films *Zoot Suit* _____ and *Stand and Deliver* (1988), respectively.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. (1981) *El Norte* (1983),
- B. (1981)—*El Norte* (1983)—
- C. (1981), *El Norte* (1983),
- D. (1981) *El Norte* (1983)

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of items in a series. The comma after “(1981)” is used conventionally to separate the first and second items in the series, and the comma after “(1983)” is used conventionally to separate the second and third items in the series.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the first and second items in the series. Choice B is incorrect because dashes can’t be used in this way to separate items in a simple series. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the items in the series.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

As jazz singer Sarah Vaughan honed her vocal abilities—acquiring a sophisticated timbre and precise control over pitch, dynamics, and _____ she earned comparisons to opera icon Leontyne Price, one of her personal heroes. The comparisons highlight how Vaughan, a jazz star, had transcended genre boundaries with her singing prowess.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. vibrato:
- B. vibrato,
- C. vibrato—
- D. vibrato

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. The dash after “vibrato” pairs with the dash after “abilities” to separate the supplementary element (“acquiring...vibrato”) from the rest of the sentence. This supplementary element functions to describe the vocal abilities Vaughan developed, and the pair of dashes indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because a colon can’t be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice B is incorrect because a comma can’t be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence.

Question ID: 97e7bedc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

Oyster mushrooms typically get their nutrients from the damp logs on which they grow, but the fungi are also carnivorous, with the ability to kill and consume microscopic worms known as nematodes. As researcher Yen-Ping Hsueh has shown, the mushrooms release a toxin that is deadly to nematodes that _____ in contact with it.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. has come
- B. comes
- C. is coming
- D. come

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The plural verb "come" agrees in number with the plural subject "nematodes." Choice A is incorrect because the singular verb "has come" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "nematodes." Choice B is incorrect because the singular verb "comes" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "nematodes." Choice C is incorrect because the singular verb "is coming" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "nematodes."

Question ID: c8540a5b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Swedish scientists Eva Engvall and Peter Perlmann developed a method for measuring the concentration of different proteins in a biological sample. Their _____ ELISA (enzyme-linked immunosorbent assay), is used to detect and measure proteins that indicate the presence of certain diseases.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. method (called
- B. method—called
- C. method, called
- D. method called

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of a supplementary element within a sentence. The comma after “method” pairs with the comma after the closing parenthesis to separate the supplementary element “called ELISA (enzyme-linked immunosorbent assay)” from the rest of the sentence. This supplementary element functions to identify the name of Engvall and Perlmann’s method, and the pair of commas indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because an opening parenthesis can’t be paired with a comma to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice B is incorrect because a dash can’t be paired with a comma to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence.

Question ID: e15c50b2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

A standard Argo float, a type of autonomous robot, measures temperature and salinity in the upper regions of ice-free oceans. More advanced floats can measure a wider range of _____ and monitor seasonal ice zones.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. variables: travel to greater depths
- B. variables, travel to greater depths,
- C. variables travel to greater depths,
- D. variables, travel to greater depths;

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of items in a series. The comma after “variables” is used conventionally to separate the first and second items in the series, and the comma after “depths” is used conventionally to separate the second and third items.

Choice A is incorrect because a colon can’t be used in this way to separate items in a simple series. Choice C is incorrect because a comma is needed after “variables” to separate the first and second items in the series. Choice D is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to separate items in a simple series.

Question ID: 988c78eb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Former First Lady of the United States Eleanor Roosevelt and Indian activist and educator Hansa Mehta were instrumental in drafting the United Nations’ Universal Declaration of Human Rights, a document that _____ the basic freedoms to which all people are entitled.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. have outlined
- B. were outlining
- C. outlines
- D. outline

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb “outlines” agrees in number with the singular subject “document.”

Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb “have outlined” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “document.” Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb “were outlining” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “document.” Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb “outline” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “document.”

Question ID: 261f4ca6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

The capital city of the Aztec empire, Tenochtitlan, was built on an island in a lake. Because of the marshy conditions, the Aztec people _____ floating farms called “chinampas.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. created
- B. created:
- C. created,
- D. created;

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a verb and its object. No punctuation is needed between the verb “created” and its object “floating farms called ‘chinampas.’” The object helps complete the idea of the verb—in this case, it explains what the Aztec people created—and any punctuation between the two results in an ungrammatical sentence.

Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the verb and its object. Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the verb and its object. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the verb and its object.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Fans of science fiction will _____ multiple references to classic sci-fi stories in Janelle Mon  e’s song lyrics, including her recurring nods to the plot of the 1927 sci-fi film *Metropolis*.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. appreciate the
- B. appreciate. The
- C. appreciate, the
- D. appreciate: the

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested here is punctuation between a verb and object. No punctuation is needed between the verb ("appreciate") and its object ("the multiple references..."). The object helps complete the idea of the verb—in this case, it explains what fans of science fiction will appreciate—and any punctuation between the two results in an ungrammatical sentence.

Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the verb and its object. Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the verb and its object. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the verb and its object.

Question ID: fdb16e20

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Quantum particles of light—photons—provide an unhackable means of transmitting encryption keys over networks, as attempts to observe particles in quantum states will invariably alter the particles _____ dismantle any information they transmit.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. and in the process,
- B. and, in the process,
- C. and in the process—
- D. and, in the process

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. This choice uses paired punctuation in the form of two commas to set off the nonessential phrase "in the process."

Choice A is incorrect. The phrase "in the process" is a nonessential element and needs to be set off with paired punctuation. We need a comma after "and" to match the one after "process." Choice C is incorrect. The phrase "in the process" is a nonessential element and needs to be set off with paired punctuation, so we would need a dash after "and" to match the one following "process." Choice D is incorrect. The phrase "in the process" is a nonessential element and needs to be set off with paired punctuation. We would need a comma after "process" to match the one following "and."

Question ID: 7e37affc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

That the geographic center of North America lay in the state of North Dakota was conceded by all _____ establishing its precise coordinates proved more divisive.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. involved:
- B. involved,
- C. involved
- D. involved;

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice uses a semicolon in a conventional way to join the first main clause ("That the...involved") and the second main clause ("establishing...divisive"). Further, the semicolon is the most appropriate choice when joining two separate, parallel statements, such as here, where the information following the semicolon contrasts with the information before.

Choice A is incorrect because placing a colon after "involved" illogically indicates that the information in the second main clause (the precise location was the subject of disagreement) explains or amplifies the information in the previous main clause (the general location was agreed upon by all). Instead, the information in the second clause contrasts with the previous information. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can't be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

In knot theory (the mathematical study of curved, closed loops), knots are characterized by their crossing numbers—that is, the number of times the knotted thread crosses over itself. The trefoil knot and the figure-eight knot, each with a crossing number below five, _____ among the simplest possible knots with the fewest number of crossings.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. was
- B. are
- C. has been
- D. is

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The plural verb "are" agrees in number with the plural compound subject "the trefoil knot and the figure-eight knot." The two types of knots joined by "and" function as a plural subject and thus require a plural verb.

Choice A is incorrect because the singular verb "was" doesn't agree in number with the plural compound subject "the trefoil knot and the figure-eight knot." Choice C is incorrect because the singular verb "has been" doesn't agree in number with the plural compound subject "the trefoil knot and the figure-eight knot." Choice D is incorrect because the singular verb "is" doesn't agree in number with the plural compound subject "the trefoil knot and the figure-eight knot."

Question ID: 4565a53c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Lucía Michel of the University of Chile observed that alkaline soils contain an insoluble form of iron that blueberry plants cannot absorb, thus inhibiting blueberry growth. If these plants were grown in alkaline soil alongside grasses that aid in iron solubilization, _____ Michel was determined to find out.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. could the blueberries thrive.
- B. the blueberries could thrive.
- C. the blueberries could thrive?
- D. could the blueberries thrive?

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is end-of-sentence punctuation. This choice correctly uses a question mark to punctuate the interrogative clause “could the blueberries thrive,” which asks a direct question at the end of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because a period can’t be used in this way to punctuate an interrogative clause, such as “could the blueberries thrive,” at the end of a sentence. Choice B is incorrect because the context requires an interrogative clause. The declarative clause “the blueberries could thrive” incorrectly indicates that it was known that the blueberries could thrive in alkaline soil, whereas Michel had yet to find this out. Choice C is incorrect because a question mark can’t be used in this way to punctuate a declarative clause, such as “the blueberries could thrive,” at the end of a sentence.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

Featuring jagged peaks of black ink surrounded by hazy swirls of blue and green paint, Zhang Daqian’s 1983 painting *Panorama of Mount Lu* is inspired by the tradition of *qinglǔ shanshui*, a type of Chinese landscape painting _____ by the use of blue and green hues to depict ethereal, otherworldly landscapes.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. has been characterized
- B. will be characterized
- C. characterized
- D. is characterized

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The nonfinite past participle "characterized" is correctly used within a supplementary element that modifies the main clause "Zhang...*shanshui*," defining *qinglǔ shanshui* and explaining some of its identifying traits.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Using the finite present perfect tense verb "has been characterized" creates a second main clause in the sentence, and the two main clauses can’t be joined in this way by only the comma before "a type." Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Using the finite future tense verb "will be characterized" creates a second main clause in the sentence, and the two main clauses can’t be joined in this way by only the comma before "a type." Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Using the finite present tense verb "is characterized" creates a second main clause in the sentence, and the two main clauses can’t be joined in this way by only the comma before "a type."

Question ID: 7a0d9031

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

In many of her landscape paintings from the 1970s and 1980s, Lebanese American artist Etel Adnan worked to capture the essence of California’s fog-shrouded Mount Tamalpais region through abstraction, using splotches of color to represent the area’s features. Interestingly, the triangle representing the mountain itself _____ among the few defined figures in her paintings.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. are
- B. have been
- C. were
- D. is

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject–verb agreement. The singular verb “is” agrees in number with the singular subject “the triangle.”

Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb “are” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “the triangle.” Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb “have been” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “the triangle.” Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb “were” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “the triangle.”

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Award-winning cinematographer James Wong Howe was known for his innovative filming techniques. While filming a boxing match for the movie *Body and Soul* _____ Howe had a handheld camera operator wear roller skates. This allowed the operator to move smoothly around actors in a boxing ring, creating an immersive experience for viewers.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. (1947), and
- B. (1947),
- C. (1947) and
- D. (1947)

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between a supplementary element and a main clause. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the supplementary phrase (“While...1947”), which indicates when the action occurred, and the main clause (“Howe had a handheld camera operator wear roller skates”).

Choice A is incorrect because a comma paired with the conjunction “and” can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between the supplementary element (“While...1947”) and the main clause (“Howe...skates”). Choice C is incorrect because the conjunction “and” can’t be used in this way to join the supplementary element (“While...1947”) and the main clause (“Howe...skates”). Choice D is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the supplementary element and the main clause with appropriate punctuation.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

In Puerto Rico, it’s not unusual for a city or town to be known by a nickname that corresponds to one of its notable features, like landscape, climate, famous residents, or chief export. For example, the Puerto Rican municipality of Aibonito is well known for its lush _____ this distinction has earned it the fitting nickname of “the Garden of Puerto Rico.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. greenery
- B. greenery,
- C. greenery and
- D. greenery;

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between two main clauses. “Aibonito is well known for its lush greenery” and “this distinction has earned it the fitting nickname...” are both complete main clauses; a semicolon correctly joins them while signaling a close logical connection.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice C is incorrect. When coordinating two longer main clauses such as these, it’s conventional to use a comma before the coordinating conjunction.

Question ID: d46ac7e7

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

A second-generation Japanese American, Wataru Misaka _____ in World War II (1941-45) and won two amateur national basketball championships at the University of Utah when he joined the New York Knicks for the 1947-48 season, becoming the first non-white basketball player in the US’s top professional league.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. already served
- B. was already serving
- C. already serves
- D. had already served

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. Misaka served in World War II before he joined the New York Knicks in 1947. To show that a past occurrence took place before another past occurrence, we need to use “had” + the past tense form of the verb. This is called the past perfect tense.

Choice A is incorrect. Misaka served in World War II before he joined the Knicks. Both events are in the past, but his service in World War II happened earlier, so we need a verb that makes it clear that his service (and the two national championships) had ended by the time he joined the Knicks. Choice B is incorrect. “Was already serving” forms the continuous past tense, which we use when we’re showing a past action that was ongoing. Misaka served in World War II before he joined the Knicks. Both events are in the past, but they’re not happening at the same time, so we shouldn’t use the continuous past tense here. Choice C is incorrect. Misaka served in World War II in the past, so we shouldn’t use the present tense “serves.”

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Winding through the ice atop Norway’s Jotunheim Mountains is the Lendbreen pass, an ancient route that was used by hunters, farmers, traders, and travelers in the Middle Ages before eventually falling into disuse. Recently, archeologists have _____ knives, horseshoes, wool tunics, and thousands of other artifacts from the icy pass.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. unearthed:
- B. unearthed,
- C. unearthed—
- D. unearthed

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. No punctuation should separate the verb "unearthed" and its objects (i.e, what was "unearthed"): "knives, horseshoes, wool tunics, and thousands of other artifacts."

Choice A is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error, separating the verb "unearthed" from its objects (i.e, what was "unearthed") with a colon. Choice B is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error, separating the verb "unearthed" from its objects (i.e, what was "unearthed") with a comma. Choice C is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error, separating the verb "unearthed" from its objects (i.e, what was "unearthed") with a dash.

Question ID: 2b6e1c06

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

A government body officially known as the Althing, _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. the world’s oldest parliaments include one which first met in 930 CE, Iceland’s.
- B. Iceland’s parliament is one of the oldest in the world, first meeting in 930 CE.
- C. the first meeting of one of the oldest parliaments in the world, Iceland’s, was in 930 CE.
- D. 930 CE was the year when Iceland’s parliament, one of the oldest parliaments in the world, first met.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase "Iceland’s parliament" the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase "a government body officially known as the Althing." In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that Iceland’s parliament—and not another noun in the sentence—is the government body known as the Althing.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase "the world’s oldest parliaments" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the world’s oldest parliaments are a government body known as the Althing. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase "the first meeting" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the first meeting of Iceland’s parliament was a government body known as the Althing. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase "930 CE" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the year 930 CE is a government body known as the Althing.

Question ID: 3595a991

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

In 1930, Japanese American artist Chiura Obata depicted the natural beauty of Yosemite National Park in two memorable woodcuts: *Evening at Carl Inn* and *Lake Basin in the High Sierra*. In 2019, _____ exhibited alongside 150 of Obata’s other works in a single-artist show at the Smithsonian American Art Museum.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. it was
- B. they were
- C. this was
- D. some were

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is pronoun–antecedent agreement. The plural pronoun “they” agrees in number with the plural antecedent “woodcuts” and clearly identifies what was exhibited at the Smithsonian American Art Museum.

Choice A is incorrect because the singular pronoun “it” doesn’t agree in number with the plural antecedent “woodcuts.” Choice C is incorrect because the singular pronoun “this” doesn’t agree in number with the plural antecedent “woodcuts.” Choice D is incorrect because the plural pronoun “some” is illogical in this context (referring to “some” of two woodcuts).

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

The city of Amsterdam partnered with consultants to develop Public Eye—an ethical AI-powered crowd-monitoring _____ video streamed from cameras in heavily touristed areas, the AI algorithm determines crowd sizes without, in the interest of protecting individuals’ privacy, retaining the footage.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. system—analyzing
- B. system, analyzing
- C. system. Analyzing
- D. system analyzing

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence ("The city...system") and another ("Analyzing...footage"). The participial phrase beginning with "analyzing" modifies the subject of the second sentence, "the AI algorithm."

Choice A is incorrect. Placing a dash before "analyzing" creates a confusing and ambiguous modifying element ("analyzing...areas") and a comma splice between "areas" and "the AI algorithm." (A comma can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences.) Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences ("The city...system" and "analyzing...footage") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Journalists have dubbed Gil Scott-Heron the “godfather of rap,” a title that has appeared in hundreds of articles about him since the 1990s. Scott-Heron himself resisted the godfather _____ feeling that it didn’t encapsulate his devotion to the broader African American blues music tradition as well as “bluesologist,” the moniker he preferred.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- Answer**
- A. nickname, however
 - B. nickname, however;
 - C. nickname, however,
 - D. nickname; however,

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a main clause and two supplementary elements. In this choice, the commas after “nickname” and “however” are correctly used to separate the supplementary adverb “however” from the main clause (“Scott-Heron...nickname”) on one side and the supplementary participial phrase (“feeling...bluesologist”) on the other.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the supplementary adverb “however” and the supplementary phrase (“feeling...bluesologist”). Choice B is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the supplementary adverb “however” and the supplementary phrase (“feeling...bluesologist”). Choice D is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the main clause (“Scott-Heron...nickname”) and the supplementary word and phrase (“however” and “feeling...bluesologist”). Moreover, placing the semicolon after “nickname” illogically signals that the following information (Scott-Heron’s feeling that the nickname didn’t encapsulate his devotion to the blues tradition) is contrary to the information in the previous clause (Scott-Heron’s resistance to the nickname).

Question ID: e31b0056

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Mary Madden of Ohio _____ a fierce advocate of women’s voting rights in the late 1800s. The dedication of Madden and her fellow activists was rewarded in 1920, when the Nineteenth Amendment to the US Constitution guaranteed American women the right to vote.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. are
- B. was
- C. have been
- D. were

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "was" agrees in number with the singular subject "Mary Madden of Ohio." Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb "are" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "Mary Madden of Ohio." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "have been" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "Mary Madden of Ohio." Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb "were" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "Mary Madden of Ohio."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

When using a search engine, many people click just the first one or two results. Click restraint is the practice of scanning a search results page and evaluating what you see before deciding which link _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. should you choose.
- B. you should choose?
- C. should you choose?
- D. you should choose.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is end-of-sentence punctuation. This choice correctly uses a period to punctuate a declarative sentence that ends with an indirect question (“which link you should choose.”)

Choice A is incorrect. The structure requires a declarative clause that presents an indirect question about what is evaluated in click restraint, not an interrogative clause that presents a direct question, such as “which link should you choose.” Choice B is incorrect. It’s unconventional to use a question mark in this way to punctuate a declarative clause that presents an indirect question, such as “which link you should choose.” Choice C is incorrect. The structure requires a declarative clause that presents an indirect question about what is evaluated in click restraint, not an interrogative clause that presents a direct question, such as “which link should you choose.”

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

If simple sugars such as ribose and glycolaldehyde _____ Earth from elsewhere and survived impact—a possibility astrophysicist Nicolle Zellner outlined in a 2020 study—the sugars could have reacted with other molecules that were already present on the planet to form the nucleotides that are the structural components of RNA and DNA.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. reach
- B. had reached
- C. will reach
- D. are reaching

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verbs to express tense. In this choice, the past perfect verb “had reached” is used correctly to describe a past action that was completed before another action in the past. Specifically, in this hypothetical scenario about the origins of RNA and DNA on Earth, the simple sugars had to have reached Earth before they could react with other molecules on the planet.

Choice A is incorrect because the present tense verb “reach” doesn’t indicate that the simple sugars reached Earth before reacting with other molecules on the planet. Choice C is incorrect because the future tense verb “will reach” doesn’t indicate that the simple sugars reached Earth before reacting with other molecules on the planet. Choice D is incorrect because the present progressive verb “are reaching” doesn’t indicate that the simple sugars reached Earth before reacting with other molecules on the planet.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

In early 1700s England, it was legal for shops to sell prints of artists’ engravings without the artists’ permission. This changed in 1735 with the passage of the Engravers’ Copyright ____ gave engravers control over the distribution and sale of all prints made from their designs.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Act, which
- B. Act; which
- C. Act. Which
- D. Act

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation between a main clause and a supplementary element. In this choice, the comma is used correctly to mark the boundary between the main clause ("This...Act") and the supplementary relative clause ("which...designs") that provides additional information about the Engravers’ Copyright Act.

Choice B is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between a main clause and a supplementary relative clause. A semicolon is conventionally used to join two main clauses, and "which...designs" isn’t a main clause. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment. Choice D is incorrect. Joining the main clause and the additional information about the Engravers’ Copyright Act ("gave...designs") without the comma and relative pronoun "which" results in a confusing and ungrammatical sentence.

Question ID: d2cf0e11

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

Inventor John Friedman created a prototype of the first flexible straw by inserting a screw into a paper straw and, using dental floss, binding the straw tightly around the _____. When the floss and screw were removed, the resulting corrugations in the paper allowed the straw to bend easily over the edge of a glass.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. screw’s thread’s.
- B. screws’ threads.
- C. screw’s threads.
- D. screws threads’.

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of plural and possessive nouns. The singular possessive noun “screw’s” and the plural noun “threads” correctly indicate that there is only one screw and it has multiple threads.

Choice A is incorrect because the context requires the plural noun “threads,” not the singular possessive noun “thread’s.” Choice B is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive noun “screw’s,” not the plural possessive noun “screws’.” Choice D is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive noun “screw’s” and the plural noun “threads,” not the plural noun “screws” or the plural possessive noun “threads.”

Question ID: 1d971f75

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Photographer Ansel Adams’s landscape portraits are iconic pieces of American art. However, many of the _____ of landscapes were intended not as art but as marketing; a concessions company at Yosemite National Park had hired Adams to take pictures of the park for restaurant menus and brochures.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. photographer’s early photo’s
- B. photographers early photo’s
- C. photographer’s early photos
- D. photographers early photos

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. There’s only one photographer (Adams), and the photos are his, so the singular possessive "photographer’s" is correct. There’s more than one photo, and nothing belongs to the photos, so the simple plural "photos" is correct.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice uses the singular possessive "photo’s," which isn’t correct. There’s more than one photo, and they don’t possess anything, so the noun should be the simple plural "photos." Choice B is incorrect. This choice uses the simple plural "photographers" and the singular possessive "photo’s," which aren’t correct. There’s only one photographer (Adams) and there’s more than one photo. Choice D is incorrect. This choice uses the simple plural "photographers," which isn’t correct. There’s only one photographer (Adams).

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Forming extensive networks via mycorrhizal association—that is, a symbiotic relationship between plants and fungi—_____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. it is the entanglement of pine trees’ roots and the fungus *Tricholoma matsutake*’s fungal hyphae that makes nutrient transport possible.
- B. the transport of nutrients is possible through the entanglement of pine trees’ roots and the fungus *Tricholoma matsutake*’s fungal hyphae.
- C. nutrients can be transported through the entanglement of pine trees’ roots and the fungus *Tricholoma matsutake*’s fungal hyphae.
- D. pine trees and the fungus *Tricholoma matsutake* can transport nutrients through their entangled tree roots and fungal hyphae.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase "pine trees and the fungus *Tricholoma matsutake*" the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase "forming...association." In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that the pine trees and fungus—and not another noun in the sentence—are forming the networks.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the it-cleft "it is" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically and confusingly suggests that "it" is forming extensive networks. Furthermore, it’s not conventional to follow a long introductory modifying element with an it-cleft construction because it results in an unnecessarily wordy and confusing sentence, such as this. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of "the transport of nutrients" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the transport of nutrients is forming extensive networks. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of "nutrients" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that nutrients are forming extensive networks.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Each year in the fall, when the weather starts to cool in the northern hemisphere, millions of North American monarch butterflies journey south. Searching for food and warmer habitats, they _____ thousands of miles—from as far north as Canada all the way down to Mexico—on this annual migration.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. flew
- B. were flying
- C. had flown
- D. fly

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verbs to express tense. In this choice, the present tense verb “fly” is consistent with the other present tense verb (“journey”) used to describe the butterflies’ yearly migration. Together, these simple present tense verbs correctly indicate that the migration is a current, yearly occurrence.

Choice A is incorrect. The simple past tense verb “flew” isn’t consistent with the other present tense verb used to describe the butterflies’ yearly migration. Choice B is incorrect. The past progressive tense verb “were flying” isn’t consistent with the other present tense verb used to describe the butterflies’ yearly migration. Choice C is incorrect. The past perfect tense verb “had flown” isn’t consistent with the other present tense verb used to describe the butterflies’ yearly migration.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

How do scientists determine what foods were eaten by extinct hominins such as Neanderthals? In the past, researchers were limited to studying the marks found on the fossilized teeth of skeletons, but in 2017 a team led by Laura Weyrich of the Australian Centre for Ancient DNA tried something _____ the DNA found in Neanderthals’ fossilized dental plaque.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. new: sequencing
- B. new; sequencing
- C. new, sequencing:
- D. new. Sequencing

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. “A team...tried something new” is an independent clause leading to an explanation of what the new thing was. A colon can only be used at the end of an independent clause, and typically introduces further explanation that expands upon the first clause, which makes a colon the perfect choice here.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice results in a punctuation error. “Sequencing...dental plaque” can’t stand on its own as a sentence, and so it can’t be linked to the independent clause “a team...tried something new” with a semicolon. Only two independent clauses can be connected in this way. Choice C is incorrect. This choice results in a punctuation error. If “sequencing” is included in the first clause, it can no longer stand on its own as a complete idea. Since a colon can only come at the end of an independent clause, using one in this way creates an error. Choice D is incorrect. This choice results in a sentence fragment. “Sequencing...dental plaque” can’t stand on its own as a sentence.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Oglala Lakota poet Layli Long Soldier’s star quilt poems offer an unusually open-ended reading experience. With _____ eight panels of text stitched together in the shape of a traditional eight-pointed Lakota star quilt, the poems present viewers with a seemingly infinite number of ways to read them.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. their
- B. it’s
- C. they’re
- D. its

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of possessive determiners. The plural possessive determiner "their" agrees in number with the plural noun "the poems," thus indicating that the poems had eight panels of text stitched together in the shape of a traditional eight-pointed Lakota star quilt.

Choice B is incorrect because "it’s" is the contraction for "it is" or "it has," not a possessive determiner. Choice C is incorrect because "they’re" is the contraction for "they are," not a possessive determiner. Choice D is incorrect because the singular possessive determiner "its" doesn’t agree in number with the plural noun "the poems."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Before the Erie Canal was completed in 1825, transporting goods by wagon between New York City and the Midwest took up to forty-five days and cost one hundred dollars per ton. By linking the Hudson River to Lake _____ canal reduced transport time to nine days and cut costs to six dollars per ton.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Erie; the
- B. Erie (the
- C. Erie, the
- D. Erie: the

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between a supplementary phrase and a main clause. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the introductory supplementary phrase (“By linking the Hudson River to Lake Erie”), which identifies how the canal reduced transport time, and the main clause (“the canal reduced transport time to nine days and cut costs to six dollars per ton”).

Choice A is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between a supplementary phrase (“By...Erie”) and the main clause (“the canal...ton”). Choice B is incorrect because an open parenthesis can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between a supplementary phrase (“By...Erie”) and the main clause (“the canal...ton”). Choice D is incorrect because a colon can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between an introductory supplementary phrase (“By...Erie”) and the main clause (“the canal...ton”).

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

During the English neoclassical period (1660–1789), many writers imitated the epic poetry and satires of ancient Greece and Rome. They were not the first in England to adopt the literary modes of classical _____ some of the most prominent figures of the earlier Renaissance period were also influenced by ancient Greek and Roman literature.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. antiquity, however
- B. antiquity, however,
- C. antiquity, however;
- D. antiquity; however,

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of a supplementary phrase following a clause. This choice uses a comma to separate the supplementary adverb phrase "however" from the independent clause it modifies ("They...antiquity") and uses a semicolon to join the first independent clause ("They...antiquity") and the second independent clause ("some...literature"). Further, placing the semicolon after "however" indicates that the information in the clause that this is part of (that neoclassical writers were not the first to adopt classical literary modes) is contrary to what might be assumed from the information in the previous sentence (that the neoclassical writers were unique in imitating classical epic poetry and satires).

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary after "however" between the two independent clauses with appropriate punctuation. Choice B is incorrect because the comma after "however" can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between the two independent clauses. Choice D is incorrect because placing the semicolon after "antiquity" illogically indicates that the information in the clause that this is part of (that prominent Renaissance figures were also influenced by classical literature) is contrary to the information in the previous clause (that neoclassical writers were not the first to adopt classical literary modes).

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

In a rural area along the border between Oklahoma and Texas, amateur astronomers gather each year to observe the night sky at the Okie-Tex Star Party. Like most star parties, Okie-Tex takes place in an area with low light pollution, _____ dark skies and ideal stargazing conditions.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. ensuring
- B. this will ensure
- C. ensures
- D. it ensures

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The nonfinite present participle "ensuring" is correctly used to form a supplementary element that modifies the main clause "Okie-Tex takes place in an area with low light pollution," describing the viewing conditions of the star party.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. The pronoun "this" and the finite future tense verb "will ensure" would add an additional main clause to this sentence, and the comma after "pollution" can't be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice C is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite present tense verb "ensures" can't be used in this way to form a supplementary element to modify the main clause. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. The pronoun "it" and the finite present tense verb "ensures" would add an additional main clause to this sentence, and the comma after "pollution" can't be used in this way to join two main clauses.

Question ID: c8607bdf

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

“Praise Song for the Day,” Elizabeth Alexander’s 2009 inaugural poem, asserts that “We cross dirt roads and highways...to see what’s on the other side.” Alexander’s use of “we” _____ Americans’ collective efforts and shared desire to seek new opportunity.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. evokes
- B. are evoking
- C. have evoked
- D. evoke

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "evokes" agrees in number with the singular subject "Alexander’s use."

Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "are evoking" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "Alexander’s use." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "have evoked" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "Alexander’s use." Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb "evoke" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "Alexander’s use."

Question ID: b6de636f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

At 1,280 meters, the Golden Gate Bridge in the United States is one of the longest suspension bridges in the _____ the Tsing Ma Bridge in China, at 1,377 meters, is even longer.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. world but
- B. world, but,
- C. world,
- D. world, but

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma and the coordinating conjunction “but” to join the first main clause (“At...world”) and the second main clause (“the...longer”).

Choice A is incorrect because when coordinating two main clauses such as these, it’s conventional to use a comma before the coordinating conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because a comma isn’t needed after the conjunction “but.” Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Latin America is known to have dozens, if not hundreds, of popular dance forms. Only five of these dances are included in international ballroom dance ____ rumba, samba, cha-cha-cha, paso doble, and jive—the last of which is grouped with the other Latin dances despite not having Latin roots.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. competitions, however:
- B. competitions, however,
- C. competitions, however;
- D. competitions; however,

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of supplementary elements within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma to separate the supplementary adverb "however" from the preceding main clause ("only...competitions"), and it uses a colon to introduce the list of dances that follows ("rumba...jive"). Further, placing the colon after "however" rather than before indicates that the information in the preceding main clause (only...competitions) is contrary to what might be assumed from the information in the previous sentence (Latin America has many more dance forms).

Choice B is incorrect. The comma after "however" can't be used in this way to introduce a series ("rumba...jive"). Choice C is incorrect because it isn't conventional to use a semicolon in this way to introduce a series of items, such as the list of dances. Choice D is incorrect because placing the semicolon after "competitions" illogically indicates that the following list of five Latin American dances ("rumba...jive") is contrary to the information in the previous clause (only five Latin American dances are included in international ballroom dance competitions).

Question ID: 5aae2475

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Stomata, tiny pore structures in a leaf that absorb gases needed for plant growth, open when guard cells surrounding each pore swell with water. In a pivotal 2007 article, plant cell _____ showed that lipid molecules called phosphatidylinositol phosphates are responsible for signaling guard cells to open stomata.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. biologist, Yuree Lee
- B. biologist Yuree Lee,
- C. biologist Yuree Lee
- D. biologist, Yuree Lee,

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation between titles and proper nouns. No punctuation is needed to offset the proper noun "Yuree Lee" from the title "plant cell biologist" that describes Lee.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed around the proper noun "Yuree Lee." Setting the phrase off with punctuation suggests that it could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn't the case.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

By the time Hawaiian king Kamehameha III _____ the throne, the number of longhorn cattle, first introduced to the islands in 1793, had drastically increased, and so too had the need for *paniolo* (Hawaiian cowboys) to manage the wild herds that then roamed throughout the volcanic terrain.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. ascended
- B. will ascend
- C. ascends
- D. is ascending

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. "Ascended" is in the simple past tense. Since Kamehameha became king in the past, this makes the most sense.

Choice B is incorrect. "Will ascend" is in the future tense, but we wouldn't know about Kamehameha III's ascent if it hadn't happened yet. The information in the sentence, as well as the tense of other verbs, tells us that the events described happened in the past. Choice C is incorrect. "Ascends" is in the simple present tense. However, the information in the sentence, as well as the tense of other verbs, tells us that the events described happened in the past. Choice D is incorrect. "Is ascending" is in the continuous present tense, which we use to show that something is ongoing, but this doesn't make sense here—the information in the sentence, as well as the tense of other verbs, tells us that the events described happened in the past.

Question ID: 4c9a2aee

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

Wanda Diaz-Merced is an astrophysicist who lost her sight when she was young. Diaz-Merced’s condition inspired her to develop software that can translate scientific data into sound. Sound-based tools _____ scientists to detect subtle patterns in data. Such patterns may not be evident in traditional graphs.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. has enabled
- B. enable
- C. is enabling
- D. enables

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The plural verb "enable" agrees in number with the plural subject "sound-based tools."

Choice A is incorrect because the singular verb "has enabled" doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject "sound-based tools." Choice C is incorrect because the singular verb "is enabling" doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject "sound-based tools." Choice D is incorrect because the singular verb "enables" doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject "sound-based tools."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Unique among animal species, humans use our vocal apparatuses primarily for two separate communicative purposes: to talk and to sing. The question of what cross-cultural traits distinguish these distinct modes, and secondarily what pressures led humans to develop them in the first place, _____ neuropsychologist Daniela Sammler’s 2024 study “Signatures of Speech and Song: ‘Universal’ Links despite Cultural Diversity.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. animates
- B. have animated
- C. animate
- D. animating

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "animates" agrees in number with the singular subject "question."

Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "have animated" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "question." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "animate" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "question." Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle "animating" doesn’t supply the clause with a finite verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Nuhād al-Ḥaddād, known as Fairuz, was one of the most beloved Lebanese singers of the twentieth century. Her broad singing repertoire—which included traditional forms, such as the Arabic *qasida* and *maqam*, alongside modern pop and jazz styles—lent Fairuz a timeless, cross-generational appeal, _____ her the moniker “the soul of Lebanon.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. earned
- B. had earned
- C. earning
- D. earn

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The word "earning" is being used to introduce an additional modifying phrase, which describes how Fairuz’s repertoire lent her cross-generational appeal. When a verb ends in -ing and doesn’t have a helper verb like "is" before it, it can be used to modify a noun or verb. This is appropriate here.

Choice A is incorrect. The underlined verb is being used to introduce additional descriptive information, which is set off from the rest of the sentence by a comma. Because there is no subject here, a finite form of the verb (like "earned") creates an error. We need another form of the verb that doesn’t require a subject and can introduce descriptive information. Choice B is incorrect. The underlined verb is being used to introduce additional descriptive information, which is set off from the rest of the sentence by a comma. Because there is no subject here, a finite form of the verb (like "had earned") creates an error. We need another form of the verb that doesn’t require a subject and can introduce descriptive information. Choice D is incorrect. The underlined verb is being used to introduce additional descriptive information, which is set off from the rest of the sentence by a comma. Because there is no subject here, a finite form of the verb (like "earn") creates an error. We need another form of the verb that doesn’t require a subject and can introduce descriptive information.

Question ID: 12013e06

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

In rural Minnesota, ecologist Leroy Walston conducted a study to determine whether seeding solar panel fields with wildflowers could bolster pollinator populations in nearby food crops. Walston’s findings indicate that—assuming solar panel installers’ _____ practice has the potential to increase the number of native bees in crops near solar fields throughout the Midwest by up to 20 percent.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. cooperation, this
- B. cooperation—this
- C. cooperation: this
- D. cooperation this

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a dash after “cooperation” to pair with the dash after “that” to separate the supplementary element “assuming solar panel installers’ cooperation” from the rest of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because a comma can’t be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because a colon can’t be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplemental element from the rest of the sentence.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

Established in 1936 by African American novelist Richard Wright, _____ it would become a vital part of the creative movement known as the Chicago Black Renaissance.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. the South Side Writers Group provided a valuable forum for Chicago writers to share ideas;
- B. Chicago writers in the South Side Writers Group had a valuable forum for sharing ideas;
- C. writers shared ideas at a valuable forum known as the South Side Writers Group in Chicago;
- D. Chicago was where the South Side Writers Group provided a valuable forum for writers to share ideas;

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase “the South Side Writers Group” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase “established in 1936 by African American novelist Richard Wright.” In doing so, this choice clearly indicates that the South Side Writers Group—and not another noun in the sentence—was established in 1936 by Richard Wright.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “Chicago writers” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the Chicago writers were established in 1936 by Richard Wright. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “writers” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the writers were established in 1936 by Richard Wright. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “Chicago” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that Chicago was established in 1936 by Richard Wright.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

The musical scores of Japanese composer Hiroyuki Sawano are famous for their mysterious titles. Laden with emojis and seemingly meaningless words, and driven largely by Sawano’s “personal feeling and mood,” _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. the listener can approach each piece free from expectations because of the titles.
- B. the titles allow the listener to approach each piece free from expectations.
- C. each piece can be approached by the listener free from expectations because of the titles.
- D. the listener’s approach to each piece because of the titles can be free from expectations.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase “the titles” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrases “laden with emojis and seemingly meaningless words, and driven largely by Sawano’s ‘personal feeling and mood.’” In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that the titles—and not another noun in the sentence—are being described as laden with emojis and driven by Sawano’s personal feeling.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of “the listener” immediately after the modifying phrases illogically suggests that the listener, rather than the titles, is laden with emojis and driven by Sawano’s personal feeling. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of “each piece” (i.e., musical score) immediately after the modifying phrases illogically suggests that the pieces, rather than the titles of the pieces, are laden with emojis and driven by Sawano’s personal feeling. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of “the listener’s approach” immediately after the modifying phrases illogically suggests that the listener’s approach, rather than the titles, is laden with emojis and driven by Sawano’s personal feeling.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Dong Lai and Diego J. Muñoz’s work on circumbinary disk accretion—a process in which, due to gravity, material from an orbiting disk spirals inward and accumulates onto two stars or black holes—relies heavily on simulations. Lai and Muñoz recognize the need for direct _____ recommending evolving binary star systems as a promising avenue for future study.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. observation; however,
- B. observation, however,
- C. observation. However,
- D. observation, however;

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. The comma after “observation” pairs with the comma after “however” to separate the supplementary adverb “however” from the rest of the sentence, which consists of a main clause (“Lai...observation”) followed by a participial phrase (“recommending...study”).

Choice A is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the main clause (“Lai...observation”) and the participial phrase (“recommending...study”) that follows the supplementary adverb “however.” A semicolon is conventionally used to join two main clauses, and “recommending...study” isn’t a main clause. Choice C is incorrect because placing a period after “observation” results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “however.” Choice D is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the main clause (“Lai...however”) and the participial phrase (“recommending...study”) that follows. A semicolon is conventionally used to join two main clauses, and “recommending...study” isn’t a main clause.

Question ID: 329255db

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Bengali author Toru Dutt’s *A Sheaf Gleaned in French Fields* (1876), a volume of English translations of French poems, _____ scholars’ understanding of the transnational and multilingual contexts in which Dutt lived and worked.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. has enhanced
- B. are enhancing
- C. have enhanced
- D. enhance

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb “has enhanced” agrees in number with the singular subject “*A Sheaf Gleaned in French Fields*,” which is the title of a book of poems.

Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb “are enhancing” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “*A Sheaf Gleaned in French Fields*.” Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb “have enhanced” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “*A Sheaf Gleaned in French Fields*.” Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb “enhance” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “*A Sheaf Gleaned in French Fields*.”

Question ID: 603755a5

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

In 1959, marine biologist Dr. Albert Jones founded the Underwater Adventure Seekers, a scuba diving _____ that is the oldest club for Black divers in the United States and that has helped thousands of diving enthusiasts become certified in the field.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. club
- B. club,
- C. club—
- D. club, and

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. “That is...field” is an essential supplement, so we should not use punctuation to separate it from “scuba diving club.” .

Choice B is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error. “That is...field” is an essential supplement, so we should not use a comma (or any kind of punctuation) to separate it from “scuba diving club.” . Choice C is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error. “That is...field” is an essential supplement, so we should not use a dash (or any kind of punctuation) to separate it from “scuba diving club.” . Choice D is incorrect. This choice creates a run-on sentence. It makes “that is...United States” into an awkward independent clause, but it also makes “that has...field” into its own awkward independent clause without the correct punctuation separating it.

Question ID: 8999c0c5

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Choreographers George Balanchine and Martha Graham both contributed sections to the dance piece *Episodes*, which premiered at New York’s City Center of Music and Drama in 1959. This cross-genre collaboration brought together the distinct features of Balanchine’s neoclassical ballet and Graham’s modern _____ the stylistic diversity and creative innovation within the dance world.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. dance, it showcased
- B. dance. Which showcased
- C. dance, showcasing
- D. dance. Showcasing

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The conventions being tested are the use of punctuation and verb forms within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the main clause (“This...dance”) and the supplementary element (“showcasing...world”) that provides additional information about what the collaboration accomplished. Moreover, the nonfinite present participle “showcasing” is used correctly to form a supplementary element that modifies the main clause (“this...dance”), describing what the collaboration demonstrated about stylistic diversity and creative innovation in the dance world.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Adding the subject “it” and the finite verb “showcased” results in a second main clause (“it...world”), and a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “which.” Choice D is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “showcasing.”

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

To humans, it does not appear that the golden orb-weaver spider uses camouflage to capture its _____ the brightly colored arachnid seems to wait conspicuously in the center of its large circular web for insects to approach. Researcher Po Peng of the University of Melbourne has explained that the spider’s distinctive coloration may in fact be part of its appeal.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. prey, rather,
- B. prey rather,
- C. prey, rather;
- D. prey; rather,

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses within a sentence. The semicolon is correctly used to join the first main clause (“To humans...prey”) and the second main clause (“rather...approach”). Further, the comma after the adverb “rather” is correctly used to separate the adverb from the main clause (“the brightly...approach”) it modifies, logically indicating that the information in this clause (how the spider’s behavior appears to humans) is contrary to the information in the previous clause (how the spider’s behavior does not appear to humans).

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without appropriate punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice C is incorrect. Placing the comma between the first main clause “To humans...prey” and the adverb “rather” illogically indicates that the information in the first main clause is contrary to what came before, which doesn’t make sense in this context.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

After immigrating from Mexico and obtaining U.S. citizenship, Octaviano Ambrosio Larrazolo entered politics, earning a reputation for being a fervent defender of Hispanic civil rights. In 1919 Larrazolo was elected governor of _____ in 1928 he became the nation’s first Hispanic U.S. Senator.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. New Mexico and
- B. New Mexico,
- C. New Mexico, and
- D. New Mexico

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma and the coordinating conjunction "and" to join the first main clause ("In 1919 Larrazolo was elected governor of New Mexico") and the second main clause ("in 1928 he became the nation’s first Hispanic US Senator").

Choice A is incorrect because when coordinating two longer main clauses such as these, it’s conventional to use a comma before the coordinating conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Recent pollen analyses of the Aran Islands have led some researchers to propose that the now treeless islands were once wooded. This hypothesis _____ that certain trees, such as *P. sylvestris*, survived without interruption or human intervention throughout the Holocene cannot stand, researchers Michael O’Connell and Karen Molloy counter, unless other explanations can first be ruled out.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. suggesting
- B. suggested
- C. suggests
- D. has suggested

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The nonfinite present participle "suggesting" is correctly used to form a restrictive participial phrase ("suggesting...Holocene") within the main clause ("This hypothesis...cannot stand..."). This participial phrase functions as part of the sentence’s subject ("This...Holocene"), providing essential identifying information about what the hypothesis states—namely, that certain trees survived without interruption or human intervention throughout the Holocene.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite verb "suggested" can’t be used in this way within the subject of the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite verb "suggests" can’t be used in this way within the subject of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite verb "has suggested" can’t be used in this way within the subject of the sentence.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

In 1937, Chinese American screen actor Anna May Wong, who had portrayed numerous villains and secondary characters but never a heroine, finally got a starring role in Paramount Pictures’ *Daughter of Shanghai*, a film that _____ “expanded the range of possibilities for Asian images on screen.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. critic, Stina Chyn, claims
- B. critic, Stina Chyn, claims,
- C. critic Stina Chyn claims
- D. critic Stina Chyn, claims,

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The conventions being tested are punctuation use between titles and proper nouns and between verbs and integrated quotations. No punctuation is needed to set off the proper noun “Stina Chyn” from the title that describes Chyn, “critic.” Because “Stina Chyn” is essential information identifying the “critic,” no punctuation is necessary. Further, no punctuation is needed between the verb “claims” and the following quotation because the quotation is integrated into the structure of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed before or after the proper noun “Stina Chyn.” Setting the critic’s name off with commas suggests that it could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn’t the case. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed before or after the proper noun “Stina Chyn.” Setting the critic’s name off with commas suggests that it could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn’t the case. Additionally, no punctuation is needed between “claims” and the integrated quotation. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the verb “claims” and its subject, “critic Stina Chyn.” Additionally, no punctuation is needed between the verb “claims” and the integrated quotation.

Question ID: a2293b3f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

A harpsichord may look just like a piano, but the difference between the two instruments is easy to hear. When a harpsichord’s keys are pressed, the strings inside the _____ are plucked, not struck.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. instrument:
- B. instrument
- C. instrument—
- D. instrument,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a subject and a verb. When, as in this case, a subject ("the strings inside the instrument") is immediately followed by a main verb ("are plucked"), no punctuation is needed.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb. Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb.

Question ID: 5aa1fffd

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Where ____ Interestingly, it was invented by an author. It first appears in the novel *Through the Looking Glass* by English author Lewis Carroll.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. did the word “chortle” come from.
- B. the word “chortle” did come from?
- C. did the word “chortle” come from?
- D. the word “chortle” come from.

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is end-of-sentence punctuation. This choice correctly uses a question mark to punctuate the interrogative sentence "where did the word ‘chortle’ come from," which asks a direct question.

Choice A is incorrect because a period can’t be used in this way to punctuate an interrogative sentence, such as "where did the word ‘chortle’ come from." Choice B is incorrect because "where the word ‘chortle’ did come from" does not follow the conventional structure of a direct question in Standard English. It’s conventional in Standard English to follow the interrogative word "where" with an auxiliary verb (such as "did") when asking a direct question. Choice D is incorrect because "where the word ‘chortle’ come from" does not follow the conventional structure of a direct question in Standard English. It’s conventional in Standard English to follow the interrogative word "where" with an auxiliary verb (such as "did") when asking a direct question. Furthermore, a period can’t be used in this way to punctuate an interrogative sentence.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Horsepower is a unit of measurement used to determine how much power a vehicle produces. The measurement is based on how much and how quickly weight can be _____. one unit of mechanical horsepower is equivalent to the amount of power it takes to lift 550 pounds one foot off the ground in one second.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. moved, for example,
- B. moved,
- C. moved; for example,
- D. moved

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice uses a semicolon in a conventional way to join the first main clause ("The measurement...moved") and the second main clause ("for example...second").

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a coordinating conjunction, a comma can't be used in this way to join the two main clauses ("The measurement...moved" and "for example...second"). Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can't be used in this way to join the two main clauses ("The measurement...moved" and "one unit...second"). Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses ("The measurement...moved" and "one unit...second") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question ID: 831b55ec

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Louise Bennett (1919–2006), also known as “Miss Lou,” was an influential Jamaican poet and folklorist. Her innovative poems _____ the use of Jamaican Creole (a spoken language) in literature.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. popularized;
- B. popularized,
- C. popularized
- D. popularized:

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a verb and an object. No punctuation is needed between the verb "popularized" and its object "the use of Jamaican Creole." The object helps complete the idea of the verb—in this case, it explains what Louise Bennett popularized—and any punctuation between the two results in an ungrammatical sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the verb and its object. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the verb and its object. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the verb and its object.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

If you try on one of artist Nick Cave’s signature Soundsuits, you can expect to swish, rustle, or clang every time you move. Cave makes his suits out of found objects, everything from ceramic birds to broken record players. He carefully considers the sound an object makes before using _____ in a suit.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. this
- B. that
- C. these
- D. it

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested here is pronoun-antecedent agreement. The singular pronoun "it" agrees in number with the singular antecedent "object."

Choice A is incorrect. The singular pronoun "this" is used to refer to a specific thing, but here there is no specific object being referred to. Instead, the sentence is referring back to a hypothetical object that Cave might use in a Soundsuit. Choice B is incorrect. The singular pronoun "that" is used to refer to a specific thing, but here there is no specific object being referred to. Instead, the sentence is referring back to a hypothetical object that Cave might use in a Soundsuit. Choice C is incorrect because the plural pronoun "these" doesn't agree in number with the singular antecedent "object."

Question ID: fa07bcb6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Ganga is a folk singing tradition that originated in the Dinaric Alps in southern Europe. Ganga singers sing different melodies at the same time. The clashing notes can echo a long way across the mountains, which is why _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. ganga has been used as a communication method?
- B. ganga has been used as a communication method.
- C. has ganga been used as a communication method.
- D. has ganga been used as a communication method?

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is end-of-sentence punctuation. This choice correctly uses a period to punctuate a declarative sentence ending with a relative clause that presents an indirect question (“why ganga has been used as a communication method.”)

Choice A is incorrect. It’s unconventional to use a question mark to punctuate a declarative sentence that presents an indirect question. Choice C is incorrect. The structure requires a declarative clause at the end of the sentence, not an interrogative clause that asks a direct question, such as “has ganga been used as a communication method.” Choice D is incorrect. The structure requires a declarative clause at the end of the sentence, not an interrogative clause that asks a direct question, such as “has ganga been used as a communication method.”

Question ID: 81ac953e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

In 1899, Swedish chemist Svante Arrhenius developed an equation to answer a long-standing question: why do chemical reactions speed up at higher temperatures? The Arrhenius equation, named for its creator, _____ an important concept in modern chemistry.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. have remained
- B. remain
- C. remains
- D. are remaining

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. This choice uses the singular verb "remains" to match the singular subject "equation."

Choice A is incorrect. The singular noun "equation" doesn't match with the plural verb conjugation "have remained." Choice B is incorrect. The singular noun "equation" doesn't match with the plural verb conjugation "remain." Choice D is incorrect. The singular noun "equation" doesn't match with the plural verb conjugation "are remaining."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Increased gender diversity is revitalizing the field of economics, according to Harvard’s Claudia Goldin. The trailblazing accomplishments of Goldin, winner of the 2023 Nobel Prize in Economics for her work on women in the labor force, _____ to the value of scholars of diverse backgrounds in spurring research into previously unexplored, but vitally important, topics.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. attests
- B. has attested
- C. is attesting
- D. attest

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The plural verb "attest" agrees in number with the plural subject "trailblazing accomplishments."

Choice A is incorrect because the singular verb "attests" doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject "trailblazing accomplishments." Choice B is incorrect because the singular verb "has attested" doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject "trailblazing accomplishments." Choice C is incorrect because the singular verb "is attesting" doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject "trailblazing accomplishments."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

In 1994, almost 200 years after the death of Wang Zhenyi, the International Astronomical _____ the contributions of the barrier-breaking 18th-century astronomer and author of “Dispute of the Procession of the Equinoxes,” naming a crater on Venus after her.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Union would finally acknowledge
- B. Union to finally acknowledge
- C. Union, having finally acknowledged
- D. Union, finally acknowledging

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. A main clause requires a finite (tensed) verb to perform the action of the subject (in this case “the International Astronomical Union”), and this choice supplies the finite modal verb phrase “would finally acknowledge” to indicate what the International Astronomical Union did.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite to-infinitive “to finally acknowledge” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice C is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle “having finally acknowledged” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle “acknowledging” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

The Dust Bowl was a period of severe drought that plagued the Great Plains of the US during the 1930s. During this time, dust storms _____ over 100 million acres of land. They even reached as far east as New York City.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. are affecting
- B. will have affected
- C. will affect
- D. affected

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verbs to express tense in a sentence. In this choice, the past tense verb "affected," used in conjunction with the phrase "during this time," correctly indicates that the dust storms occurred in the 1930s.

Choice A is incorrect because the present progressive tense verb "are affecting" doesn't indicate that the dust storms occurred in the 1930s.

Choice B is incorrect because the future perfect tense verb "will have affected" doesn't indicate that the dust storms occurred in the 1930s.

Choice C is incorrect because the future tense verb "will affect" doesn't indicate that the dust storms occurred in the 1930s.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

In his 2011 book, historian Sebouh David Aslanian quantifies the reading patterns of early modern Armenian merchants from New Julfa. Aslanian's macroanalysis _____ nearly 1,000 book titles published between 1512 and 1800 shows not only the steady popularity of religious texts but also a broadening interest in secular books, especially those on history and geography.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. examined
- B. examines
- C. had examined
- D. examining

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The sentence’s subject is “Aslanian’s macroanalysis,” and its finite main verb is “shows.” This choice correctly uses the nonfinite present participle “examining” to form an integrated participial phrase (“examining...1800”) that describes the macroanalysis, indicating what it examined.

Choice A is incorrect because using the finite verb “examined” creates an ungrammatical sentence. The sentence already has the finite main verb “shows,” so “examined” can’t also function as a second main verb here without additional punctuation or conjunctions. Choice B is incorrect because using the finite verb “examines” creates an ungrammatical sentence. The sentence already has the finite main verb “shows,” so “examines” can’t also function as a second main verb here without additional punctuation or conjunctions. Choice C is incorrect because using the finite verb “had examined” creates an ungrammatical sentence. The sentence already has the finite main verb “shows,” so “had examined” can’t also function as a second main verb here without additional punctuation or conjunctions.

Question ID: 1f39ab8b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

In the novel *Things Fall Apart* by Chinua Achebe, Okonkwo is a leader of Umuofia (a fictional Nigerian clan) and takes pride in his culture’s traditions. However, when the arrival of European missionaries brings changes to Umuofia, the novel asks a central question: How _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Umuofia’s traditions will be affected.
- B. will Umuofia’s traditions be affected.
- C. Umuofia’s traditions will be affected?
- D. will Umuofia’s traditions be affected?

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The clause before the colon tells us that the novel “asks a question,” so the clause after the colon should be in the conventional form of a question: with the verb before the subject, and a question mark at the end.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice ends the sentence with a period, which isn’t right. The clause before the colon tells us that the novel “asks a question,” so the clause after the colon should be that question. Choice B is incorrect. This choice ends the sentence with a period, which isn’t right. The clause before the colon tells us that the novel “asks a question,” so the clause after the colon should be that question. In Standard English, questions place the verb before the subject and end with a question mark. Choice C is incorrect. This choice doesn’t conform to the conventions of Standard English. In Standard English, questions place the verb before the subject.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

In 2015, a team led by materials scientists Anirudha Sumant and Diana Berman succeeded in reducing the coefficient of friction (COF) between two surfaces to the lowest possible level—superlubricity. A nearly frictionless (and, as its name suggests, extremely slippery) state, _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. when their COF drops below 0.01, two surfaces reach superlubricity.
- B. two surfaces, when their COF drops below 0.01, reach superlubricity.
- C. reaching superlubricity occurs when two surfaces’ COF drops below 0.01.
- D. superlubricity is reached when two surfaces’ COF drops below 0.01.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun “superlubricity” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase “a nearly frictionless...state.” In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that superlubricity—and not another noun in the sentence—is being described as nearly frictionless and extremely slippery.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. Regardless of the introductory “when...” clause, the main subject “two surfaces” follows the modifying phrase (“A nearly frictionless...state”), illogically suggesting that the surfaces are the nearly frictionless, extremely slippery state. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “two surfaces” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the surfaces are a nearly frictionless and extremely slippery state. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the gerund phrase “reaching superlubricity” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the act of reaching superlubricity is the nearly frictionless, extremely slippery state.

Question ID: 5fd86f4b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

The ghazal, a poetic form originating in seventh-century Arabic poetry, has an intricate structure. The twentieth-century Kashmiri American poet Agha Shahid Ali explains that each one of a ghazal’s couplets, while adhering to the patterns of rhyme (*qafia*) and refrain (*radif*) established in the poem’s opening lines (*matla*), _____ thematically and logically autonomous, resulting in a poem with “a stringently formal disunity.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. is
- B. were
- C. have been
- D. are

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The singular verb "is" agrees in number with the singular subject "each one of a ghazal’s couplets." While the prepositional phrase "of a ghazal’s couplets" within the subject contains a plural noun, the head of the subject ("each one") is singular, indicating that each individual couplet (not the couplets as a group) is "thematically and logically autonomous," or self-standing.

Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "were" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "each one of a ghazal’s couplets." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "have been" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "each one of a ghazal’s couplets." Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb "are" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "each one of a ghazal’s couplets."

Question ID: f868d438

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

In 2018, the innovative works of Congolese sculptor and architect Bodys Isek _____ were featured in *City Dreams*, a solo exhibition at New York’s Museum of Modern Art.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Kingelez;
- B. Kingelez,
- C. Kingelez
- D. Kingelez:

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between a subject and a verb. No punctuation is needed when the subject of a sentence is immediately followed by a main verb. In this case, the sentence’s subject (“the innovative works of Congolese sculptor and architect Bodys Isek Kingelez”) is followed by the main verb “were featured,” and no punctuation should come between them.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb.

Question ID: 60dd03bc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Located in the northern United States, the Great Lakes Basin contains roughly 35,000 islands. Lake Superior has Grand Island, for example. Lake Michigan has Belle Isle. Lake Huron, though, is home _____ the largest island of them all: Manitoulin Island.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. to;
- B. to—
- C. to
- D. to,

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a preposition and its complement. No punctuation is needed between the preposition "to" and its complement "the largest island of them all." The complement completes the meaning of the preposition in the phrase "home to the largest island of them all," and any punctuation within it results in an ungrammatical sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the preposition and its complement. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the preposition and its complement. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the preposition and its complement.

Question ID: 6d4b2e1e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

The 1977 play *And the Soul Shall Dance* depicts two Japanese American farming families in Depression-era Southern California. Critics have noted the way pioneering _____ compares the experiences of *issei* (Japanese nationals who emigrated to America) and *nisei* (their American-born children).

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. playwright, Wakako Yamauchi,
- B. playwright, Wakako Yamauchi
- C. playwright Wakako Yamauchi,
- D. playwright Wakako Yamauchi

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation between titles and proper nouns. No punctuation is needed to set off the proper noun "Wakako Yamauchi" from the title that describes Yamauchi, "pioneering playwright." Because "Wakako Yamauchi" is essential information identifying the "pioneering playwright," no punctuation is necessary.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed before or after the proper noun "Wakako Yamauchi." Setting the playwright’s name off with commas suggests that it could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn’t the case. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the title "pioneering playwright" and the proper noun "Wakako Yamauchi." Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the proper noun "Wakako Yamauchi" and the verb "compares."

Question ID: 6205f7e4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

A worker cooperative is a business that is owned and operated by its workers. This model stands in contrast to traditional models in which a smaller group of owners controls a company. Because the profits made by a cooperative are shared by all workers—who are also owners—the workers _____ directly from its success.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. benefit
- B. benefited
- C. were benefiting
- D. had benefited

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verbs to express tense. In this choice, the present tense verb “benefit” is consistent with the other present tense verbs (“is,” “stands,” and “are shared”) used to describe worker cooperatives and how they function.

Choice B is incorrect because the past tense verb “benefited” isn’t consistent with the other present tense verbs used to describe worker cooperatives and how they function. Choice C is incorrect because the past progressive tense verb “were benefiting” isn’t consistent with the other present tense verbs used to describe worker cooperatives and how they function. Choice D is incorrect because the past perfect tense verb “had benefited” isn’t consistent with the other present tense verbs used to describe worker cooperatives and how they function.

Question ID: 7c766ceb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

A popular suite of mapping and spatial analysis software, ArcGIS enables cartographers like Karachi Cartography founder Namra Khalid _____ maps by analyzing and arranging raw geospatial data.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. create
- B. to create
- C. creating
- D. created

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The nonfinite to-infinitive verb “to create” is correctly used to form a subordinate clause that expresses how ArcGIS facilitates the creation of maps (by analyzing and arranging certain data).

Choice A is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite verb “create” can’t be used in this way to form a subordinate clause that expresses how ArcGIS facilitates the creation of maps. Choice C is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle “creating” can’t be used in this way to form a subordinate clause that expresses how ArcGIS facilitates the creation of maps. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite verb “created” can’t be used in this way to form a subordinate clause that expresses how ArcGIS facilitates the creation of maps.

Question ID: 39ac6498

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

In forecasting weather events, meteorologists sometimes discuss the role of atmospheric rivers. What are atmospheric rivers, and how _____ Part of the water cycle, atmospheric rivers are narrow channels of moisture moving through the atmosphere. In certain conditions, these “rivers” can release some of their moisture as precipitation.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. do they affect our weather.
- B. they do affect our weather.
- C. do they affect our weather?
- D. they do affect our weather?

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is end-of-sentence punctuation. This choice correctly uses a question mark to punctuate the coordinated interrogative clauses "What are atmospheric rivers" and "how do they affect our weather," both of which ask direct questions.

Choice A is incorrect because a period can't be used in this way to punctuate an interrogative clause, such as "how do they affect our weather," at the end of a sentence. Choice B is incorrect because the structure requires an interrogative clause and a question mark at the end of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because the structure requires an interrogative clause at the end of the sentence.

Question ID: 8d00cd7c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Within Earth’s biomes, there are four main types of desert: arid, semiarid, coastal, and cold. The roughly _____ is classified as an arid desert.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. 200,000 km² Puntland Desert,
- B. 200,000 km², Puntland Desert
- C. 200,000 km² Puntland Desert
- D. 200,000 km², Puntland Desert,

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation between a modifier and a noun and also between a subject and a verb. No punctuation is needed when, as in this case, a modifying phrase (“roughly 200,000 km²”) precedes the noun phrase it modifies (“Puntland Desert”) to form the subject of the sentence. Additionally, no punctuation is needed between the subject (“The roughly...Desert”) and the main verb (“is classified”).

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the main verb. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the modifier and the noun phrase. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the modifier and the noun phrase, nor is it needed between the subject and the main verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

The violins handmade in the seventeenth century by Italian craftsman Antonio Stradivari have been celebrated as some of the finest in the world. In close collaboration with musicians, Stradivari introduced changes to the shape of a traditional violin, flattening some of the instrument’s curves and making _____ lighter overall.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. those
- B. one
- C. them
- D. it

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is pronoun–antecedent agreement. The singular pronoun “it” agrees in number with the singular antecedent “violin” and thus indicates that the traditional violin (and not its curves) was made lighter.

Choice A is incorrect because the plural pronoun “those” doesn’t agree in number with the singular antecedent “violin.” Choice B is incorrect because the singular pronoun “one” is ambiguous in this context; the resulting sentence leaves unclear what Stradivari made lighter. Choice C is incorrect because the plural pronoun “them” doesn’t agree in number with the singular antecedent “violin.”

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

With some 16,000 in attendance, the Second World Black and African Festival of Arts and _____ or FESTAC '77, as the event was more commonly known—became the largest pan-African event on record. FESTAC drew people from around the world to Lagos, Nigeria, for a monthlong celebration of Black and African art, scholarship, and activism.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Culture:
- B. Culture—
- C. Culture,
- D. Culture

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The text uses a dash to introduce a nonessential element that explains the acronym FESTAC. The dash matches the dash that comes after “known,” ending the descriptive aside.

Choice A is incorrect. A colon can only come after an independent clause, which isn’t the case here. Choice C is incorrect. While punctuation is required to set off “or FESTAC...known” from the rest of the sentence, nonessential elements must be separated from the sentence with matching punctuation. Since a dash appears on the other side of the element, we can’t use a comma here. Choice D is incorrect. The descriptive aside “or FESTAC...known” is a nonessential element that must be separated with punctuation from the rest of the sentence. This choice fails to add the necessary punctuation before the nonessential element.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

The element carbon has the highest melting point _____ all the elements on the periodic table—3,500 degrees Celsius.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. of
- B. of—
- C. of,
- D. of:

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a preposition and its complement. No punctuation is needed between the preposition "of" and its complement "all the elements on the periodic table." The complement completes the meaning of the preposition in the phrase "the highest melting point of all the elements on the periodic table," and using punctuation to separate the complement from the preposition results in an ungrammatical sentence.

Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the preposition and its complement. Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the preposition and its complement. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the preposition and its complement.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

In the eastern Chinese city of Suzhou, known as a hub for silk manufacturing, a unique tradition of embroidery _____ back over two thousand years—one that includes iconic double-sided stitching with different images on each side—remains popular with modern audiences, preserving the city’s cultural heritage.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. dates
- B. date
- C. dating
- D. has dated

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The sentence’s subject is “a unique tradition of embroidery,” and its finite main verb is “remains.” This choice correctly uses the nonfinite present participle “dating” to form an integrated participial phrase (“dating...years”) that modifies the subject, providing additional information about how far back the tradition goes.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. Using the finite present tense verb “dates” creates a second finite verb in the main clause, which already has the finite verb “remains” as its main verb. Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. Using the finite present tense verb “date” creates a second finite verb in the main clause, which already has the finite verb “remains” as its main verb. Furthermore, the plural verb “date” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject, “a unique tradition of embroidery.” Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. Using the finite present perfect tense verb “has dated” creates a second finite verb in the main clause, which already has the finite verb “remains” as its main verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

In Marisol’s 1968 sculpture *Mi Mama y Yo*, gone are the types of pop culture references that made the Parisian-born Venezuelan American artist a star at the height of the pop art movement. In _____ place is a far more personal subject: a sculptural depiction of the artist as a young girl with her mother.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. its
- B. they’re
- C. their
- D. it’s

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of possessive determiners. The plural possessive determiner "their" agrees in number with the plural noun "types" and thus indicates that the more personal subject matter of Marisol’s 1968 sculpture takes the place of those types of pop culture references that made Marisol a star.

Choice A is incorrect because the singular possessive determiner "its" doesn’t agree in number with the plural noun "types." Choice B is incorrect because "they’re" is the contraction for "they are," not a possessive determiner. Choice D is incorrect because "it’s" is the contraction for "it is" or "it has," not a possessive determiner.

Question ID: 56770dda

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

In his 1963 exhibition *Exposition of Music—Electronic Television*, Korean American artist Nam June Paik showed how television images could be manipulated to express an artist’s perspective. Today, Paik _____ considered the first video artist.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. will be
- B. had been
- C. was
- D. is

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verbs to express tense. In this choice, the present tense verb "is," used in conjunction with the word "today," correctly indicates that Paik is currently considered the first video artist.

Choice A is incorrect because the future tense verb "will be" doesn’t indicate that Paik is currently considered the first video artist. Choice B is incorrect because the past perfect tense verb "had been" doesn’t indicate that Paik is currently considered the first video artist. Choice C is incorrect because the past tense verb "was" doesn’t indicate that Paik is currently considered the first video artist.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Sociologist Todd Gitlin co-opted the term “recombinant,” normally used in reference to genetic engineering, to describe serialized television shows of the 1980s. Gitlin’s use of the term referenced TV studios’ practice of repackaging successful narrative formulas as new _____ even shows that varied only slightly from other shows still attracted sizeable audiences.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. content, in that era
- B. content; in that era,
- C. content in that era,
- D. content, in that era,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice uses a semicolon in a conventional way to join the first main clause ("Gitlin’s...content") and the second main clause beginning with a supplementary phrase ("in... audiences"). Further, placing a comma after "era" separates the supplementary phrase "in that era" from the rest of the main clause that follows ("even...audiences").

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Further, this choice fails to mark the boundary between the supplementary phrase "in that era" and the rest of the main clause that follows ("even...audiences"). Choice C is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses ("Gitlin’s...content" and "in... audiences") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses.

Question ID: 6174a5b6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

Many folktales that originate in the Czech language start with a phrase that roughly translates to “there was, there was not.” Many tales that originate in English use “once upon a time.” Such phrases, known as story starters, _____ from language to language.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. vary
- B. has varied
- C. varies
- D. is varying

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The plural verb “vary” agrees in number with the plural subject “such phrases.” The supplementary phrase “known as story starters,” set off by commas, doesn’t change the subject’s number.

Choice B is incorrect. The singular verb phrase “has varied” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “such phrases.” Choice C is incorrect. The singular verb “varies” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “such phrases.” Choice D is incorrect. The singular verb phrase “is varying” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “such phrases.”

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Known for her massive photorealistic paintings of African American figures floating or swimming in pools, Calida Garcia _____ was the logical choice to design the book cover for Ta-Nehisi Coates’s *The Water Dancer*, a novel about an African American man who can travel great distances through water.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Rawles—
- B. Rawles:
- C. Rawles,
- D. Rawles

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between a subject and a verb. When, as in this case, a subject (“Calida Garcia Rawles”) is immediately followed by a verb (“was”), no punctuation is needed.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb. Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

“He was just the man for such a place, and it was just the place for such a man.” This line is from Frederick Douglass’s autobiography *Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass* (1845). It’s an example of antimetabole, a writing technique that _____ emphasis by repeating a statement in a reversed order.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. create
- B. are creating
- C. have created
- D. creates

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "creates" agrees in number with the singular subject "technique." Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb "create" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "technique." Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "are creating" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "technique." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "have created" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "technique."

Question ID: e92a7ad3

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

In the Inca Empire (1438–1533), ayllus _____ family clans that ranged in size from small groups to thousands of people.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. is
- B. was
- C. has been
- D. were

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The plural verb "were" agrees in number with the plural subject "ayllus," which are described as plural "family clans."

Choice A is incorrect because the singular verb "is" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "ayllus." Choice B is incorrect because the singular verb "was" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "ayllus." Choice C is incorrect because the singular verb "has been" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "ayllus."

Question ID: c468db1c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

A group of ecologists led by Axel Mithöfer at the Max Planck Institute for Chemical Ecology in Germany examined the defensive responses of two varieties of the sweet potato _____ TN57, which is known for its insect resistance, and TN66, which is much more susceptible to pests.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. plant.
- B. plant;
- C. plant
- D. plant:

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a main clause and a supplementary phrase. In this choice, a colon is correctly used to mark the boundary between the main clause (“A group...plant”) and the supplementary element (“TN57...pests”) and to introduce the following elaboration on the specific varieties of sweet potato plants that were examined.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “TN57.” Choice B is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the main clause (“A group...plant”) and the supplementary element (“TN57...pests”). A semicolon is conventionally used to join two main clauses, whereas a colon is conventionally used to introduce an element that explains or amplifies the information in the preceding clause. Choice C is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the main clause (“A group...plant”) and the supplementary element (“TN57...pests”) with appropriate punctuation.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

Tracy Fullerton's *Walden, a game*, an unlikely fusion of the writings of nineteenth-century transcendentalist Henry David Thoreau with today's open-world video games, _____ players to explore a digital version of Walden Pond, the idyllic natural setting featured in Thoreau's book *Walden*.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. invites
- B. invite
- C. are inviting
- D. have invited

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb “invites” agrees in number with the singular subject “Tracy Fullerton’s *Walden, a game*.”

Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb “invite” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “Tracy Fullerton’s *Walden, a game*.” Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb “are inviting” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “Tracy Fullerton’s *Walden, a game*.” Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb “have invited” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “Tracy Fullerton’s *Walden, a game*.”

Question ID: 8a9d2f4e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Researchers studying the “terra-cotta army,” the thousands of life-size statues of warriors found interred near the tomb of Emperor Qin Shi Huang of China, were shocked to realize that the shape of each statue’s ears, like the shape of each person’s ears, _____ unique.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. are
- B. is
- C. were
- D. have been

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "is" agrees in number with the singular subject "the shape." Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb "are" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "the shape." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "were" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "the shape." Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb "have been" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "the shape."

Question ID: 576b2c70

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

A member of the Cherokee Nation, Mary Golda Ross is renowned for her contributions to NASA's Planetary Flight Handbook, which _____ detailed mathematical guidance for missions to Mars and Venus.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. provided
- B. having provided
- C. to provide
- D. providing

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of finite verbs in a relative clause. Relative clauses, such as the one beginning with “which,” require a finite verb, a verb that can function as the main verb of a clause. This choice correctly supplies the clause with the finite past tense verb “provided.”

Choice B is incorrect because the non-finite participle “having provided” doesn’t supply the clause with a finite verb. Choice C is incorrect because the non-finite to-infinitive “to provide” doesn’t supply the clause with a finite verb. Choice D is incorrect because the non-finite participle “providing” doesn’t supply the clause with a finite verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

The Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) tracks comparative price list data for its thirty-eight member countries. For instance, in July 2021, a hypothetical basket of goods priced at 100 US dollars (USD) in the United States would have cost 62 USD and 110 USD in fellow OECD _____ and Luxembourg, respectively.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. nations, Chile
- B. nations; Chile
- C. nations: Chile
- D. nations Chile

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation between titles and proper nouns. No punctuation is needed to set off the coordinated noun phrase "Chile and Luxembourg" from the title that describes the two countries, "fellow OECD nations." Because the proper nouns "Chile and Luxembourg" are essential information identifying the "fellow OECD nations," no punctuation is necessary.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the country names ("Chile and Luxembourg") and the title ("fellow OECD nations") describing them. Further, setting the countries' names off with commas suggests that they could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn't the case. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the country names ("Chile and Luxembourg") and the title ("fellow OECD nations") describing them. Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the country names ("Chile and Luxembourg") and the title ("fellow OECD nations") describing them. Placing a colon after "nations" would confusingly suggest that these were the costs of the basket of goods for "fellow OECD nations" in general, not for Chile and Luxembourg specifically.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Paintings by the renowned twentieth-century US _____ were featured in *Artist to Artist*, an exhibition at the Smithsonian Art Museum that paired the works of artists whose career trajectories intersected in meaningful ways.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. artists: Thomas Hart Benton and Jackson Pollock,
- B. artists Thomas Hart Benton and Jackson Pollock
- C. artists Thomas Hart Benton, and Jackson Pollock,
- D. artists, Thomas Hart Benton and Jackson Pollock

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation around noun phrases. No punctuation is needed because the coordinated noun phrase "Thomas Hart Benton and Jackson Pollock" is a restrictive appositive, meaning that it provides essential identifying information about the noun phrase before it, "the renowned twentieth-century US artists."

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the noun phrase "the renowned twentieth-century US artists" and the restrictive appositive "Thomas Hart Benton and Jackson Pollock." Additionally, no punctuation is needed between the sentence's subject ("paintings by the renowned twentieth-century US artists Thomas Hart Benton and Jackson Pollock") and the main verb ("were featured"). Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the coordinated elements "Thomas Hart Benton" and "Jackson Pollock." Additionally, no punctuation is needed between the sentence's subject ("paintings by the renowned twentieth-century US artists Thomas Hart Benton and Jackson Pollock") and the main verb ("were featured"). Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the noun phrase "the renowned twentieth-century US artists" and the restrictive appositive "Thomas Hart Benton and Jackson Pollock."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

In 1453, English King Henry VI became unfit to rule after falling gravely ill. As a result, Parliament appointed Richard, Third Duke of York, who had a strong claim to the English throne, to rule as Lord Protector. Upon recovering two years later, _____ forcing an angered Richard from the royal court and precipitating a series of battles later known as the Wars of the Roses.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Henry resumed his reign,
- B. the reign of Henry resumed,
- C. Henry’s reign resumed,
- D. it was Henry who resumed his reign,

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice ensures that the introductory phrase “upon recovering two years later” appears immediately before the noun it modifies (“Henry”), clearly establishing that Henry recovered two years later.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “the reign of Henry” immediately after the introductory phrase illogically suggests that the reign of Henry recovered two years later. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “Henry’s reign” immediately after the introductory phrase illogically suggests that Henry’s reign recovered two years later. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the function word “it” immediately after the introductory phrase illogically suggests that “it” recovered two years later.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

From 1912 to 1951, Charlotta Bass owned and operated the newspaper *The California Eagle*. While it was under Bass’s leadership, *The Eagle* _____ one of the US’s most influential Black-owned newspapers.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. will become
- B. became
- C. is becoming
- D. to become

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The conventions being tested are the use of verbs to express tense and the use of verb forms within a sentence. In this choice, the past tense verb "became" is consistent with the other past tense verbs ("owned," "operated," and "was") used to indicate that, at a period of time in the past, Bass’s leadership resulted in her newspaper becoming one of the most influential Black-owned newspapers in the US. In addition, "became" supplies the main clause with a finite (tensed) verb, which is required to perform the action of the subject (in this case, "*The Eagle*").

Choice A is incorrect because the future tense verb "will become" isn’t consistent with the other past tense verbs used to discuss Bass and her newspaper. Choice C is incorrect because the present progressive verb "is becoming" isn’t consistent with the other past tense verbs used to discuss Bass and her newspaper. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite to-infinitive "to become" doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

The relationship between genomes and epigenomes reveals how cells with identical DNA develop different _____ whereas the genome in each cell contains a complete DNA sequence, the epigenome consists of chemical compounds that determine which traits in the sequence will be expressed.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. functions
- B. functions,
- C. functions and,
- D. functions:

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of a colon within a sentence. In this choice, the colon correctly introduces the following explanation of the different functions of genomes and epigenomes.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses ("The relationship...functions" and "whereas...expressed") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to join two main clauses ("The relationship...functions" and "whereas...expressed"). Choice C is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction "and" can't be used in this way to join two main clauses. Furthermore, "and" fails to indicate that what follows is an explanation of how cells with identical DNA develop different functions.

Question ID: da53d726

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

In February 1919, following the end of the First World War, women from ten countries around the world convened the Inter-Allied Women’s Conference in Paris. The conference’s goals were _____ ensure women’s participation in the proceedings of the Paris Peace Conference, to secure the right of women to serve in the League of Nations, and to advocate for human rights.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. threefold: to
- B. threefold. To
- C. threefold to
- D. threefold; to

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. In this choice, the colon correctly introduces the series of goals held by the 1919 Inter-Allied Women’s Conference.

Choice B is incorrect because placing a period after "threefold" results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with "To." Choice C is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The main clause ("The conference’s goals were threefold") and the series supplement ("to...rights") are fused without punctuation. Choice D is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to introduce a series. A semicolon is conventionally used to join two main clauses, whereas a colon is conventionally used to introduce a series, making the colon the better choice in this context.

Question ID: f2eaaf5d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

At eight paragraphs long, the preamble to the constitution of _____ country in Western Asia—is much longer than the one-paragraph preamble to the United States Constitution.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Bahrain—a
- B. Bahrain, a
- C. Bahrain a
- D. Bahrain: a

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of a supplementary element within a sentence. The dash after “Bahrain” pairs with the dash after “Asia” to separate the supplementary element “a country in Western Asia” from the rest of the sentence.

Choice B is incorrect because a comma can’t be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because a colon can’t be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Botanists recognize over fifty different species of sunflower. One species, the silverleaf sunflower, _____ both an early-flowering ecotype that tends to grow in coastal areas and a late-flowering ecotype that grows inland.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. having included
- B. including
- C. to include
- D. includes

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. This verb needs to function as the main verb in the sentence, with the subject “one species,” so it needs to be conjugated. This choice gives us the singular present tense “includes,” which is the only conjugated form of the verb among the choices.

Choice A is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. This verb needs to function as the main verb in the sentence, with the subject “one species,” so it needs to be conjugated. “Having included” is a participle form of the verb: it’s not conjugated and doesn’t function like a normal verb. Choice B is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. This verb needs to function as the main verb in the sentence, with the subject “one species,” so it needs to be conjugated. “Including” is the gerund form of the verb: it’s not conjugated and doesn’t function like a normal verb. Choice C is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. This verb needs to function as the main verb in the sentence, with the subject “one species,” so it needs to be conjugated. “To include” is the infinitive form of the verb: it’s not conjugated.

Question ID: 0b005ae2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Recently unearthed Neronian tools in France dating to 54,000 years ago and attributed to *Homo sapiens* may provide evidence that interactions between Neanderthals and modern humans occurred 10,000 years earlier than was previously _____ finding that, if true, would overturn current theories about *H. sapiens* migration during the Upper Paleolithic.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. supposed; a
- B. supposed. A
- C. supposed a
- D. supposed, a

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the main clause ("Recently...supposed") and the supplementary element ("a finding...Paleolithic") that provides additional information about the implications of the Neronian tool discovery.

Choice A is incorrect because a semicolon can't be used in this way to join the main clause ("Recently...supposed") and the supplementary element ("a finding...Paleolithic"). Choice B is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with "a finding." Choice C is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The main clause ("Recently...supposed") and the supplementary element ("a finding...Paleolithic") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question ID: 4a90a978

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

In 1990, California native and researcher Ellen Ochoa left her position as chief of the Intelligent Systems Technology Branch at a NASA research center _____ the space agency’s astronaut training program.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. to join
- B. is joining
- C. joined
- D. joins

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of nonfinite verb forms in a sentence. The nonfinite to-infinitive verb "to join" is correctly used to form a subordinate clause that expresses why Ochoa left her position (to join the training program).

Choice B is incorrect because the finite verb "is joining" can't be used in this way to indicate Ochoa's action of joining the training program. A conjunction such as "and" would be needed to coordinate "is joining" with the previous finite verb, "left." Choice C is incorrect because the finite verb "joined" can't be used in this way to indicate Ochoa's action of joining the training program. A conjunction such as "and" would be needed to coordinate "joined" with the previous finite verb, "left." Choice D is incorrect because the finite verb "joins" can't be used in this way to indicate Ochoa's action of joining the training program. A conjunction such as "and" would be needed to coordinate "joins" with the previous finite verb, "left."

Question ID: 59e41600

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Why are Rome’s famous concrete structures, such as the Colosseum, still standing after 2,000-plus years, when modern concrete may not even last for fifty? Scientists _____ that the secret to Roman concrete’s durability was its unique blend of ingredients, which included volcanic ash and seawater.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. explain
- B. having explained
- C. explaining
- D. to explain

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The main clause of a sentence requires a finite (tensed) verb, and this choice supplies the finite present tense verb “explain” to indicate what the scientists do.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle “having explained” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice C is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle “explaining” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite to-infinitive “to explain” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

According to the University of Hawaiʻi at Mānoa, aloha ʻāina is “a recognition, commitment, and practice sustaining the ea—or life breath” between the Hawaiian people and their natural environments. The concept has been proudly embodied _____ Native Hawaiians for generations, contributing to the lush flora and renowned beauty of the islands.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. by;
- B. by:
- C. by,
- D. by

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a preposition and its complement. No punctuation is needed between the preposition "by" and its complement "Native Hawaiians." The complement completes the meaning of the preposition in the phrase "proudly embodied by Native Hawaiians," and any punctuation within it results in an ungrammatical sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the preposition and its complement. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the preposition and its complement. Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the preposition and its complement.

Question ID: d75d57a0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

While many video game creators strive to make their graphics ever more _____ others look to the past, developing titles with visuals inspired by the “8-bit” games of the 1980s and 1990s. (The term “8-bit” refers to a console whose processor could only handle eight bits of data at once.)

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. lifelike but
- B. lifelike
- C. lifelike,
- D. lifelike, but

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between a subordinate clause and a main clause. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the subordinate clause (“While...lifelike”) and the main clause (“others look to the past”).

Choice A is incorrect because it results in an incomplete sentence with no main clause. Choice B is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the subordinate clause (“While...lifelike”) and the main clause (“others...past”). Choice D is incorrect because it results in an incomplete sentence with no main clause.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

The Lion Light system, developed by Kenyan inventor Richard Turere, consists of LED lights installed around the perimeter of livestock pastures. Powered with _____ the blinking LEDs keep lions away at night, thus protecting the livestock without risking harm to the endangered lions.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. energy collected, by solar panels, during the day
- B. energy collected by solar panels during the day
- C. energy collected by solar panels during the day,
- D. energy, collected by solar panels during the day,

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between a supplementary phrase and a main clause. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the supplementary phrase (“powered...day”), which describes how the LEDs are powered, and the main clause (“the blinking...night”).

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the supplementary phrase and the main clause with appropriate punctuation. Furthermore, placing commas around the phrase “by solar panels” suggests that it could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn’t the case. Choice B is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the supplementary phrase and the main clause with appropriate punctuation. Choice D is incorrect. Placing commas around the phrase “collected by solar panels during the day” suggests that it could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn’t the case.

Question ID: 6997261f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

In 2009, researchers determined that pottery fragments from a cave in China were close to 18,000 years old. These are some of the oldest _____ of pottery ever found.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. pieces:
- B. pieces,
- C. pieces
- D. pieces—

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a noun and a prepositional phrase. No punctuation is needed between the noun "pieces" and the prepositional phrase "of pottery." The prepositional phrase provides essential information about what kind of pieces were found, so it shouldn't be separated from the rest of the noun phrase ("some of the oldest pieces") with punctuation.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the noun phrase "some of the oldest pieces" and the prepositional phrase "of pottery." Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the noun phrase "some of the oldest pieces" and the prepositional phrase "of pottery." Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the noun phrase "some of the oldest pieces" and the prepositional phrase "of pottery."

Question ID: 3daf126e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

A model created by biologist Luis Valente predicts that the rate of speciation—the rate at which new species form—on an isolated island located approximately 5,000 kilometers from the nearest mainland _____ triple the rate of speciation on an island only 500 kilometers from the mainland.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. being
- B. to be
- C. to have been
- D. will be

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is finite and nonfinite verb forms within a sentence. Relative clauses, such as the one beginning with “that,” require a finite verb, a verb that can function as the main verb of a clause. This choice correctly supplies the clause with the finite future tense verb “will be.”

Choice A is incorrect because the nonfinite participle “being” doesn’t supply the clause with a finite verb. Choice B is incorrect because the nonfinite to-infinitive “to be” doesn’t supply the clause with a finite verb. Choice C is incorrect because the nonfinite to-infinitive “to have been” doesn’t supply the clause with a finite verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

For thousands of years, people in the Americas _____ the bottle gourd, a large bitter fruit with a thick rind, to make bottles, other types of containers, and even musical instruments. Oddly, there is no evidence that any type of bottle gourd is native to the Western Hemisphere; either the fruit or its seeds must have somehow been carried from Asia or Africa.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. to use
- B. have used
- C. having used
- D. using

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is finite and nonfinite verb forms within a sentence. A main clause requires a finite verb to perform the action of the subject (in this case, “people in the Americas”), and this choice supplies the finite past perfect tense verb “have used” to indicate what people in the Americas used the gourd for.

Choice A is incorrect because the nonfinite to-infinitive “to use” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice C is incorrect because the nonfinite participle “having used” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice D is incorrect because the nonfinite participle “using” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb.

Question ID: 5ee7fb04

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

In modern plays, actors typically won’t acknowledge the _____ do so breaks the fourth wall, a metaphorical barrier between actors and audiences that allows viewers to suspend the knowledge that they’re watching a staged performance.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. audience. As to
- B. audience to
- C. audience. To
- D. audience, to

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence ("In modern...audience") and another ("To do...performance").

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with "as." Choice B is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences ("In modern...audience" and "To do...performance") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences.

Question ID: a12e3b8a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Customers who are satisfied with how a company resolves a service issue may regard that company more positively than they would if no such issue had occurred. This idea is known as the service recovery _____ research suggests that it has important implications for customer loyalty and retention.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. paradox,
- B. paradox
- C. paradox, and
- D. paradox and,

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma and the coordinating conjunction "and" to join the first main clause ("This idea...paradox") and the second main clause ("research...retention").

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can't be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice D is incorrect because when coordinating two longer main clauses such as these, it's conventional to use a comma before the coordinating conjunction, not after it.

Question ID: c04e9136

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

The 2022 Nobel Prize in Chemistry was awarded to three pioneers in the field of click chemistry: two-time Nobel laureate Barry Sharpless, who coined the term “click chemistry” in 1998; Carolyn Bertozzi, founder of the Bertozzi Group at _____ and Morten Meldal, a professor at the University of Copenhagen in Denmark.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Stanford
- B. Stanford,
- C. Stanford:
- D. Stanford;

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. This choice correctly uses a semicolon to punctuate a complex list (which is made up of items that have commas in them).

Choice A is incorrect. This is a complex list, indicated by the semicolon between "1998" and "Carolyn Bertozzi." What comes after the blank is a separate list item, so punctuation is needed after "Stanford." Choice B is incorrect. This is a complex list, indicated by the semicolon between "1998" and "Carolyn Bertozzi." The items in this list have internal punctuation in the form of commas and must therefore be separated by semicolons to avoid confusion. Choice C is incorrect. This is a complex list, indicated by the semicolon between "1998" and "Carolyn Bertozzi." Colons aren't used to separate items in a list.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

In 1881, French chemist Camille Faure redesigned the rechargeable lead-acid battery. Faure’s design greatly increased the amount of electricity that the original battery, which the French physicist Gaston Planté _____ fifteen years earlier, could hold.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. is inventing
- B. will invent
- C. invents
- D. had invented

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. Faure redesigned the battery in 1881, and the original battery was invented “fifteen years earlier.” Notice that this is the only choice in the past tense. To indicate that a past occurrence took place before another past occurrence, we need to use “had” + the past tense form of the verb. This is called the “past perfect” tense.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice creates a tense error. Planté invented the original battery in the past, so we shouldn’t use the present tense “is inventing.” Choice B is incorrect. This choice creates a tense error. Planté invented the original battery in the past, so we shouldn’t use the future tense “will invent.” Choice C is incorrect. This choice creates a tense error. Planté invented the original battery in the past, so we shouldn’t use the present tense “invents.”

Question ID: 92f309b2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Arms outstretched, right wrist over left with both hands dangling, South Korean musician Psy galloped from one foot to the other in the iconic dance of his 2012 international hit song “Gangnam Style.” Later, a statue depicting Psy’s arm-positioning during the dance was erected in the place that inspired the song’s _____ Gangnam District in Seoul, South Korea.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. name;
- B. name.
- C. name
- D. name—

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a dash after the main clause (“Later...name”) to introduce the supplementary element (“Gangnam...Korea”) that identifies the place that inspired the song’s name.

Choice A is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the main clause (“Later...name”) and the supplementary element (“Gangnam...Korea”). A semicolon is conventionally used to join two main clauses. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “Gangnam.” Choice C is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the main clause and the supplementary element with appropriate punctuation.

Question ID: c49e946e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

As the fourteenth US librarian of Congress, Carla Hayden has many responsibilities. These include overseeing the Library of Congress’s collections, which boast more than 162 million _____ the US Copyright Office, which registers copyright claims and advises Congress on copyright law; and appointing the US poet laureate.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. items managing
- B. items, managing
- C. items; managing
- D. items. Managing

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of elements in a complex series. It’s conventional to use a semicolon to separate items in a complex series with internal punctuation, and in this choice, the semicolon after "items" is conventionally used to separate the first item ("overseeing...items") and the second item ("managing...law") in a list of Hayden’s responsibilities.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the first item and the second item in the complex series. Choice B is incorrect because a comma after "items" doesn’t match the semicolon used later to separate the second and third items in the series ("managing...law" and "and appointing the US poet laureate"). Choice D is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with "Managing."

Question ID: 6d247c13

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

The Boston Saloon was one of the most popular African American–owned establishments in nineteenth-century Nevada. _____ by businessman William A.G. Brown, the saloon was known to offer elegant accommodations and an inclusive environment.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Created
- B. Creates
- C. Creating
- D. Create

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The nonfinite past participle "created" is correctly used to form a supplementary element that modifies the noun phrase "the saloon," identifying who established the Boston Saloon.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite present tense verb "creates" can't be used in this way to form a supplementary element to modify the noun phrase "the saloon." Choice C is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite present participle "creating" can't be used in this way to form a supplementary element to modify the noun phrase "the saloon." Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite present tense verb "create" can't be used in this way to form a supplementary element to modify the noun phrase "the saloon."

Question ID: fe41f258

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

In ancient Greece, an Epicurean was a follower of Epicurus, a philosopher whose beliefs revolved around the pursuit of pleasure. Epicurus defined pleasure as “the absence of pain in the body and of trouble in the _____ that all life’s virtues derived from this absence.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. soul,” positing
- B. soul”: positing
- C. soul”; positing
- D. soul.” Positing

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a main clause and a participial phrase. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the main clause (“Epicurus...‘soul’”) and the participial phrase (“positing...absence”) that provides additional information about how Epicurus defined pleasure.

Choice B is incorrect because a colon can’t be used in this way to join a main clause and a participial phrase. Choice C is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join a main clause and a participial phrase. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “positing.”

Question ID: 4c06427b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

Interest in mechanotransduction, the mechanism by which cells sense and convert mechanical stimuli into biochemical signals, is expanding because of innovative work by biomedical scientists—many of whom, like neuroscience and biophysics expert Elba Serrano, _____ this mechanism to better understand how the body’s neurological and biomechanical systems interact.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. is studying
- B. has studied
- C. study
- D. studies

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The plural verb "study" agrees in number with the plural subject "many."

Choice A is incorrect because the singular verb "is studying" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "many." Choice B is incorrect because the singular verb "has studied" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "many." Choice D is incorrect because the singular verb "studies" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "many."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Instead of sleeping on soft pillows, ancient Egyptians slept on hard, elevated headrests, their design _____ airflow, protection from insects, and hairstyle maintenance over comfort.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. had prioritized
- B. was prioritizing
- C. prioritized
- D. prioritizing

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The nonfinite present participle “prioritizing” is correctly used to form a supplementary element that modifies “their design,” describing what the headrests’ design prioritized.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. The finite past perfect verb “had prioritized” creates a second main clause in the sentence, and the comma after “headrests” can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. The finite past progressive verb “was prioritizing” creates a second main clause in the sentence, and the comma after “headrests” can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. The finite past tense verb “prioritized” creates a second main clause in the sentence, and the comma after “headrests” can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

While constructing the Limyra Bridge, ancient Roman builders relied on temporary wooden beams to support the stone and brick structure. These temporary supports, a construction system known as _____ were removed when the bridge was completed.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. falsework;
- B. falsework
- C. falsework,
- D. falsework:

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. The comma after "falsework" pairs with the comma after "supports" to separate the supplementary element "a construction system known as falsework" from the rest of the sentence. This supplementary element functions to clarify the term "these temporary supports," and the pair of commas indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because a semicolon can't be paired with a comma in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice B is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplemental element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because a colon can't be paired with a comma in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence.

Question ID: 8a264a54

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

With a blend of traditional design elements, such as arched Gothic ceilings, and modern ones, such as floor-to-ceiling _____ design splits the difference between old and new, a mixture that is increasingly seen in home interiors in the US.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. windows; transitional
- B. windows—transitional
- C. windows. Transitional
- D. windows, transitional

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the introductory subordinate clause ("With...windows") and the main clause ("transitional design splits the difference between old and new").

Choice A is incorrect because a semicolon can't be used in this way to separate the subordinate clause ("With...windows") from the main clause ("transitional...new"). Choice B is incorrect because a dash can't be used in this way to separate the subordinate clause ("With...windows") from the main clause ("transitional...new"). Choice C is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with "with."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

The Alvarez theory, developed in 1980 by physicist Luis Walter Alvarez and his geologist son Walter Alvarez, maintained that the secondary effects of an asteroid impact caused many dinosaurs and other animals to die _____ it left unexplored the question of whether unrelated volcanic activity might have also contributed to the mass extinctions.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. out but
- B. out, but
- C. out
- D. out,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma and the coordinating conjunction “but” to join the first main clause (“the Alvarez...out”) and the second main clause (“it left...extinctions”).

Choice A is incorrect because when coordinating two longer main clauses such as these, it’s conventional to use a comma before the coordinating conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

A species of *Byropsis* algae produces toxins to avoid being eaten by predators. However, in some cases, the toxins the organism uses to protect itself from predation actually _____ its attractiveness to predators. The Hawaiian sea slug, for example, not only tolerates *Byropsis* toxins but actually uses them for protection in the same way the algae does.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. is increasing
- B. increase
- C. increases
- D. has increased

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The plural verb "increase" agrees in number with the plural subject "toxins."

Choice A is incorrect because the singular verb "is increasing" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "toxins." Choice C is incorrect because the singular verb "increases" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "toxins." Choice D is incorrect because the singular verb "has increased" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "toxins."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

A pioneer in the field of taphonomy (the study of how organic remains become fossils), _____ may be just as prevalent in the fossil record as those of thick-shelled organisms.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. fossils of thin-shelled organisms, Anna Behrensmeyer demonstrated in a 2005 analysis,
- B. Anna Behrensmeyer demonstrated in a 2005 analysis that fossils of thin-shelled organisms
- C. it was demonstrated in a 2005 analysis by Anna Behrensmeyer that fossils of thin-shelled organisms
- D. a 2005 analysis—by Anna Behrensmeyer—demonstrated that fossils of thin-shelled organisms

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase “Anna Behrensmeyer” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase “a pioneer...fossils.” In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that Anna Behrensmeyer—and not another noun in the sentence—is a pioneer in the field of taphonomy.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “fossils of thin-shelled organisms” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the “fossils” are a pioneer in the field of taphonomy. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the pronoun “it” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that “it” is a pioneer in the field of taphonomy. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “a 2005 analysis” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that “a 2005 analysis” is a pioneer in the field of taphonomy.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

Because a cycle of lunar phases _____ 29.5 days to complete, it’s possible to observe two full moons in a single month, one at the beginning and one at the end.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. are taking
- B. have taken
- C. take
- D. takes

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "takes" agrees in number with the singular subject "a cycle of lunar phases."

Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb "are taking" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "a cycle of lunar phases." Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "have taken" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "a cycle of lunar phases." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "take" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "a cycle of lunar phases."

Question ID: 64a40675

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

In 1953, a fellow performer tripped on legendary jazz musician Dizzy Gillespie’s trumpet, bending its bell upward. When Gillespie tested the damaged instrument, he realized that he _____ sound of a bent bell over that of a straight one.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. preferred; the
- B. preferred the
- C. preferred, the
- D. preferred. The

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a verb and its object. No punctuation is needed between the verb "preferred" and its object "the sound of a bent bell over that of a straight one." The object helps complete the idea of the verb—in this case, it explains what type of sound Gillespie preferred—and any punctuation between the two results in an ungrammatical sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the verb and its object. Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the verb and its object. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the verb and its object.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

Josephine Paddock and Florence Esté were among the 300 artists who exhibited at the 1913 Armory Show, a groundbreaking New York City art exhibition that introduced modernism to American audiences. Though shocking at the time, an abstract cubist painting exhibited by Marcel Duchamp—one of several works that received scorn from critics—_____ the Western art canon more than a century later.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. has entered
- B. have entered
- C. were entering
- D. enter

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "has entered" agrees in number with the singular subject "an abstract cubist painting."

- Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "have entered" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "an abstract cubist painting."
- Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "were entering" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "an abstract cubist painting."
- Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb "enter" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "an abstract cubist painting."

Question ID: 265e7f4c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

The Globe Theatre in London is a reconstruction of the famed venue where many of Shakespeare’s plays were first performed. In 1613, a prop cannon _____ during a performance and ignited the Globe’s thatched roof. No one was hurt, but in two hours the original Globe was gone.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. malfunctions
- B. will malfunction
- C. has malfunctioned
- D. malfunctioned

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verbs to express tense. In this choice, the past tense verb "malfunctioned" is consistent with the other past tense verbs ("ignited" and "was") used to describe the destruction of the original Globe Theatre.

Choice A is incorrect because the present tense verb "malfunctions" isn’t consistent with the other past tense verbs used to describe the destruction of the original Globe Theatre. Choice B is incorrect because the future tense verb "will malfunction" isn’t consistent with the other past tense verbs used to describe the destruction of the original Globe Theatre. Choice C is incorrect because the present perfect tense verb "has malfunctioned" isn’t consistent with the other past tense verbs used to describe the destruction of the original Globe Theatre.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Helical _____ widely understood to confer stability and efficiency in the locomotion of a variety of microscopic organisms—including bacteria, eukaryotic algae, and ciliates—bestows similar advantages, albeit via different propulsive modes, to larger oceanic macroplanktons, such as salps.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. swimming, is
- B. swimming is
- C. swimming has been
- D. swimming,

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. The comma after “swimming” pairs with the dash after “ciliates” to offset the supplementary element (“widely...ciliates”) that interrupts the main clause of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect. Adding the verb “is” here creates an ungrammatical sentence structure with two main verbs (“is” and “bestows”) without appropriate punctuation and/or conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it fails to offset the supplementary element with appropriate punctuation. Furthermore, adding the verb “is” here creates an ungrammatical sentence that has two finite verbs (“is” and “bestows”) without appropriate punctuation and/or conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it fails to offset the supplementary element with appropriate punctuation. Furthermore, adding the verb “has been” here creates an ungrammatical sentence that has two finite verbs (“has been” and “bestows”) without appropriate punctuation and/or conjunction.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

The Balkan nation of Bosnia and Herzegovina does not have one president but _____ as members of the office of the presidency, one representing the nation’s Bosniaks, one its Serbs, and one its Croats, these elected officials take turns serving as the office’s chairperson.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. three, known
- B. three. Known
- C. three who are known
- D. three, who are known

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence (“The Balkan...three”) and another (“Known...chairperson”). While the supplementary element (“known...Croats”) could logically be attached to either the first main clause (“The Balkan...three”) or the second main clause (“these elected...chairperson”), end-of-sentence punctuation is needed to indicate to which sentence the supplementary element belongs.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. In this choice, the first sentence, consisting of a main clause (“The Balkan...three”) and supplementary element (“known...Croats”), is incorrectly joined with a second main clause (“these elected...chairperson”) using a comma. A comma can’t be used in this way to join two sentences. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. In this choice, the first sentence, consisting of a main clause (“The Balkan...three”) and a relative clause (“who are...Croats”), is incorrectly joined with a second main clause (“these elected...chairperson”) using a comma. A comma can’t be used in this way to join two sentences. Additionally, this choice omits the comma needed after “three” to mark the beginning of the supplementary relative clause (“who are known...Croats”). Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. In this choice, the first sentence, consisting of a main clause (“The Balkan...three”) and a supplementary relative clause (“who are...Croats”), is incorrectly joined with a second main clause (“these elected...chairperson”) using a comma. A comma can’t be used in this way to join two sentences.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

The alga species *Chlorella vulgaris* is very efficient at making oxygen. For this reason, scientists are currently exploring ways to use this species in space. *C. vulgaris* might be used, for example, to build future biological air exchange systems that _____ oxygen for astronauts.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. are producing
- B. produced
- C. produce
- D. have produced

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verbs to express tense. Simple present tense verbs can be used to describe actions that tend to occur, including in a hypothetical or future scenario. In this case, the simple present tense verb “produce” indicates what the air exchange systems might be able to do in the future (produce oxygen for astronauts).

Choice A is incorrect. The present progressive tense verb “are producing” suggests that the oxygen is currently being produced, not that it might be produced in the future. Choice B is incorrect because the past tense verb “produced” suggests that the oxygen was produced in the past, not that it might be produced in the future. Choice D is incorrect because the present perfect tense verb “have produced” suggests that the oxygen has been produced from a point in the past up to the present, not that it might be produced in the future.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Researchers studying magnetosensation have determined why some soil-dwelling roundworms in the Southern Hemisphere move in the opposite direction of Earth's magnetic field when searching for _____ in the Northern Hemisphere, the magnetic field points down, into the ground, but in the Southern Hemisphere, it points up, toward the surface and away from worms’ food sources.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. food:
- B. food,
- C. food while
- D. food

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is colon use within a sentence. A colon used in this way introduces information that illustrates or explains information that has come before it. In this case, the colon introduces the following explanation of why some roundworms in the Southern Hemisphere move in the opposite direction of Earth’s magnetic field.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to join two long independent clauses (“Researchers...food” and “in...sources”) such as these. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two clauses (“Researchers...food” and “in...sources”) are fused without punctuation. Furthermore, the conjunction “while” fails to indicate that what follows is an explanation of why some roundworms in the Southern Hemisphere move in the opposite direction of Earth’s magnetic field. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two clauses (“Researchers...food” and “in...sources”) are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question ID: 12bd5b75

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

With its towering, six-spired exterior of granitelike quartz monzonite, the Salt Lake Temple is one of the most instantly recognizable structures in the state of Utah. However, many people do not know that _____ built over the course of forty years, with construction beginning in 1853 and ending in 1893.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. it was
- B. one was
- C. they were
- D. both were

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is pronoun-antecedent agreement. The singular pronoun "it" agrees in number with the singular antecedent "the Salt Lake Temple."

Choice B is incorrect because the singular pronoun "one" is ambiguous in this context; the resulting sentence leaves unclear whether there is only one Salt Lake temple or multiple. Choice C is incorrect because the plural pronoun "they" doesn't agree in number with the singular antecedent "the Salt Lake Temple." Choice D is incorrect because the plural pronoun "both" doesn't agree in number with the singular antecedent "the Salt Lake Temple."

Question ID: 3ed5ebb4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

In her analysis of Edith Wharton’s *The House of Mirth* (1905), scholar Candace Waid observes that the novel depicts the upper classes of New York society as “consumed by the appetite of a soulless _____ an apt assessment given that *The House of Mirth* is set during the Gilded Age, a period marked by rapid industrialization, economic greed, and widening wealth disparities.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. materialism”; and
- B. materialism” and
- C. materialism,”
- D. materialism”

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between a main clause and a supplementary noun phrase. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the main clause (“scholar...materialism”) and the supplementary noun phrase (“an apt assessment”) that describes Waid’s observation about how *The House of Mirth* depicts the upper classes of New York society.

Choice A is incorrect because a semicolon and the conjunction “and” can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between a main clause and a supplementary noun phrase. Choice B is incorrect. Joining the main clause (“scholar...materialism”) and the following noun phrase with the conjunction “and” results in a confusing and illogical sentence that suggests that the novel depicts the upper classes of New York society as “an apt assessment,” which doesn’t make sense in this context. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the main clause and the supplementary noun phrase with appropriate punctuation.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

After winning the 1860 presidential election, Abraham Lincoln appointed Edward Bates, Salmon P. Chase, and William H. Seward to his cabinet. Lincoln's decision was surprising, since each of these men had run against him, but historians have praised it, noting that Lincoln _____ his rivals' diverse talents to strengthen his administration.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. has leveraged
- B. is leveraging
- C. will leverage
- D. leveraged

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The subject of the verb is "Lincoln," and the first sentence tells us that we're talking about something that Abraham Lincoln did in 1860. So the simple past tense "leveraged" fits the logic of the text.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice creates a tense issue. "Has leveraged" is the present perfect tense, which is used for an action that began in the past and continues into the present. Lincoln started leveraging his rivals' talents in 1860—it's definitely not still happening today. So the present perfect tense isn't appropriate. Choice B is incorrect. This choice creates a tense issue. "Is leveraging" is the present tense, but Lincoln leveraged his rivals' talents in 1860, so the present tense isn't appropriate. Choice C is incorrect. This choice creates a tense issue. "Will leverage" is the future tense, but Lincoln leveraged his rivals' talents in 1860, so the future tense isn't appropriate.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Joshua Hinson, director of the language revitalization program of the Chickasaw Nation in Oklahoma, helped produce the world’s first Indigenous-language instructional app, Chickasaw _____ Chickasaw TV, in 2010; and a Rosetta Stone language course in Chickasaw, in 2015.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Basic; in 2009, an online television network;
- B. Basic; in 2009, an online television network,
- C. Basic, in 2009; an online television network,
- D. Basic, in 2009, an online television network,

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of items in a complex series. It’s conventional to use a semicolon to separate items in a complex series with internal punctuation, and in this choice, the semicolon after “2009” is conventionally used to separate the first item (“the world’s...2009”) and the second item (“an online...2010”) in the series of things that Hinson helped create. Further, the comma after “Basic” correctly pairs with the comma after “app,” and the comma after “network” correctly pairs with the comma after “TV” to set off the supplemental elements (“Chickasaw Basic” and “Chickasaw TV”) that provide the names of the app and the TV network, respectively. Altogether, the punctuation in this choice results in a sentence that clearly indicates that Hinson helped make a language app in 2009, an online TV network in 2010, and a language course in 2015.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to punctuate the complex series in a way that makes clear that Hinson helped make a language app in 2009, an online TV network in 2010, and a language course in 2015. Choice B is incorrect because it fails to punctuate the complex series in a way that makes clear that Hinson helped make a language app in 2009, an online TV network in 2010, and a language course in 2015. Choice D is incorrect because the comma after “2009” doesn’t match the semicolon used to separate the second and third items in the complex series.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

One of the earliest known maps is a Babylonian clay tablet thought to be almost 4,500 years old. The map _____ the area of a plot of land, shows a river valley, and includes the cardinal directions.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. describes
- B. describe
- C. have described
- D. are describing

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The singular verb "describes" agrees in number with the singular subject "map."

Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "describe" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "map." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "have described" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "map." Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb "are describing" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "map."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

Dolores Huerta’s advocacy on behalf of farmworkers was rooted in her experience as a schoolteacher in Stockton, California, in the early 1950s. Hoping to help her students and their families outside the _____ Huerta left teaching to start the Stockton chapter of the Community Service Organization, a group focused on the needs of local farmworkers.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. classroom.
- B. classroom;
- C. classroom,
- D. classroom

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the introductory participial phrase ("Hoping...classroom") and the main clause ("Huerta...farmworkers").

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with "hoping." Choice B is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between the participial phrase ("Hoping...classroom") and the main clause ("Huerta...farmworkers"). Choice D is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the participial phrase ("Hoping...classroom") and the main clause ("Huerta...farmworkers").

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Dr. Rocío Paola Caballero-Gill is a paleoceanographer. This means that Dr. Caballero-Gill doesn’t just study oceans as they are today. She uses chemistry and fossil evidence _____ oceans as they were in the past.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. has studied
- B. to study
- C. studied
- D. studies

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The nonfinite to-infinitive verb “to study” is correctly used to form a subordinate clause that indicates what Dr. Caballero-Gill uses chemistry and fossil evidence for (to study oceans as they were in the past).

Choice A is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite verb “has studied” can’t be used in this way to form a subordinate clause that indicates what Dr. Caballero-Gill uses the evidence for. Choice C is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite verb “studied” can’t be used in this way to form a subordinate clause that indicates what Dr. Caballero-Gill uses the evidence for. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite verb “studies” can’t be used in this way to form a subordinate clause that indicates what Dr. Caballero-Gill uses the evidence for.

Question ID: f570cece

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

Both Arteaga, in the state of Coahuila, and Lagos de Moreno, in the state of Jalisco, have been designated by Mexico as *pueblos mágicos* (magical villages) to celebrate these _____ natural beauty and unique cultural traditions.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. town
- B. town’s
- C. towns
- D. towns’

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of possessive nouns. The plural possessive noun “towns’” correctly indicates that the natural beauty and unique cultural traditions belong to both Arteaga and Lagos de Moreno.

Choice A is incorrect because the context requires the plural possessive noun “towns’,” not the singular noun “town.” Choice B is incorrect because the context requires the plural possessive noun “towns’,” not the singular possessive noun “town’s.” Choice C is incorrect because the context requires the plural possessive noun “towns’,” not the plural noun “towns.”

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Hard

Question

The prime meridian, the global indicator of zero degrees longitude established in 1884, was originally determined using astronomically derived coordinates. _____ as decades passed, new calculations would reveal increasingly precise coordinates, yet the prime meridian remained unchanged; it wasn't until the 1980s that, spurred by improved geodetic data, the prime meridian was officially moved—roughly one hundred meters east.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. Specifically,
- B. To that end,
- C. Again and again,
- D. Granted,

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. "Again and again" logically signals that the information in this sentence—that new calculations revealed increasingly precise coordinates for the location of the prime meridian—refers to events that occurred multiple times in the decades after the establishment of the prime meridian in 1884 (which is described in the preceding sentence).

Choice A is incorrect because "specifically" illogically signals that the information in this sentence provides specific, precise details elaborating on the description of the prime meridian's establishment in the previous sentence. Instead, the sentence indicates that increasingly precise coordinates were revealed on multiple occasions in the decades following the meridian's establishment. Choice B is incorrect because "to that end" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is a means of accomplishing a goal established in the previous sentence about the prime meridian's establishment. Instead, the sentence indicates that increasingly precise coordinates were revealed on multiple occasions in the decades following the meridian's establishment. Choice D is incorrect because "granted" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is in opposition to the information about the prime meridian's establishment in the previous sentence. Instead, the sentence indicates that increasingly precise coordinates were revealed on multiple occasions in the decades following the meridian's establishment.

Question ID: afec1a70

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Medium

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- As engineered structures, many bird nests are uniquely flexible yet cohesive.
- A research team led by Yashraj Bhosale wanted to better understand the mechanics behind these structural properties.
- Bhosale’s team used laboratory models that simulated the arrangement of flexible sticks into nest-like structures.
- The researchers analyzed the points where sticks touched one another.
- When pressure was applied to the model nests, the number of contact points between the sticks increased, making the structures stiffer.

The student wants to present the primary aim of the research study. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. Bhosale’s team wanted to better understand the mechanics behind bird nests’ uniquely flexible yet cohesive structural properties.
- B. The researchers used laboratory models that simulated the arrangement of flexible sticks and analyzed the points where sticks touched one another.
- C. After analyzing the points where sticks touched, the researchers found that the structures became stiffer when pressure was applied.
- D. As analyzed by Bhosale’s team, bird nests are uniquely flexible yet cohesive engineered structures.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. It describes the reason Bhosale’s team wanted to study the structures of bird nests—that is to say, the study’s primary aim.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice doesn’t present the primary aim of the research study. It describes how the study worked, but not why it was done. Choice C is incorrect. This choice doesn’t present the primary aim of the research study. It describes a result of the experiment, but not why it was carried out. Choice D is incorrect. This choice doesn’t present the primary aim of the research study.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Easy

Question

In 1942, the 1,500-mile Alaska Highway was constructed in under nine months, largely due to the skilled work of nearly 4,000 African American soldiers from US Army engineering regiments. The soldiers’ contribution was overlooked for decades. _____ in 2017, lawmakers declared October 25 a day of recognition—“Alaska Highway Day”—for the troops who helped build this critical roadway.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. Lastly,
- B. Then,
- C. Similarly,
- D. For example,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. "Then" logically signals that the event described in this sentence—lawmakers’ 2017 declaration of Alaska Highway Day—is part of a chronological sequence of events, occurring after the decades-long period in which the soldiers’ contribution was overlooked.

Choice A is incorrect because "lastly" illogically signals that this sentence presents the last of a series of points or reasons. Instead, it describes a later event occurring in a chronological sequence of events. Choice C is incorrect because "similarly" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is similar to the previous information about the soldiers’ contribution being overlooked for decades. Instead, it describes an event occurring after that decades-long period. Choice D is incorrect because "for example" illogically signals that this sentence provides an example illustrating the previous information about the soldiers’ contribution being overlooked for decades. Instead, it describes an event occurring after that decades-long period.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Easy

Question

Samuel Coleridge-Taylor was a prominent classical music composer from England who toured the US three times in the early 1900s. The child of a West African father and an English mother, Coleridge-Taylor emphasized his mixed-race ancestry. For example, he referred to himself as Anglo-African. _____ he incorporated the sounds of traditional African music into his classical music compositions.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. In addition,
- B. Actually,
- C. However,
- D. Regardless,

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. “In addition” logically signals that the detail in this sentence—that Coleridge-Taylor included traditional African music in his classical compositions—adds to the information in the previous sentence. Specifically, the previous sentence indicates one way in which Coleridge-Taylor emphasized his mixed-race ancestry, and the claim that follows indicates a second, additional way.

Choice B is incorrect because “actually” illogically signals that the detail in this sentence is surprising in light of the information in the previous sentence. Instead, the detail adds to the information, indicating a second, additional way in which Coleridge-Taylor emphasized his mixed-race ancestry. Choice C is incorrect because “however” illogically signals that the detail in this sentence contrasts with the information in the previous sentence. Instead, the detail adds to the information, indicating a second, additional way in which Coleridge-Taylor emphasized his mixed-race ancestry. Choice D is incorrect because “regardless” illogically signals that the detail in this sentence is true despite the information in the previous sentence. Instead, the detail adds to the information, indicating a second, additional way in which Coleridge-Taylor emphasized his mixed-race ancestry.

Question ID: 4d2736f0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Hard

Question

In her poetry collection *Thomas and Beulah*, Rita Dove interweaves the titular characters’ personal stories with broader historical narratives. She places Thomas’s journey from the American South to the Midwest in the early 1900s within the larger context of the Great Migration. _____ Dove sets events from Beulah’s personal life against the backdrop of the US Civil Rights Movement.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- Answer**
- A. Specifically,
 - B. Thus,
 - C. Regardless,
 - D. Similarly,

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. “Similarly” logically signals that the information in the sentence—that Dove situates Beulah’s life in the context of the US Civil Rights Movement—is similar to the previous information about Thomas and the Great Migration. Both sentences support the first sentence’s claim that Dove portrays her characters in the context of broader historical narratives.

Choice A is incorrect because “specifically” illogically signals that the information about Beulah in this sentence provides specific details elaborating on the previous information about Thomas. Instead, it’s similar to the previous information about Thomas. Choice B is incorrect because “thus” illogically signals that the information about Beulah in this sentence is a result or consequence of the previous information about Thomas. Instead, it’s similar to the previous information about Thomas. Choice C is incorrect because “regardless” illogically signals that the information about Beulah in this sentence is true despite the previous information about Thomas. Instead, it’s similar to the previous information about Thomas.

Question ID: d3b7d7a3

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Hard

Question

Many historical accounts of the 1930s focus on the widespread movement of people from dust bowl–ravaged Great Plains states to faraway California. However, a 2016 study of 1940 census data complicates this popular narrative; _____ researchers determined, migrants in states hardest hit by prolonged droughts and dust storms—Colorado, Kansas, Oklahoma, and Texas—merely relocated within the region.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. for this reason,
- B. more often,
- C. additionally,
- D. nevertheless,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “More often” logically signals that the historical outcome in this clause—dust bowl migrants’ relocation within the Great Plains region—was more common than the movement to California described in many historical accounts.

Choice A is incorrect because “for this reason” illogically signals that the historical outcome in this clause was caused by either the narrative about widespread movement to California or the 2016 study’s complication of that narrative. Instead, dust bowl migrants’ regional relocation was found to be more common than the movement to California described in many historical accounts. Choice C is incorrect because “additionally” illogically signals that the historical outcome in this clause merely adds to either the narrative about widespread movement to California or the 2016 study’s complication of that narrative. Instead, dust bowl migrants’ regional relocation was found to be more common than the movement to California described in many historical accounts. Choice D is incorrect because “nevertheless” illogically signals that the historical outcome in this clause is true despite either the narrative about widespread movement to California or the 2016 study’s complication of that narrative. While the findings about dust bowl migrants’ regional relocation did challenge the previous narrative, they did not challenge the study’s findings, and this choice creates a confusing ambiguity. Instead, dust bowl migrants’ regional relocation was found to be more common than the movement to California described in many historical accounts.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Hard

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The *Atlantic Monthly* magazine was first published in 1857.
- The magazine focused on politics, art, and literature.
- In 2019, historian Cathryn Halverson published the book *Faraway Women and the “Atlantic Monthly.”*
- Its subject is female authors whose autobiographies appeared in the magazine in the early 1900s.
- One of the authors discussed is Juanita Harrison.

The student wants to introduce Cathryn Halverson’s book to an audience already familiar with the *Atlantic Monthly*. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. Cathryn Halverson’s *Faraway Women and the “Atlantic Monthly”* discusses female authors whose autobiographies appeared in the magazine in the early 1900s.
- B. A magazine called the *Atlantic Monthly*, referred to in Cathryn Halverson’s book title, was first published in 1857.
- C. *Faraway Women and the “Atlantic Monthly”* features contributors to the *Atlantic Monthly*, first published in 1857 as a magazine focusing on politics, art, and literature.
- D. An author discussed by Cathryn Halverson is Juanita Harrison, whose autobiography appeared in the *Atlantic Monthly* in the early 1900s.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The sentence effectively introduces Cathryn Halverson’s book to an audience already familiar with the *Atlantic Monthly*, noting the title of Halverson’s book and describing its content without providing background information about the *Atlantic Monthly*.

Choice B is incorrect. The sentence introduces the *Atlantic Monthly* and mentions that it’s referred to in Cathryn Halverson’s book title; it doesn’t effectively introduce Halverson’s book. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence assumes that the audience is unfamiliar with the *Atlantic Monthly*, providing background information about the magazine; it doesn’t effectively introduce Halverson’s book to an audience already familiar with the *Atlantic Monthly*. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence assumes that the audience is familiar with the *Atlantic Monthly*, it doesn’t effectively introduce Cathryn Halverson’s book.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Easy

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Sue is the nickname of a dinosaur fossil specimen housed at the Field Museum of Natural History.
- The Field Museum of Natural History is located in Chicago, Illinois.
- Sue is a member of the genus *Tyrannosaurus*.
- Big Mike is the nickname of a dinosaur fossil specimen housed at the Museum of the Rockies.
- The Museum of the Rockies is located in Bozeman, Montana.
- Big Mike is a member of the genus *Tyrannosaurus*.

The student wants to emphasize a similarity between the two specimens. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. The Field Museum of Natural History, where Sue is housed, is located in Chicago, Illinois.
- B. Big Mike is the nickname of a *Tyrannosaurus* fossil specimen housed at the Museum of the Rockies in Bozeman, Montana.
- C. The dinosaur fossil specimens Sue and Big Mike are both members of the genus *Tyrannosaurus*.
- D. While Sue is housed at the Field Museum of Natural History, Big Mike is housed at the Museum of the Rockies.

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes a similarity between the two specimens, noting that Sue and Big Mike are members of the same genus: *Tyrannosaurus*.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence only provides information about where one of the specimens (Sue) can be found; it doesn't emphasize a similarity between the two specimens. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence only provides information about one specimen (Big Mike); it doesn't emphasize a similarity between the two specimens. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence contrasts the locations of Sue and Big Mike; it doesn't emphasize a similarity between the two specimens.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Easy

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The Haber-Bosch process is an industrial process used to manufacture ammonia (NH₃).
- It was invented by chemists Fritz Haber and Carl Bosch in 1910.
- The process’s primary reaction combines nitrogen (N₂) from the air with hydrogen (H₂).
- It requires an iron catalyst and high temperatures and pressures.
- Most of the ammonia produced by this process is used in fertilizers.

The student wants to provide an overview of the Haber-Bosch process. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. The Haber-Bosch process needs nitrogen, hydrogen, and an iron catalyst.
- B. The Haber-Bosch process uses an iron catalyst along with high temperatures and pressures to manufacture ammonia from nitrogen and hydrogen.
- C. Chemists Fritz Haber and Carl Bosch invented an industrial process to manufacture ammonia to be used in fertilizers.
- D. In 1910, chemists Fritz Haber and Carl Bosch invented the Haber-Bosch process, which requires high temperatures and pressures.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The sentence provides an overview of the Haber-Bosch process, explaining that it uses an iron catalyst, high temperatures, and high pressures to manufacture ammonia from nitrogen and hydrogen.

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence identifies some of the process’s required components (nitrogen, hydrogen, and an iron catalyst), the overview is incomplete; it doesn’t explain what the process does (produces ammonia) or mention the conditions needed for it to function (high temperatures and pressures). Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence indicates who invented the process (Fritz Haber and Carl Bosch) and that it produces ammonia, the overview is incomplete; it doesn’t mention any of the necessary ingredients or conditions. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence mentions the inventors of the process along with the required conditions (high temperatures and pressures), it doesn’t explain that the process produces ammonia or indicate what components are needed.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Medium

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Organisms release cellular material into their environment by shedding substances such as hair or skin.
- The DNA in these substances is known as environmental DNA, or eDNA.
- Researchers collect and analyze eDNA to detect the presence of species that are difficult to observe.
- Geneticist Sara Oyler-McCance’s research team analyzed eDNA in water samples from the Florida Everglades to detect invasive constrictor snake species in the area.
- The study determined a 91% probability of detecting Burmese python eDNA in a given location.

The student wants to present the study to an audience already familiar with environmental DNA. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. Sara Oyler-McCance’s researchers analyzed eDNA in water samples from the Florida Everglades for evidence of invasive constrictor snakes, which are difficult to observe.
- B. An analysis of eDNA can detect the presence of invasive species that are difficult to observe, such as constrictor snakes.
- C. Researchers found Burmese python eDNA, or environmental DNA, in water samples; eDNA is the DNA in released cellular materials, such as shed skin cells.
- D. Sara Oyler-McCance’s researchers analyzed environmental DNA (eDNA)—that is, DNA from cellular materials released by organisms—in water samples from the Florida Everglades.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. This choice presents the study in a way that assumes the audience is already familiar with eDNA.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice doesn’t present the study. It only states a general fact about eDNA analysis. Choice C is incorrect. This choice isn’t suited for an audience already familiar with eDNA. A familiar audience wouldn’t need to have the term defined or explained. Choice D is incorrect. This choice isn’t suited for an audience already familiar with eDNA. A familiar audience wouldn’t need to have the term defined or explained. It also doesn’t present the study.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Medium

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Sam Maloof (1916–2009) was an American woodworker and furniture designer.
- He was the son of Lebanese immigrants.
- He received a “genius grant” from the John D. and Catherine T. MacArthur Foundation in 1985.
- The Museum of Fine Arts in Boston, Massachusetts, owns a rocking chair that Maloof made from walnut wood.
- The armrests and the seat of the chair are sleek and contoured, and the back consists of seven spindle-like slats.

The student wants to describe the rocking chair to an audience unfamiliar with Sam Maloof. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. With its sleek, contoured armrests and seat, the walnut rocking chair in Boston’s Museum of Fine Arts is just one piece of furniture created by American woodworker Sam Maloof.
- B. Sam Maloof was born in 1916 and died in 2009, and during his life, he made a chair that you can see if you visit the Museum of Fine Arts in Boston.
- C. Furniture designer Sam Maloof was a recipient of one of the John D. and Catherine T. MacArthur Foundation’s “genius grants.”
- D. The rocking chair is made from walnut, and it has been shaped such that its armrests and seat are sleek and contoured.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The sentence effectively describes the rocking chair to an audience unfamiliar with Sam Maloof, noting its sleek, contoured armrests and seat and explaining that Sam Maloof (the walnut chair’s creator) was an American woodworker.

Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence explains who Sam Maloof was and mentions a chair, it doesn’t describe the chair. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence explains who Sam Maloof was, it doesn’t describe the rocking chair. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence describes the rocking chair, it doesn’t explain who Sam Maloof was.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Medium

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Species belonging to the Orchidaceae (orchid) family can be found in both tropical and temperate environments.
- Orchidaceae species diversity has not been well studied in temperate forests, such as those in Oaxaca, Mexico.
- Arelee Estefanía Muñoz-Hernández led a study to determine how many different Orchidaceae species are present in the forests of Oaxaca.
- Muñoz-Hernández and her team collected orchids each month for a year at a site in Oaxaca.
- Seventy-four Orchidaceae species were present at the site.

The student wants to present the study and its findings. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. A study led by Arelee Estefanía Muñoz-Hernández identified a total of 74 Orchidaceae species in the temperate forests of Oaxaca, Mexico.
- B. There are orchids in many environments, but there are 74 Orchidaceae species in Oaxaca, Mexico.
- C. Oaxaca, Mexico, is home to temperate forests containing 74 Orchidaceae species.
- D. Arelee Estefanía Muñoz-Hernández and her team wanted to know how many different Orchidaceae species are present in the forests of Oaxaca, Mexico, so they conducted a study to collect orchids.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. This choice most effectively presents the study and its findings. It opens with the study and names its lead researcher, then tells us its finding: that they identified 74 Orchidaceae species in the temperate forests of Oaxaca, Mexico.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice doesn't include the study's findings, so it fails to achieve the goal. It doesn't mention that there was a study at all. Choice C is incorrect. This choice doesn't present the study, so it fails to achieve the goal. It doesn't mention that there was a study at all. Choice D is incorrect. This choice doesn't include the study's findings, so it fails to achieve the goal.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Medium

Question

While studying jorō spiders, a large species originally from East Asia, University of Georgia researchers wondered if the spiders’ rapid spread throughout the southeastern US was a result of aggressive behavior. _____ they discovered that jorō spiders are gentle giants who react to even minor disturbances by “freezing” in place for an hour or more.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. Therefore,
- B. Instead,
- C. For example,
- D. In other words,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “Instead” logically signals that the information about the researchers’ discovery in this sentence—that jorō spiders are gentle giants who “freeze” in place when disturbed—contradicts their initial hypothesis about the spiders’ aggressiveness described in the previous sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because “therefore” illogically signals that the discovery about jorō spiders’ gentleness is a result of the initial hypothesis about their aggressive behavior. Instead, the sentence presents information that contradicts the initial hypothesis. Choice C is incorrect because “for example” illogically signals that the discovery about jorō spiders’ gentleness exemplifies the initial hypothesis about their aggressive behavior. Instead, the sentence presents information that contradicts the initial hypothesis. Choice D is incorrect because “in other words” illogically signals that the discovery about jorō spiders’ gentleness is merely restating or rephrasing the initial hypothesis about their aggressive behavior. Instead, the sentence presents information that contradicts the initial hypothesis.

Question ID: 264e7415

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Easy

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The Philadelphia and Lancaster Turnpike was a road built between 1792 and 1794.
- It was the first private turnpike in the United States.
- It connected the cities of Philadelphia and Lancaster in the state of Pennsylvania.
- It was sixty-two miles long.

The student wants to emphasize the distance covered by the Philadelphia and Lancaster Turnpike. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. The sixty-two-mile-long Philadelphia and Lancaster Turnpike connected the Pennsylvania cities of Philadelphia and Lancaster.
- B. The Philadelphia and Lancaster Turnpike was the first private turnpike in the United States.
- C. The Philadelphia and Lancaster Turnpike, which connected two Pennsylvania cities, was built between 1792 and 1794.
- D. A historic Pennsylvania road, the Philadelphia and Lancaster Turnpike was completed in 1794.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes the distance covered by the Philadelphia and Lancaster Turnpike, noting that the turnpike, which connected the two Pennsylvania cities in its name, was sixty-two miles long.

Choice B is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes the significance of the turnpike; it doesn’t emphasize the distance that the turnpike covered. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence mentions that the turnpike connected two Pennsylvania cities, it doesn’t emphasize the specific distance covered by the turnpike. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes when the turnpike was built; it doesn’t emphasize the distance that the turnpike covered.

Question ID: 25a197dd

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Easy

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The human body requires magnesium for over 300 essential processes.
- Magnesium is a mineral present in many foods.
- Peanuts contain 49 milligrams per ounce (mg/oz) of magnesium.
- Almonds contain 80 mg/oz.
- Chia seeds contain 150 mg/oz.

The student wants to identify which of the three foods has the highest magnesium content. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. At 80 mg/oz, almonds contain more magnesium than peanuts (49 mg/oz).
- B. Chia seeds contain 150 mg/oz of magnesium, which is more than peanuts and almonds.
- C. Magnesium is present in many foods, including peanuts, almonds, and chia seeds.
- D. Peanuts contain 49 mg/oz of magnesium, a mineral the human body requires for over 300 essential processes.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The sentence identifies chia seeds as having the highest magnesium content of the three foods, noting that they contain 150 mg/oz, which is more than both peanuts and almonds.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence compares the magnesium content of almonds and peanuts; it doesn't identify which of the three foods has the highest magnesium content. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence merely mentions the three foods; it doesn't identify which one has the highest magnesium content. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence identifies the magnesium content of peanuts; it doesn't identify which of the three foods has the highest magnesium content.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Hard

Question

In a heated debate in biogeography, the field is divided between dispersalists and vicariancists. _____ there are those who argue that dispersal is the most crucial determining factor in a species’ distribution, and those who insist that vicariance (separation due to geographic barriers) is. Biogeographer Isabel Sanmartín counts herself among neither.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. Furthermore,
- B. By contrast,
- C. Similarly,
- D. That is,

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. “That is” logically signals that the information in this sentence, which explains the difference between the dispersalists’ position and the vicariancists’ position, clarifies the terms of the debate between dispersalists and vicariancists introduced in the previous sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because “furthermore” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is merely additional to (and separate from) the information in the previous sentence about the debate between dispersalists and vicariancists. Instead, the sentence clarifies the terms of the debate, explaining the difference between the dispersalists’ position and the vicariancists’ position. Choice B is incorrect because “by contrast” illogically signals that the information in this sentence contrasts with the information in the previous sentence. Instead, the sentence clarifies the terms of the debate between dispersalists and vicariancists introduced in the previous sentence. Choice C is incorrect because “similarly” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is merely similar to (and separate from) the information in the previous sentence about the debate between dispersalists and vicariancists. Instead, the sentence clarifies the terms of the debate, explaining the difference between the dispersalists’ position and the vicariancists’ position.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Medium

Question

Scientists were able to isolate a relatively pure sample of selenium in 1817, the same year they first discovered the element’s existence. _____ the isolation process took longer for molybdenum, which was isolated in its pure form three years after scientists first discovered it.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. By contrast,
- B. Thus,
- C. Similarly,
- D. For instance,

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. "By contrast" logically signals that the information in this sentence—that isolating molybdenum was a relatively long process—contrasts with the previous information that isolating selenium was a short process.

Choice B is incorrect because "thus" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is a result of the previous information about selenium’s short isolation process. Instead, the sentence presents contrasting information about molybdenum’s longer isolation process. Choice C is incorrect because "similarly" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is similar to the previous information about selenium’s short isolation process. Instead, the sentence presents contrasting information about molybdenum’s longer isolation process. Choice D is incorrect because "for instance" illogically signals that the information in this sentence exemplifies the previous information about selenium’s short isolation process. Instead, the sentence presents contrasting information about molybdenum’s longer isolation process.

Question ID: a40c7aa3

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Medium

Question

Most of the planets that have been discovered outside our solar system orbit G-type stars, like our Sun. In 2014, _____ researchers identified a planet orbiting KELT-9, a B-type star more than twice as massive and nearly twice as hot as the Sun. Called KELT-9b, it is one of the hottest planets ever discovered.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. likewise,
- B. however,
- C. therefore,
- D. for example,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The word “however” logically signals that the information in this sentence about the planet KELT-9b—that it orbits a B-type star—contrasts with the previous information about planets discovered outside our solar system. Most of these planets orbit G-type stars, not B-type stars.

Choice A is incorrect because “likewise” illogically signals that the information about the planet KELT-9b is similar to the previous information about most planets outside our solar system. Instead, it contrasts with that information. Choice C is incorrect because “therefore” illogically signals that the information about the planet KELT-9b is a result of the previous information about most planets outside our solar system. Instead, it contrasts with that information. Choice D is incorrect because “for example” illogically signals that the information about the planet KELT-9b is an example of the previous information about most planets outside our solar system. Instead, it contrasts with that information.

Question ID: e3bbf2bf

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Easy

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In World War I, US soldiers who were members of the Choctaw Nation in Oklahoma participated in the Choctaw Code Talkers program.
- The Choctaw Code Talkers were trained to relay coded military information in their native language.
- In World War II, the US Army recruited Navajo (Diné) soldiers to transmit coded messages in their native language.
- These soldiers were known as the Navajo Code Talkers.

The student wants to emphasize a similarity between the Choctaw Code Talkers and the Navajo Code Talkers. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. US soldiers who were members of the Choctaw Nation in Oklahoma used their native language to relay coded information.
- B. In World War II, one group of Navajo (Diné) soldiers was known as the Navajo Code Talkers.
- C. Both the Choctaw Code Talkers and the Navajo Code Talkers transmitted coded military messages in the soldiers’ native languages.
 - The Choctaw Code Talkers, not the Navajo Code Talkers, served in World War I.

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes a similarity between the Choctaw Code Talkers and the Navajo Code Talkers by explaining that both groups used their native languages to transmit coded messages for the military.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence describes the Choctaw Code Talkers; it doesn’t emphasize a similarity between the Choctaw Code Talkers and the Navajo Code Talkers. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence introduces the Navajo Code Talkers; it doesn’t emphasize a similarity between the Choctaw Code Talkers and the Navajo Code Talkers. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes a difference between the Choctaw Code Talkers and the Navajo Code Talkers; it doesn’t emphasize a similarity.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Easy

Question

In 1815, while in exile in Jamaica, Venezuelan revolutionary Simón Bolívar penned a letter praising England’s republican government and expressing hope that Latin American nations seeking independence from Spain might achieve something similar. The letter was addressed to a local merchant, Henry Cullen; _____ though, Bolívar’s goal was to persuade political leaders from England and Europe to support his cause.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. additionally,
- B. ultimately,
- C. accordingly,
- D. consequently,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “Ultimately” means “in the long run” or “at the highest level.” Although Bolívar wrote to a local merchant, his ultimate goal was to send a message to political leaders in Europe. Therefore, “ultimately” fits perfectly in this context.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice uses a transition that indicates the addition of an agreeing idea. However, the second part of the sentence actually disagrees with the first part. Bolívar addressed the letter to Cullen, but he was really sending a message to someone else. Notice how the contrast word “though” also acts as a transition between these ideas. Choice C is incorrect. This choice uses a cause-and-effect transition. Bolívar’s writing of the letter to Cullen would not cause him to have a goal of persuading European powers to support him. Choice D is incorrect. This choice uses a cause-and-effect transition. Bolívar’s writing of the letter to Cullen would not cause him to have a goal of persuading European powers to support him.

Question ID: 8a1ad52b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Medium

Question

A research team led by Gal Badihi has discovered that chimpanzees communicate through exchanges of gestures occurring at a pace similar to that of human conversations. _____ chimpanzee gesture exchanges have short pauses of about 120 milliseconds between communications, comparable to the 200-millisecond average pause between turns in human speech.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. As a result,
- B. Specifically,
- C. By contrast,
- D. Nevertheless,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “Specifically” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that pauses between chimpanzee gestures average about 120 milliseconds, comparable to the 200-millisecond average pause in human speech—provides specific, precise details elaborating on the previous sentence’s claim about the pace of chimpanzee communication being similar to that of human conversations.

Choice A is incorrect because “as a result” illogically signals that this sentence presents a result or consequence of the claim about chimpanzee communication described in the previous sentence. Instead, the sentence provides specific details elaborating on that claim. Choice C is incorrect because “by contrast” illogically signals that the information about chimpanzee gesture exchanges in this sentence contrasts with the previous sentence’s claim about the pace of chimpanzee communication being similar to that of human conversations. Instead, the sentence provides specific details elaborating on that claim. Choice D is incorrect because “nevertheless” illogically signals that the information about chimpanzee gesture exchanges in this sentence is true despite the previous claim about the pace of chimpanzee communication. Instead, the sentence provides specific details elaborating on that claim.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Medium

Question

The Babylonian king Hammurabi achieved much during his forty-year reign. He conquered all of Mesopotamia and built Babylon into one of the most powerful cities of the ancient world. Today, _____ he is mainly remembered for a code of laws inscribed on a seven-foot-tall block of stone: the Code of Hammurabi.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. therefore,
- B. likewise,
- C. however,
- D. for instance,

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. “However” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that Hammurabi is mainly remembered for just a single achievement, the Code of Hammurabi—is contrary to what might be assumed from the previous information about Hammurabi’s many achievements.

Choice A is incorrect because “therefore” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is a result of the previous information about Hammurabi’s many achievements. Instead, this sentence makes a point that is contrary to what might be assumed from the previous information. Choice B is incorrect because “likewise” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is similar to the previous information about Hammurabi’s many achievements. Instead, this sentence makes a point that is contrary to what might be assumed from the previous information. Choice D is incorrect because “for instance” illogically signals that this sentence exemplifies the previous information about Hammurabi’s many achievements. Instead, this sentence makes a point that is contrary to what might be assumed from the previous information.

Question ID: 4c43bf61

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Medium

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The International Center for the Arts of the Americas (ICAA) is directed by Mari Carmen Ramírez.
- Ramírez oversaw an initiative to create an online archive of historical documents related to the history of Latin American and Latino visual art.
- The ICAA digitized over 10,000 documents, including the writings of Latin American and Latino artists and critics.
- The creation of the archive didn't require historical documents to be removed from their countries of origin.
- Scholars now have more access to these documents.

The student wants to explain an advantage of the ICAA's archive being digital. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. Over 10,000 documents related to the history of Latin American and Latino visual art are part of the ICAA archive.
- B. By offering online versions of historical documents, the ICAA's archive provides more access to these materials without removing them from their countries of origin.
- C. Among the historical documents in the ICAA's archive are the writings of Latin American and Latino artists and critics.
- D. The ICAA's director, Mari Carmen Ramírez, oversaw the creation of an online archive of historical documents related to Latin American and Latino visual art.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The sentence explains an advantage of the ICAA's archive being digital, noting that the archive provides more access to historical documents since they don't have to be removed from their countries of origin.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes the number of documents in the ICAA archive; it doesn't explain an advantage of the archive being digital. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence notes the types of historical documents the ICAA's archive contains; it doesn't explain an advantage of the archive being digital. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence identifies who oversaw the creation of the ICAA's online archive; it doesn't explain an advantage of the archive being digital.

Question ID: 16631d34

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Medium

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The Million Song Dataset (MSD) includes main audio features and descriptive tags for popular songs.
- Audio features include acoustic traits such as loudness and pitch intervals.
- Many algorithms use these audio features to predict a new song’s popularity.
- These algorithms may fail to accurately identify main audio features of a song with varying acoustic traits.
- Algorithms based on descriptive tags that describe fixed traits such as genre are more reliable predictors of song popularity.

The student wants to explain a disadvantage of relying on audio features to predict a song’s popularity. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. Many popularity-predicting algorithms are based on a song’s audio features, such as loudness and pitch intervals.
- B. Algorithms based on audio features may misidentify the main features of a song with varying acoustic traits, making such algorithms less reliable predictors of popularity than those based on fixed traits.
- C. Audio features describe acoustic traits such as pitch intervals, which may vary within a song, whereas descriptive tags describe fixed traits such as genre, which are reliable predictors of popularity.
- D. The MSD’s descriptive tags are reliable predictors of a song’s popularity, as the traits they describe are fixed.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. This choice uses relevant information from the notes to explain a disadvantage of relying on audio features to predict a song’s popularity—namely, that it may misidentify features of certain songs. It also contrasts audio features with descriptive tags, which are more reliable predictors.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice only states a fact about the algorithms without evaluating their reliability or accuracy. Choice C is incorrect. This choice only describes the difference between audio features and descriptive tags without indicating why this difference matters for predicting popularity. Choice D is incorrect. This choice only mentions descriptive tags, which are not the focus of the student’s rhetorical goal.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Medium

Question

The Inca of South America used intricately knotted string devices called quipus to record countable information, like population data and payments. _____ they may have used quipus to record more complex information, like stories and myths, according to researchers.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. As a result,
- B. In other words,
- C. In addition,
- D. For example,

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. "In addition" logically signals that the claim in this sentence—that the Inca of South America may have used quipus to record more complex information—is an additional point related to the previous statement about the Inca using quipus to record countable information.

Choice A is incorrect because "as a result" illogically signals that the claim in the sentence is a consequence or result of the previous statement about the Inca using quipus to record countable information. Instead, the possibility that the Inca used quipus to record more complex information is an additional point about how the quipus were used. Choice B is incorrect because "in other words" illogically signals that the claim in the sentence is merely a paraphrase or restatement of the previous statement about the Inca using quipus to record countable information. Instead, the possibility that the Inca used quipus to record more complex information is an additional point about how the quipus were used. Choice D is incorrect because "for example" illogically signals that the claim in the sentence exemplifies the previous statement about the Inca using quipus to record countable information. Instead, the possibility that the Inca used quipus to record more complex information is an additional point about how the quipus were used.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Easy

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- *Oracles of the Pink Universe* was a 2021 exhibition at the Denver Museum of Art in Colorado.
- It featured eight artworks by South African artist Simphiwe Ndzube.
- One of these works is a painting titled *Assertion of Will*.
- *Assertion of Will* depicts three standing figures.
- The figures wear clothing made of fabric pieces stitched to the painting’s canvas.

The student wants to describe how fabric is used in *Assertion of Will*. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. In *Assertion of Will*, the figures’ clothing is made of fabric pieces stitched to the painting’s canvas.
- B. The exhibition *Oracles of the Pink Universe* featured artworks by artist Simphiwe Ndzube.
- C. Depicting three standing, clothed figures, *Assertion of Will* is a painting by Simphiwe Ndzube.
- D. Simphiwe Ndzube’s *Assertion of Will* was one of eight artworks exhibited in *Oracles of the Pink Universe* at the Denver Museum of Art.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. This choice directly describes how fabric is used in *Assertion of Will*, by explaining that the fabric pieces are part of the painting itself.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice provides contextual information about the exhibition, but it doesn’t mention anything about the painting or the fabric. Choice C is incorrect. This choice mentions that the figures are clothed, but it doesn’t explain how the fabric is integrated into the painting. Choice D is incorrect. This choice provides contextual information about the painting, but it doesn’t mention anything about the fabric or how it is used.

Question ID: 601b9d18

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Medium

Question

Some members of the US Supreme Court have resisted calls to televise the court’s oral arguments, concerned that the participants would be tempted to perform for the cameras (and thus lower the quality of the discourse). _____ the justices worry that most viewers would not even watch the full deliberations, only short clips that could be misinterpreted and mischaracterized.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. However,
- B. Additionally,
- C. In comparison,
- D. For example,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “Additionally” logically signals that the claim in this sentence—that some Supreme Court justices worry that viewers (of televised court arguments) would watch only short, misleading clips—adds to the information in the previous sentence. Specifically, the previous sentence indicates one concern raised by those opposed to televising the court’s oral arguments, and the claim that follows indicates a second, additional concern.

Choice A is incorrect because “however” illogically signals that the claim in this sentence contrasts with the information in the previous sentence. Instead, the claim adds to the information, indicating a second, additional concern that some Supreme Court justices have about televising the court’s arguments. Choice C is incorrect because “in comparison” illogically signals that the claim in this sentence is being compared to the information in the previous sentence. Instead, the claim adds to the information, indicating a second, additional concern that some Supreme Court justices have about televising the court’s arguments. Choice D is incorrect because “for example” illogically signals that the claim in this sentence exemplifies the information in the previous sentence. Instead, the claim adds to the information, indicating a second, additional concern that some Supreme Court justices have about televising the court’s arguments.

Question ID: 60917233

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Medium

Question

In the 1880s, inventor Lewis Latimer improved upon Thomas Edison’s design for the electric light bulb. _____ Latimer made the light bulb more durable by placing cardboard around its carbon filament. With this innovation, Latimer became the first Black inventor to contribute to the electrification of the world.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. Soon,
- B. Regardless,
- C. However,
- D. Specifically,

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. "Specifically" logically signals that the information in this sentence—Latimer making the light bulb more durable—provides a specific detail elaborating on the more general claim in the previous sentence that Latimer improved the light bulb.

Choice A is incorrect because "soon" illogically signals that the information in this sentence occurred shortly after Latimer improved the light bulb. Instead, Latimer making the bulb more durable was the specific improvement. Choice B is incorrect because "regardless" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is true despite the previous claim about Latimer. Instead, the information about Latimer making the bulb more durable provides a specific detail elaborating on that claim. Choice C is incorrect because "however" illogically signals that the information in this sentence contrasts with the previous claim about Latimer. Instead, the information about Latimer making the bulb more durable provides a specific detail elaborating on that claim.

Question ID: 1d79a59d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Hard

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Leaders of the Province of Guatemala proclaimed independence for Central America from the Spanish Empire on September 15, 1821.
- The accompanying Declaration of Independence was written by Honduran scholar and politician José Cecilio del Valle.
- The 1812 Spanish Constitution had provided some degree of independence for Central America, but it was repealed by the Spanish king in 1814.
- Valle, a loyal advisor to the Spanish Empire’s administrators in Central America, had long opposed independence.
- He changed his mind after Colonel Rafael del Riego’s 1820 revolt, which demanded the return of rights lost in 1814.

The student wants to place the 1821 Declaration of Independence in the context of Valle’s changing political beliefs. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. Colonel Riego’s revolt was the inspiration that Valle, a long-standing opponent of Central American independence, needed to change his political beliefs.
- B. Long an opponent of Central American independence, Valle changed his mind after an 1820 revolt and wrote the 1821 declaration.
- C. A change in Valle’s political beliefs that occurred when the Spanish king repealed the 1812 constitution led to Valle writing Central America’s Declaration of Independence.
- D. The writing of Central America’s Declaration of Independence may not have happened were it not for Colonel Riego’s 1820 revolt.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The sentence places the Declaration of Independence in the context of Valle’s changing political beliefs, noting that Valle was long an opponent of Central American independence but changed his mind after an 1820 revolt and then wrote the Declaration of Independence in 1821.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence states that Valle’s political beliefs changed after Riego’s revolt but doesn’t indicate how these changed beliefs provide context for the 1821 Declaration of Independence. Choice C is incorrect because it misrepresents information from the notes. Valle’s political beliefs changed after Riego’s 1820 revolt, not when the Spanish king repealed the 1812 constitution. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence indicates a relationship between Colonel Riego’s 1820 revolt and Central America’s Declaration of Independence, it doesn’t mention Valle’s changing political beliefs.

Question ID: ec3d7605

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Medium

Question

Award-winning travel writer Linda Watanabe McFerrin considers the background research she conducts on destinations featured in her travel books to be its own reward. _____ McFerrin admits to finding the research phase of her work just as fascinating and engaging as exploring a location in person.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. By contrast,
- B. Likewise,
- C. Besides,
- D. In fact,

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. “In fact” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that McFerrin finds the research phase of her work to be just as fascinating as travel—emphasizes and elaborates on the previous sentence’s point that McFerrin regards background research as a rewarding activity.

Choice A is incorrect because “by contrast” illogically signals that the information in this sentence contrasts with the previous sentence’s point about McFerrin’s attitude toward background research. Instead, it emphasizes and elaborates on that point. Choice B is incorrect because “likewise” illogically signals that this sentence merely adds a second, similar point to the previous sentence’s point about McFerrin’s attitude toward background research. Instead, it emphasizes and elaborates on that point. Choice C is incorrect because “besides” illogically signals that this sentence provides a separate point in addition to, or apart from, the previous sentence’s point about McFerrin’s attitude toward background research. Instead, it emphasizes and elaborates on that point.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Easy

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The mountain pygmy possum is a mammal species.
- Up until 1966, it was believed to be extinct.
- That year, a live mountain pygmy possum was identified in the wild in Australia.
- The mountain pygmy possum is considered a Lazarus species.
- “Lazarus species” is a term for living species of organisms that were once believed to be extinct.

The student wants to define the term “Lazarus species” and provide an example of one. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish these goals?

Answer

- A. The term “Lazarus species” describes a living species of organism, such as the mountain pygmy possum, that was once believed to be extinct.
- B. One example of a Lazarus species is the mountain pygmy possum, a mammal species that was identified in the wild in Australia in 1966.
- C. The mountain pygmy possum, a species of mammal, was identified in the wild in 1966.
- D. Sometimes, a species once believed to be extinct is later found living in the wild.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The sentence defines the term "Lazarus species" and provides an example of one, explaining that a Lazarus species is a living organism that was once believed to be extinct and providing the mountain pygmy possum as an example.

Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence provides an example of a Lazarus species, it doesn't define the term "Lazarus species." Choice C is incorrect. The sentence provides information about the mountain pygmy possum; it doesn't define the term "Lazarus species" or explicitly identify the mountain pygmy possum as a Lazarus species. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence describes the concept of a Lazarus species, it doesn't define the term or provide an example of a Lazarus species.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Medium

Question

In 1873, Spanish scientist Santiago Ramón y Cajal observed that brain fibers have distinct boundaries with clear end points, a finding that went against earlier assumptions about the brain. _____ scientists had assumed that the brain was a continuous web of fused fibers, not a vast network of distinct, individual cells.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. However,
- B. Previously,
- C. As a result,
- D. Likewise,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “Previously” logically signals that the fused fiber theory came before Ramón y Cajal’s discovery.

Choice A is incorrect. “However” illogically signals that the fused fiber theory in this sentence contrasts with the information in the previous sentence. While this theory does contrast with Ramón y Cajal’s discovery, the previous sentence concludes by stating that his discovery went against prior assumptions about the brain. The fact that the fused fiber theory was one of those earlier assumptions makes “however” an illogical choice. Choice C is incorrect because “as a result” illogically signals that the fused fiber theory in this sentence was a result of the discovery in the previous sentence. Instead, the fused fiber theory came before Ramón y Cajal’s discovery. Choice D is incorrect because “likewise” illogically signals that the fused fiber theory in this sentence was similar to the discovery in the previous sentence. Instead, the fused fiber theory, which came before Ramón y Cajal’s discovery, was very different from it.

Question ID: 84e108cf

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Medium

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Platinum is a rare and expensive metal.
- It is used as a catalyst for chemical reactions.
- Platinum catalysts typically require a large amount of platinum to be effective.
- Researcher Jianbo Tang and his colleagues created a platinum catalyst that combines platinum with liquid gallium.
- Their catalyst was highly effective and required only trace amounts of platinum (0.0001% of the atoms in the mixture).

The student wants to explain an advantage of the new platinum catalyst developed by Jianbo Tang and his colleagues. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. Researcher Jianbo Tang and his colleagues created a platinum catalyst that combines platinum, a rare and expensive metal, with liquid gallium.
- B. Like other platinum catalysts, the new platinum catalyst requires a particular amount of the metal to be effective.
- C. Platinum is a rare and expensive metal that is used as a catalyst for chemical reactions; however, platinum catalysts typically require a large amount of platinum to be effective.
- D. While still highly effective, the new platinum catalyst requires far less of the rare and expensive metal than do other platinum catalysts.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence explains an advantage of Tang and his colleagues’ platinum catalyst, noting that it requires far less platinum (which is rare and expensive) than other platinum catalysts do.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence describes the platinum catalyst that Tang and his colleagues created; it doesn’t explain an advantage of their platinum catalyst. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes a similarity between the new platinum catalyst and other platinum catalysts; it doesn’t explain an advantage of the new platinum catalyst. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence connects the metal platinum to the functioning of platinum catalysts, noting that large amounts of platinum are typically required for platinum catalysts to be effective; it doesn’t explain an advantage of Tang and his colleagues’ platinum catalyst.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Hard

Question

In hindsight, given the ideas about the natural world circulating among British scientists in the 1800s, the theory of natural selection was an obvious next step. It may not have been a coincidence, _____ that Charles Darwin and Alfred Wallace arrived at the concept independently. Indeed, contrary to the popular myth of the lone genius, theirs is not the first paradigm-shifting theory to have emerged from multiple scholars working in parallel.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. however,
- B. then,
- C. moreover,
- D. for example,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. "Then" signals that this sentence's claim about Darwin and Wallace follows logically from the previous information. In other words, both scientists independently arriving at the theory of natural selection was, arguably, an expected outcome of the circumstances mentioned in the previous sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because "however" illogically signals that the claim in this sentence contrasts with the previous information about the ideas circulating among British scientists in the 1800s. Instead, this claim follows logically from that information. Choice C is incorrect because "moreover" illogically signals that the claim in this sentence merely adds to the previous information about the ideas circulating among British scientists in the 1800s. Instead, this claim follows logically from that information. Choice D is incorrect because "for example" illogically signals that this sentence provides an example supporting the previous information about the ideas circulating among British scientists in the 1800s. Instead, it presents a claim that follows logically from that information.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Medium

Question

For years, biologists have experimented with using grime-eating bacteria rather than harsh chemicals to clean artworks, and results have been impressive overall. _____ these bacterial strains—which can metabolize centuries' worth of oil, glue, dirt, and other surface impurities without creating harmful byproducts—have proven more effective than traditional chemical cleaning methods.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. However,
- B. In many cases,
- C. As a result,
- D. Additionally,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “In many cases” logically links the information that follows to the previous sentence’s claim that the results of bacterial cleaning “have been impressive overall.” This sentence supports that claim by indicating that the bacteria “have proven more effective than traditional chemical cleaning methods.” Noting that this is true “in many cases” appropriately frames the information in the sentence and thus completes the text with the most logical transition.

Choice A is incorrect because “however” illogically signals that the information in this sentence contrasts with the previous information. Instead, this sentence supports the previous sentence’s claim that the results of bacterial cleaning “have been impressive overall,” noting that the bacteria “have proven more effective than traditional chemical cleaning methods.” Choice C is incorrect because “as a result” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is a consequence of the claim about the results of bacterial cleaning. Instead, this sentence supports the previous sentence’s claim that the results of bacterial cleaning “have been impressive overall,” noting that the bacteria “have proven more effective than traditional chemical cleaning methods.” Choice D is incorrect because “additionally” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is merely additional to (and separate from) the previous information about the results of bacterial cleaning. Instead, this sentence supports the previous sentence’s claim that the results of bacterial cleaning “have been impressive overall,” noting that the bacteria “have proven more effective than traditional chemical cleaning methods.”

Question ID: c78620ba

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Easy

Question

In 1968, US Congressman John Conyers introduced a bill to establish a national holiday in honor of Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. The bill didn’t make it to a vote, but Conyers was determined. He teamed up with Shirley Chisholm, the first Black woman to be elected to Congress, and they resubmitted the bill every session for the next fifteen years. _____ in 1983, the bill passed.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. Instead,
- B. Likewise,
- C. Finally,
- D. Additionally,

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. “Finally” logically signals that the bill passing—following many attempts between 1968 and 1983—is the final, concluding event in the sequence described in the previous sentences.

Choice A is incorrect because “instead” illogically signals that the bill passing is an alternative to one of the events described in the previous sentences. Instead, it is the final event in the sequence. Choice B is incorrect because “likewise” illogically signals that the bill passing is similar to one of the events described in the previous sentences. Instead, it is the final event in the sequence. Choice D is incorrect because “additionally” illogically signals that the bill passing is merely another event described along with the events of the previous sentences. Instead, it is the final, concluding event in the sequence.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Easy

Question

It has long been thought that humans first crossed a land bridge into the Americas approximately 13,000 years ago. _____ based on radiocarbon dating of samples uncovered in Mexico, a research team recently suggested that humans may have arrived more than 30,000 years ago—much earlier than previously thought.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. As a result,
- B. Similarly,
- C. However,
- D. In conclusion,

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. “However” logically signals that the theory discussed in this sentence—that humans may have arrived in the Americas over 30,000 years ago—contrasts with the previously discussed theory that humans arrived around 13,000 years ago.

Choice A is incorrect because “as a result” illogically signals that the theory in this sentence is the result of the theory discussed in the previous sentence. Instead, this theory contrasts with the previous one. Choice B is incorrect because “similarly” illogically signals that the theory in this sentence is similar to the theory discussed in the previous sentence. Instead, this theory contrasts with the previous one. Choice D is incorrect because “in conclusion” illogically signals that the theory in this sentence concludes or summarizes the discussion of the previous theory. Instead, this theory contrasts with the previous one.

Question ID: 94c9788e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Medium

Question

Brain imaging research led by neuroscientist Dwaynica Greaves found that actors showed suppressed responses in the left anterior prefrontal cortex (the portion of the brain associated with self-awareness) when their names were called during performances; _____ the actors’ responses were normal in nonacting contexts. These findings suggest that when embodying characters, performers may temporarily set aside their personal identities.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- Answer**
- A. specifically,
 - B. conversely,
 - C. likewise,
 - D. thus,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “Conversely” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that the actors’ responses were normal in nonacting contexts—presents the opposite of the previous finding that actors showed suppressed responses when their names were called during performances.

Choice A is incorrect because “specifically” illogically signals that the information about the actors’ normal responses in nonacting contexts provides specific details elaborating on the previous finding of suppressed responses during performances. Instead, the sentence presents the responses as opposites. Choice C is incorrect because “likewise” illogically signals that the actors’ normal responses in nonacting contexts are similar to the suppressed responses observed during performances. Instead, the sentence presents the responses as opposites. Choice D is incorrect because “thus” illogically signals that the actors’ normal responses in nonacting contexts are a result or consequence of the suppressed responses observed during performances. Instead, the sentence presents the responses as opposites.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Easy

Question

In 1845, the United States District Court for the state of Iowa was established. Initially, the court’s jurisdiction was a single district that encompassed the entire state, but as Iowa’s population grew, this single district began to struggle to serve the needs of everyone in the state. _____ the court’s jurisdiction was subdivided into two districts, each with its own district court.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. Nevertheless,
- B. Ultimately,
- C. Additionally,
- D. For example,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “Ultimately” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that the court’s jurisdiction was subdivided into two districts—was the eventual outcome or resolution of the previously described struggle of the single district to serve the needs of everyone in the state.

Choice A is incorrect because “nevertheless” illogically signals that the information in the sentence is true despite the single district’s struggle to serve the state’s needs. Instead, the sentence describes the eventual resolution of that struggle. Choice C is incorrect because “additionally” illogically signals that the information in the sentence is merely an additional fact related to the single district’s struggle. Instead, the sentence describes the eventual resolution of that struggle. Choice D is incorrect because “for example” illogically signals that the information in the sentence provides a specific example of the single district’s struggle to serve the state’s needs. Instead, the sentence describes the eventual resolution of that struggle.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Easy

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Muslins are woven cotton fabrics with a variety of uses.
- Dhaka muslin is a handmade fabric produced in Dhaka, Bangladesh.
- It has an extremely fine weave and is primarily used to make luxury clothing.
- Sheeting muslin is a machine-made fabric produced in factories.
- It has a coarse weave and is primarily used to upholster furniture and create backdrops for theater sets.

The student wants to emphasize a difference between the two muslins. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. Dhaka muslin is a handmade fabric with an extremely fine weave, while sheeting muslin is machine made with a coarse weave.
- B. Dhaka muslin and sheeting muslin are two different types of woven cotton fabrics.
- C. Muslins can be used in a variety of ways, from making luxury clothing to upholstering furniture and creating backdrops for theater sets.
- D. Sheeting muslin is machine made, has a coarse weave, and is used for furniture and theater sets.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The difference between the two different kinds of muslin is emphasized.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice lists two kinds of muslins, but does not say how they are different from one another. Choice C is incorrect. This choice does not emphasize a difference between the two muslins. Choice D is incorrect. This choice does not emphasize a difference between the two muslins. It only describes sheeting muslin.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Medium

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Grimanesa Amoros is a Peruvian American artist well known for her LED light sculptures.
- Her sculpture *Uros Island* is made of smooth multicolored LED domes.
- It occupies 335 cubic feet of space.
- Her sculpture *Fortuna* is made of entangled blue and white LED tubes.
- It occupies 19,950 cubic feet of space.

The student wants to emphasize a similarity between *Uros Island* and *Fortuna*. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. The smooth LED domes of Grimanesa Amoros’s *Uros Island* stand in contrast to the tangled LED tubes of *Fortuna*.
- B. At 19,950 cubic feet in size, Grimanesa Amoros’s *Fortuna* cuts a larger figure than the 335-cubic-foot *Uros Island*.
- C. Grimanesa Amoros is the artist behind *Uros Island*—a sculpture made of smooth multicolored LED domes.
- D. *Uros Island* is an LED light sculpture made by Grimanesa Amoros, as is *Fortuna*.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes a similarity between the sculptures, noting that both *Uros Island* and *Fortuna* are LED light sculptures created by Grimanesa Amoros.

Choice A is incorrect. Noting that *Uros Island*’s smooth LED domes contrast with *Fortuna*’s tangled LED tubes, the sentence emphasizes a difference between the two sculptures rather than a similarity. Choice B is incorrect. Contrasting the respective sizes of *Uros Island* and *Fortuna*, the sentence emphasizes a difference between the two sculptures rather than a similarity. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence describes *Uros Island*, it doesn’t mention *Fortuna* or emphasize any similarity between the two sculptures.

Question ID: 441f0505

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Medium

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- A lever is a simple machine consisting of a rigid beam and a fulcrum.
- The fulcrum is the point about which the beam pivots.
- The input force (effort) is the force applied to the lever.
- The output force (load) is the force that the lever exerts on another object.
- In first-class levers, the fulcrum is located between the effort and the load.
- In second-class levers, the load is located between the effort and the fulcrum.

The student wants to contrast first-class levers and second-class levers. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. In levers, the effort is the force applied to the lever; the load, in contrast, is the force that the lever exerts on another object.
- B. In first-class and second-class levers, the fulcrum and the load are in different locations.
- C. First-class levers are simple machines consisting of a rigid beam and a fulcrum, but then again, the same is true of second-class levers.
- D. In first-class levers, the fulcrum is located between the effort and the load, but in second-class levers, the load is located between the effort and the fulcrum.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence contrasts first-class levers and second-class levers, explaining that the fulcrum in a first-class lever is between the effort and the load, whereas in a second-class lever the load is between the effort and the fulcrum.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence defines two terms associated with levers; it doesn't contrast first-class levers and second-class levers. Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence seems to acknowledge a general difference in fulcrum and load locations between first-class and second-class levers, it does not specify what this difference is. Moreover, the sentence could be read as emphasizing a similarity—that in both types of levers, the fulcrum and load are in different locations. The sentence thus fails to effectively contrast the two types of levers. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence describes a similarity between first-class and second-class levers; it doesn't contrast them.

Question ID: 6c9df5d1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Medium

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Some powerful works of literature have so influenced readers that new legislation has been passed as a result.
- *The Interesting Narrative of the Life of Olaudah Equiano* (1789) is the autobiography of a man who endured slavery on both sides of the Atlantic.
- Equiano’s book contributed to the passage of the Slave Trade Act of 1807.
- *The Jungle* (1906) is a fictional work by Upton Sinclair that describes unsanitary conditions in US meatpacking plants.
- Sinclair’s book contributed to the passage of the Pure Food and Drug Act in 1906.

The student wants to emphasize a difference between the two books. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. Although both are powerful works of literature that contributed to new legislation, Equiano’s book is an autobiography, while Sinclair’s is fictional.
- B. They may have written about different topics, but Equiano and Sinclair both influenced readers.
- C. The 1807 Slave Trade Act resulted in part from a book by Equiano, while the 1906 Pure Food and Drug Act resulted in part from a book by Sinclair.
- D. *The Interesting Narrative of the Life of Olaudah Equiano* and *The Jungle* are two works of literature that contributed to new legislation (concerning the slave trade and food safety, respectively).

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. This choice emphasizes a difference between the two books by using relevant information from the notes to contrast their genres.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice mentions a difference between the books (their different topics), but it emphasizes a similarity between the books (their influence on readers). Choice C is incorrect. This choice provides information about the books that reflects both a similarity (both resulted in new laws) and a difference (the specific laws that resulted), without emphasizing either. Choice D is incorrect. This choice doesn’t emphasize a difference between the two books. Instead, it *emphasizes a similarity*.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Hard

Question

Long thought to be sessile (immobile), adult *Chelonibia testudinaria*, barnacles that adhere to sea turtle shells, have been observed to shift slightly in position over time—a phenomenon that has been attributed to the barnacles’ passive displacement by water currents. _____ a research team found that adult *C. testudinaria* moved toward the heads of their sea turtle hosts and thus against the prevailing water flow, behavior consistent with self-initiated locomotion.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. Contrary to this phenomenon,
- B. Undermining this explanation,
- C. Drawing a similar conclusion,
- D. Confirming this hypothesis,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “Undermining this explanation” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that adult *Chelonibia testudinaria* showed behavior consistent with self-initiated locomotion—undermines or weakens the previous explanation that barnacle movement was a result of passive displacement by water currents.

Choice A is incorrect because “contrary to this phenomenon” illogically signals that the information in this sentence about barnacles exhibiting behavior consistent with self-initiated locomotion opposes the previous information about barnacles shifting slightly in position over time. Instead, the sentence undermines or weakens the previous claim about passive displacement. That is, the sentence doesn’t oppose the fact that the barnacles shifted position: it challenges the previous sentence’s explanation for the movement. Choice C is incorrect because “drawing a similar conclusion” illogically signals that the information in this sentence about barnacles exhibiting behavior consistent with self-initiated locomotion is similar to the previous conclusion that barnacle movement is the result of passive displacement. Instead, the sentence undermines or weakens the previous sentence’s explanation for how the barnacles moved. Choice D is incorrect because “confirming this hypothesis” illogically signals that the information in this sentence about barnacles exhibiting behavior consistent with self-initiated locomotion confirms the hypothesis in the previous sentence that the barnacle movement was the result of passive displacement. Instead, the sentence undermines or weakens the previous sentence’s explanation for how the barnacles moved.

Question ID: f07570bb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Medium

Question

Researchers believe that pieces of hull found off Oregon’s coast are from a Spanish cargo ship that was lost in 1697. Stories passed down among the area’s Confederated Tribes of Siletz Indians support this belief. _____ Siletz stories describe how blocks of beeswax, an item the ship had been carrying, began washing ashore after the ship was lost.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. For this reason,
- B. For example,
- C. However,
- D. Likewise,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “For example” logically signals that the Siletz beeswax stories mentioned in this sentence are examples consistent with the previous claim that Siletz stories support the shipwreck theory.

Choice A is incorrect because “for this reason” illogically signals that the Siletz stories about the beeswax were caused by the previous claim that Siletz stories support the shipwreck theory. Instead, the beeswax stories are examples consistent with the claim. Choice C is incorrect because “however” illogically signals that the Siletz stories about the beeswax contrast with the previous claim that Siletz stories support the shipwreck theory. Instead, the beeswax stories are examples consistent with the claim. Choice D is incorrect because “likewise” illogically signals that the Siletz stories about the beeswax are similar to the previous claim that Siletz stories support the shipwreck theory. Instead, the beeswax stories are examples consistent with the claim.

Question ID: 4b99b481

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Medium

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Scientists have developed a “freeze-thaw” battery that can retain 92% of its charge after twelve weeks.
- The battery contains molten salt (a type of salt that liquifies when heated and solidifies at room temperature).
- When the salt is in a liquid state, energy flows through the battery.
- When the salt is in a solid state, energy stops flowing and is stored in the battery.
- The stored (frozen) energy can be used by reheating (thawing) the battery.

The student wants to specify how the salt enables energy storage. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. Scientists have developed a freeze-thaw battery that contains molten salt, which liquifies when heated and solidifies at room temperature.
- B. The stored energy in a freeze-thaw battery, which contains molten salt, can be used by reheating the battery.
- C. When the molten salt in a freeze-thaw battery solidifies at room temperature, energy stops flowing and can be stored in the battery.
- D. Molten salt allows a freeze-thaw battery to retain 92% of its charge after twelve weeks.

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence specifies how the salt in a freeze-thaw battery enables energy storage, explaining that energy stops flowing and can be stored when the salt solidifies at room temperature.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence explains some properties of molten salt; it doesn’t specify how that salt enables energy storage. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence indicates how the energy in a freeze-thaw battery can be released; it doesn’t specify how the salt in the battery enables energy storage. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence specifies how much charge the freeze-thaw battery retains when storing energy; it doesn’t specify how the salt in the battery enables energy storage.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Medium

Question

Alexander Lawrence Posey (1873–1908) varied his focus and tone depending on the genre in which he was writing. In his poetry, he used heartfelt language to evoke the beauty and peacefulness of his natural surroundings; in his journalism, _____ he employed humor and satire to comment on political issues affecting his Muskogee Creek community.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. that is,
- B. granted,
- C. similarly,
- D. by contrast,

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. This sentence compares two examples of Posey’s tone: the “heartfelt language” he used in his poetry versus the “humor and satire” he used in his journalism. We know from these descriptions and from the claim in the previous sentence that the two tones are very different from each other. So the transition “by contrast” fits the context perfectly.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice uses a transition that indicates a restatement of the same idea in other words. But the text isn’t restating the first example here. Instead, it’s offering a second, totally different example. Choice B is incorrect. This choice uses a transition that means “admittedly.” But the text isn’t admitting or conceding anything here. Instead, these two examples work together to support the claim made in the first sentence. Choice C is incorrect. This choice uses a transition that indicates the addition of an agreeing idea. But these two examples are intentionally very different from each other, so “similarly” doesn’t make sense here.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Medium

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Musicians around the world have used protest songs to raise awareness about human rights violations.
- US folk singer Aunt Molly Jackson released the protest song “Poor Miner’s Farewell” in 1932.
- It exposed the unlivable wages and dangerous working conditions coal miners faced in Kentucky during the 1920s and 1930s.
- South African singer-songwriter Hugh Masekela released the protest song “Bring Him Back Home” in 1987.
- It called on the South African government to free Nelson Mandela, an anti-apartheid leader who’d been unjustly imprisoned.

The student wants to contrast the song “Poor Miner’s Farewell” with the song “Bring Him Back Home.” Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. The songs “Poor Miner’s Farewell” and “Bring Him Back Home” both raised awareness about human rights violations.
- B. While both are protest songs, “Poor Miner’s Farewell” is about coal miners in Kentucky, whereas “Bring Him Back Home” is about the anti-apartheid leader Nelson Mandela.
- C. Hugh Masekela’s song “Bring Him Back Home,” released in 1987, called on the South African government to free Nelson Mandela.
- D. Released in 1932 by Aunt Molly Jackson, the song “Poor Miner’s Farewell” was a protest against the unlivable wages and dangerous working conditions faced by Kentucky coal miners.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The sentence contrasts the two songs, noting that "Poor Miner’s Farewell" is about coal miners in Kentucky, whereas "Bring Him Back Home" is about Nelson Mandela.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes a similarity between "Poor Miner’s Farewell" and "Bring Him Back Home"; it doesn’t contrast the two songs. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence provides a description of the song "Bring Him Back Home," it doesn’t mention "Poor Miner’s Farewell" or contrast the two songs. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence provides a description of the song "Poor Miner’s Farewell," it doesn’t mention "Bring Him Back Home" or contrast the two songs.

Question ID: 296801d2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Medium

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The Azores is a group of islands about 870 miles off the coast of Portugal.
- Historians have long believed that in the fifteenth century Portuguese mariners were the first humans to populate the Azores.
- A 2015 study coauthored by Sofia Gabriel and Maria da Luz Mathias found that Vikings from Scandinavia may have populated the Azores as early as the ninth century.
- The researchers found a genetic connection between house mice in the Azores and house mice in Scandinavia.
- House mice may have traveled from Scandinavia to the Azores on Viking ships.

The student wants to specify who may have first populated the Azores, according to the 2015 study. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. Historians have long believed that the first humans to populate the Azores, a group of islands about 870 miles off the coast of Portugal, arrived in the fifteenth century.
- B. Portuguese mariners may not have been the first humans to populate the Azores.
- C. In their 2015 study, the researchers found a genetic connection between house mice in the Azores and those in Scandinavia.
- D. According to a 2015 study, the first humans to populate the Azores may have been Vikings from Scandinavia, not mariners from Portugal as previously believed.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. This choice effectively specifies who may have first populated the Azores, according to the 2015 study: the Vikings.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice doesn't effectively specify who may have first populated the Azores, according to the 2015 study. It only mentions the historical belief that the Portuguese were first. The 2015 study drew a different conclusion. Choice B is incorrect. This choice casts doubt on the Portuguese claim but doesn't name the group of people who may have arrived before the Portuguese. Choice C is incorrect. This choice mentions the evidence that the researchers found but not the conclusion they drew from it. It doesn't name the possible group of people who may have arrived before the Portuguese.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Easy

Question

Geoscientists have long considered Hawaii’s Mauna Loa volcano to be Earth’s largest shield volcano by volume, measuring approximately 74,000 cubic kilometers. _____ according to a 2020 study by local geoscientist Michael Garcia, Hawaii’s Pūhāhonu shield volcano is significantly larger, boasting a volume of about 148,000 cubic kilometers.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- Answer**
- A. Secondly,
 - B. Consequently,
 - C. Moreover,
 - D. However,

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. “However” logically signals that this sentence, which indicates that the Pūhāhonu volcano may be larger than the Mauna Loa volcano, offers a contrast to or refutation of the previous assumption that Mauna Loa is the largest shield volcano.

Choice A is incorrect because “secondly” illogically signals that this sentence merely offers an additional or secondary point concerning the previous assumption that Mauna Loa is the largest shield volcano. Instead, the sentence offers a contrast to or refutation of that assumption. Choice B is incorrect because “consequently” illogically signals that this sentence offers a result or consequence of the previous assumption that Mauna Loa is the largest shield volcano. Instead, the sentence offers a contrast to or refutation of that assumption. Choice C is incorrect because “moreover” illogically signals that this sentence merely adds to the previous assumption that Mauna Loa is the largest shield volcano. Instead, the sentence offers a contrast to or refutation of that assumption.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Hard

Question

A turtle shell appears external to the animal, protecting its body like armor. _____ the shell is often incorrectly assumed to be an exoskeleton, a rigid outer casing like that of a crustacean or an insect, when in fact it is an endoskeleton, a part of the turtle’s internal bone structure, more akin to a spine or a pair of ribs.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. That being said,
- B. However,
- C. For instance,
- D. Hence,

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. "Hence" logically signals that the information in this sentence about turtle shells—that people incorrectly assume they are exoskeletons—is a consequence of the shells appearing external to the animal.

Choice A is incorrect because "that being said" illogically signals that this sentence qualifies or contrasts with the previous information about turtle shells appearing external to the animal. Instead, it presents a consequence of that information. Choice B is incorrect because "however" illogically signals that this sentence contrasts with the previous information about turtle shells appearing external to the animal. Instead, it presents a consequence of that information. Choice C is incorrect because "for instance" illogically signals that this sentence provides an example supporting the previous information about turtle shells appearing external to the animal. Instead, it presents a consequence of that information.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	Easy

Question

Okot p’Bitek’s poem *Song of Lawino* (1966) explores postcolonial Ugandan life through the eyes of a woman living in a rural village. With its vibrant imagery, biting satiric tone, and dexterous use of traditional Acholi song and phraseology, the poem inspired a generation of East African writers. _____ those who adopted its style are often referred to as Okot School poets.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

Answer

- A. Nevertheless,
- B. Fittingly,
- C. By comparison,
- D. Instead,

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “Fittingly” is a transition that means “appropriately” or “suitably,” and it is appropriate that writers who adopted their style from Okot p’Bitek would be known as the Okot School poets.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice uses a disagreement transition. But this sentence is not disagreeing with anything—rather, it’s discussing how it makes sense for those writers who adopted Okot’s style to be known as the Okot School poets. Choice C is incorrect. This choice uses a transition that compares two ideas. But this sentence is not comparing the Okot School poets and their style to Okot’s style. Choice D is incorrect. This choice uses a disagreement transition. But this sentence is not disagreeing with anything—rather, it’s discussing how it makes sense for those writers who adopted Okot’s style to be known as the Okot School poets.

Question ID: 7d5c32e6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Hard

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The fifth Solvay Conference on Physics was held in 1927.
- It brought together twenty-nine of the era’s preeminent scientists to discuss the emerging field of quantum theory.
- The conference famously featured a debate between physicists Albert Einstein and Niels Bohr.
- Bohr proposed that subatomic entities like electrons had only probable realities until they were observed.
- Einstein argued that subatomic entities like electrons had a reality independent of observation.
- Bohr’s position, later called the Copenhagen interpretation, remains the most widely accepted theory of quantum mechanics.

The student wants to place Einstein’s argument within its historical context. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. During the dawn of quantum theory, Einstein maintained the independent reality of some subatomic entities, although Bohr’s opposing interpretation would become the widely accepted view.
- B. At the 1927 Solvay Conference on Physics, Einstein disagreed with Bohr’s argument that subatomic entities like electrons had a reality independent of observation.
- C. The attendees of the 1927 Solvay Conference were among the preeminent scientists of their era, including Einstein, who opposed Bohr’s proposal.
- D. In 1927, Einstein and Bohr engaged in a famous debate; Bohr’s argument, later called the Copenhagen interpretation, would remain popular decades after.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The sentence places Einstein’s argument within the historical context of the development of quantum theory, noting that his argument—made during the dawn of the field—conflicted with Bohr’s argument, which became the widely accepted view.

Choice B is incorrect. The sentence misrepresents information from the notes, attributing the argument that electrons had a reality independent of observation to Bohr, not Einstein. In addition, while the sentence provides the date of the conference, it doesn’t place Einstein’s argument in the context of the development of quantum theory. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence indicates that Einstein attended the 1927 Solvay Conference; it doesn’t identify Einstein’s argument or place it in the historical context of the development of quantum theory. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence explains that Einstein and Bohr had a famous debate in 1927 and that Bohr’s argument remained popular decades afterward; it doesn’t identify Einstein’s argument or place it in the context of the development of quantum theory.